THE ECONOMIC TIMES

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VOL. 42 NO. 259 | BENGALURU | 20 PAGES | ₹4.00 ONLY (₹12.00 WITH ET WEALTH)

MONDAY, 2 NOVEMBER 2026

KKR, Singtel, Tata Communications are exploring sale of STT Global Data Centres India at a valuation of more than $5 billion to unlock value ▶ P 1

▶ Digital Payment Cos Fortify Security Systems as Cyberattacks Rise ▶ GST Mopup, Auto Sales, Other Key Macroindicators All Rise on Strong Demand: P 1

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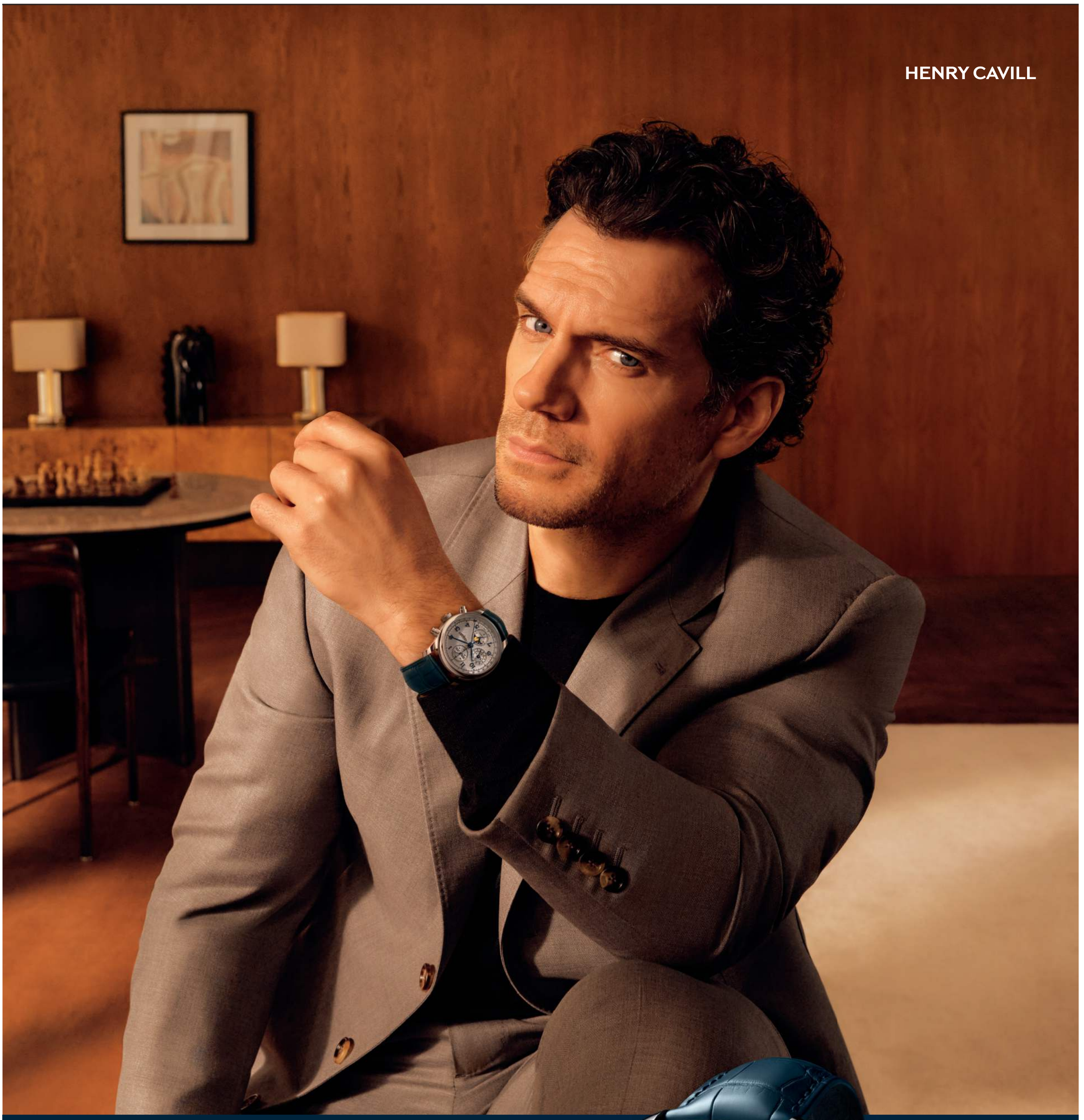

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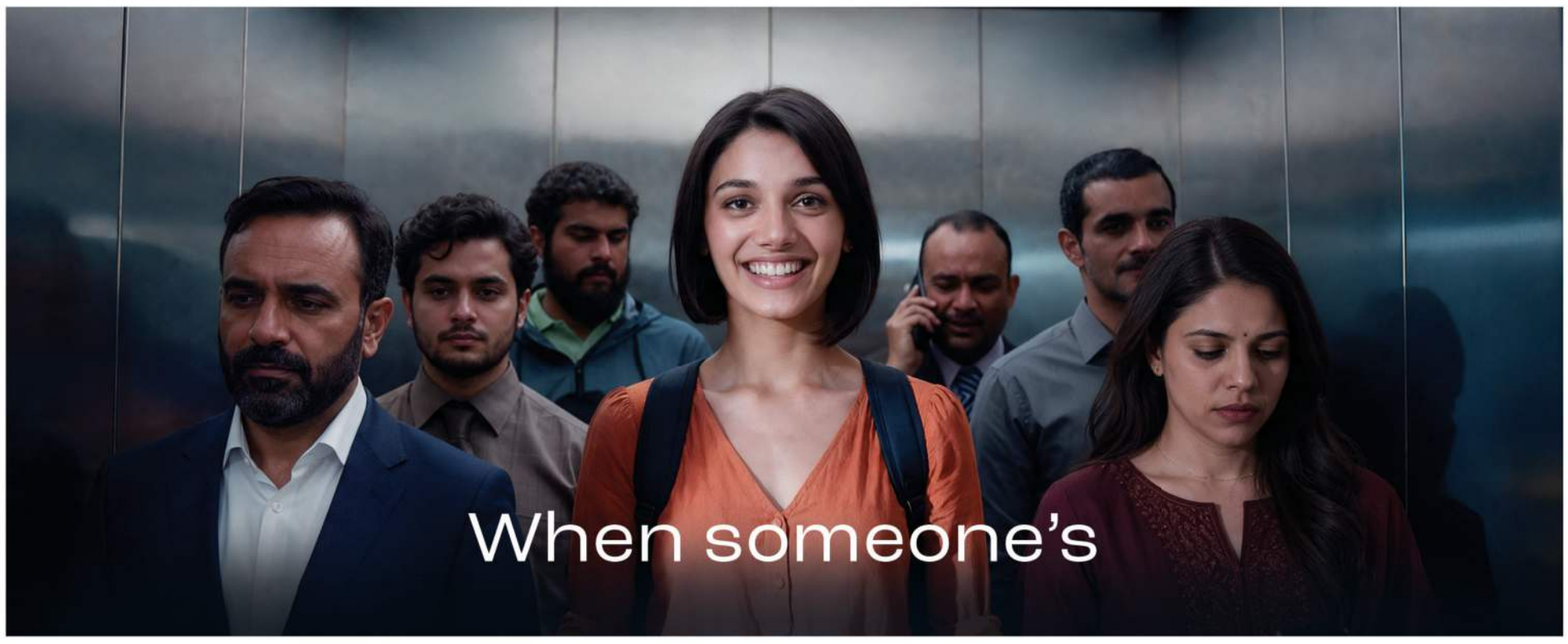
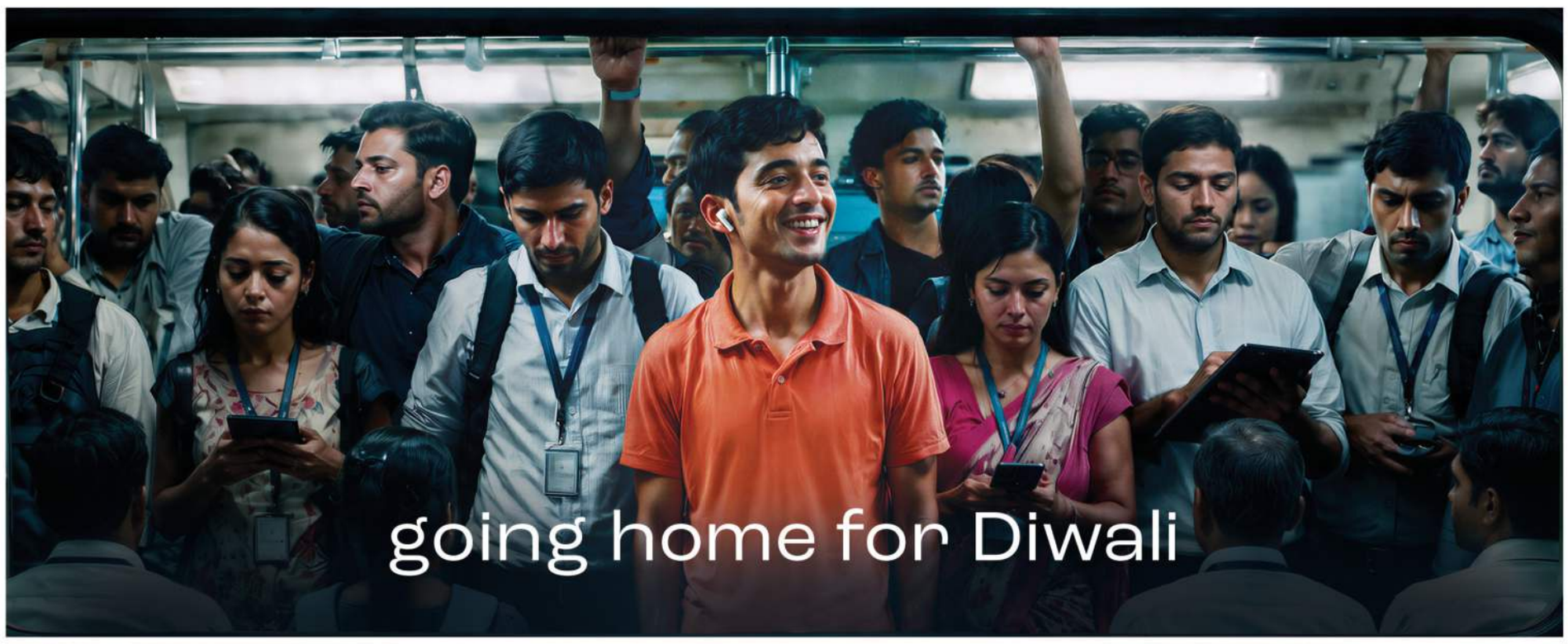
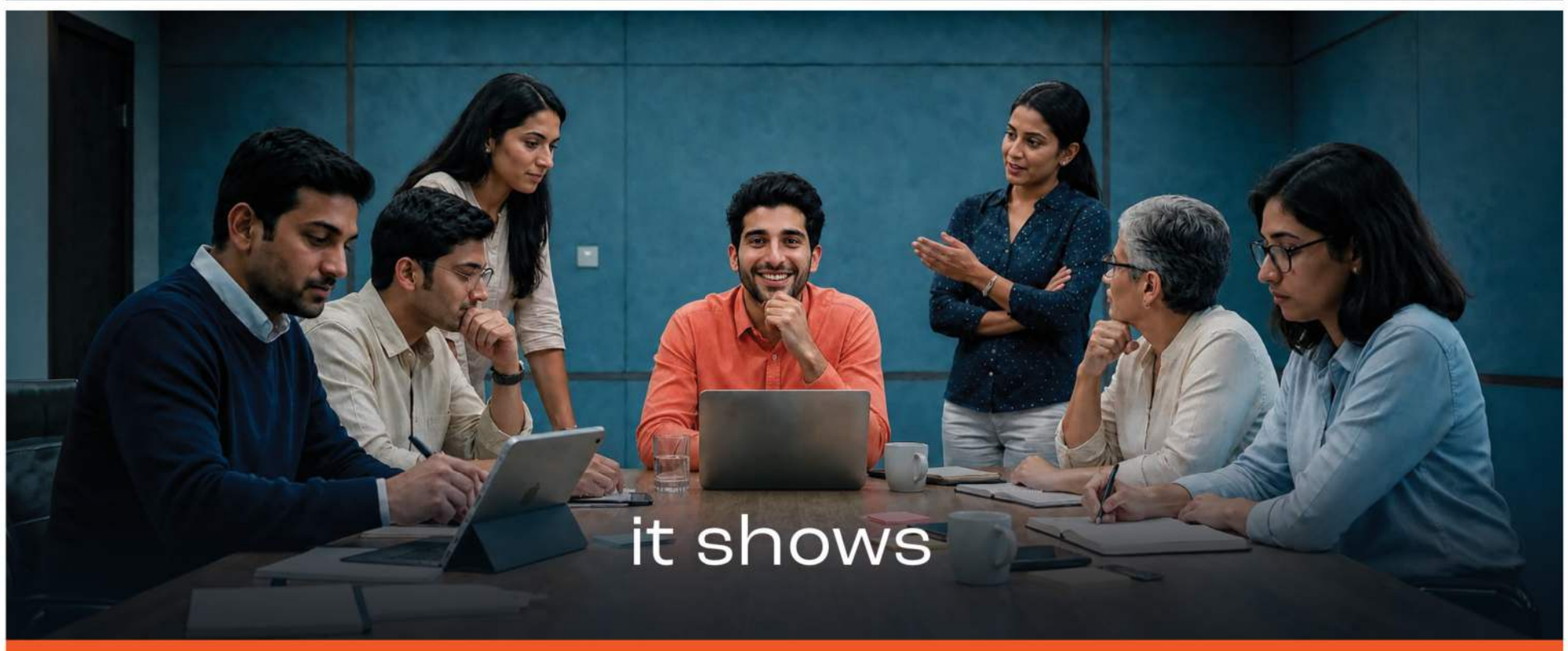
MONDAY, 2 NOVEMBER 2026

The possibility of NEET-UG 2027 continuing in pen-and-paper format cannot be ruled out. Southern states have reservations about the reform plan ▶ P 3

▶ CEC will have to Quit & Go to Jail, says Gandhi ▶ BJP Counters Rally With March ▶ Global Criticism over Covid Toughened China's Attitude, says Misri: P 2







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Tweet OF THE DAY

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A startup with 100 feature requests is a good place to be. It means people care enough to want the product to be fixed/improved. Don't be bogged down

Tech Buzz

Samsung is at Work on 17-in Foldable Tab

WASHINGTON: Samsung has reportedly started development on a massive 17-inch foldable tablet that shrinks down to an 8-inch form factor when folded. As per GSM Arena, the revelation stems from a source who originally stated in late August that a 17-inch foldable tablet was in development across multiple versions and test devices, without naming the manufacturer at the time. In an update, the same source identified the company behind the project, stating that "Samsung has already started". The upcoming hardware functions as an 8-inch tablet when closed and expands into a full 17-inch display once unfolded. The tipster noted that additional specifications cannot be shared at this stage. – **Agencies**

33%
Share of AI shoppers who identified AI-powered search tools as the biggest influence behind their most recent purchase
– McKinsey Report

DeepSeek's Coding Agent is Out in Beta

WASHINGTON: DeepSeek has released a prototype of a more autonomous coding agent as it seeks to challenge Anthropic's Claude Code. The open-source offering, dubbed 'Superagent' can proactively monitor group chats among developers for feedback on coding issues and suggest solutions without being summoned, DeepSeek Harness team said in a post. The new agent aims to "take as little human attention as possible, and give as much value as possible", DeepSeek said in a user manual on GitHub. Earlier this year, DeepSeek created the Harness team to focus on helping build AI agents that can take on US coding services. The term harness refers to software scaffolding that wraps around a large language model which enables AI agents to manage more complex tasks. – **Bloomberg**

Jargon Buster

Agent Sprawl

The messy proliferation of too many autonomous AI agents running across a company without central oversight

Speed Pays Rich for New-age Logistics Cos Chasing Growth

Rising demand for rapid deliveries from D2C brands and ecomm sellers creates opportunities

Pranav Mukul

New Delhi: New-age third-party logistics companies are increasingly looking to turn speedy delivery into a premium service, as burgeoning demand from direct-to-consumer (D2C) brands and ecommerce sellers creates opportunities beyond traditional parcel transportation.

Delhivery and Shadowfax, two of India's largest third-party logistics companies, are expanding their same-day and next-day delivery services, betting that merchants will pay more for faster deliveries as competition for customers intensifies. For Bengaluru-based Shadowfax, the economics of this shift are already becoming visible. The company's same-day delivery service commands 15-20% higher realisations on the same network, chief executive Abhishek Bansal said during the company's second-quarter earnings call on October 29.

The opportunity is also significant for Gurgaon-based Delhivery. Its same-day and next-day delivery business, along with integrated fulfillment services for vertical ecommerce brands, represents a ₹300-500 crore business, chief executive Sahil Barua said during the company's earnings call on October 30.

The shift is reflected in the strong growth both companies have seen in their core express businesses. In the second quarter of this fiscal year, Shadowfax's revenue from express parcels rose 55% year-on-year to ₹1,096 crore. Delhivery's express shipments during the same period increased by 32.1% from a year ago to 325 million.

"It is not price, it is speed," Bansal said, explaining Shadowfax's competitive strategy. "A logistics network competes on price, reach and speed. Price can be matched within a quarter. Reach can be bought, but speed has to be built." Shadowfax's Prime business, which offers same-day intracity and next-day intercity deliveries, is emerging as a key growth driver for the company. Revenue from its D2C business more than doubled year-on-year in the September quarter, while its Prime business grew 36% sequentially.

ET Insight
Decentralising fast fulfillment will ignite a D2C boom, allowing homegrown brands in smaller cities to compete head-to-head with retail giants

The company now offers same-day and next-day deliveries across more than 120 cities.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO
www.economictimes.com

GST Revamp Gives D2C Firms Pan-India Wings Amid Festive Biz Rush

Online brands stand to benefit from radical simplification of multi-state compliance

Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Direct-to-consumer brands expect simplified goods and services tax registration for small sellers to help reduce compliance costs and timelines for expansion into more states.

New rules approved at the 57th GST Council meeting on October 8 allow sellers, such brands, on online marketplaces to declare the ecommerce platforms' warehouse as their local principal place of business (PPO) for the GST purpose starting November 1, subject to special conditions.

Under this, brands and sellers don't need to secure physical office spaces, negotiate local rental agreements, or pay redundant overheads in every state they operate. "We operate in about five states and now the process to expand becomes simpler," said Rachit Jain, cofounder of BrunoMilano Watches. "We no longer need to have a physical presence in every state to obtain GST registration. We can simply use any ecommerce platform's warehouse as a PPO to start operating from a new state."

While there is not a large financial benefit from this, brands expect the new rule to make compliance easier. This regulatory change allows brands to streamline nationwide logistics and capitalise on peak consumer demand right before upcoming sale events like Diwali and Black Friday, executives said.

"Consumers now expect one-day deliveries, which means businesses need to keep inventory spread across the country. This makes it easier to add locations to our books rather than going through the process individually for every location," Jain said.

Proposed measures include simplifying the process of adding an APOB within a state

Earlier, adding a warehouse meant an official had to physically verify documents and it could take anywhere from a week to a month or more, according to executives.

"With this new rule, brands will take a week or two to deliver from one part of the country to another. Being able to store goods in warehouses across cities on one registration will let the brand split stock and keep costs in check," said Kanupriya Ahluwalia, founder of beauty and personal care brand Hyeglo Beauty.

Legacy Brands Win Big as Oct E2W Sales Surge 48% to 2.24L

Fuel inflation, budget models push buyers to EVs

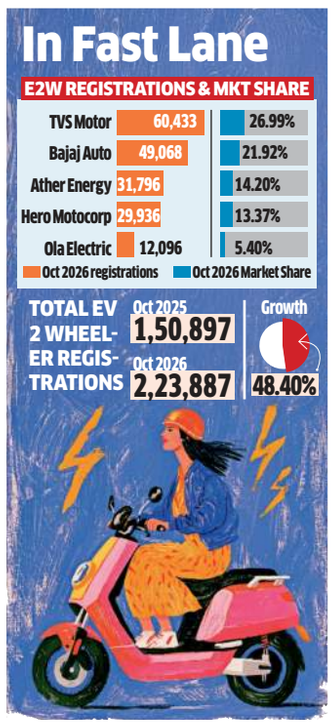
Ayanti Bera

Bengaluru: Electric two-wheeler sales in India surged 48% year-on-year to 2.24 lakh units in October, marking the highest monthly sales on record, as festive demand and new model launches helped drive adoption, according to Vahan vehicle registration data, a proxy for sales.

The record monthly sales come as established automakers continue to strengthen their position in the growing electric two-wheeler market, banking on their distribution networks, manufacturing scale and after-sales service to expand their customer base.

TVS Motor retained its leadership in October, nearly doubling registrations to 60,433 units and expanding its market share to 27% from 20.6% a year ago. Hero MotoCorp also gained ground, with its share rising to 13.4% from 10.9%, while Bajaj Auto maintained its market share at nearly 22%.

"Improvements in the charging ecosystem, greater awareness about EVs and a reduction in the cost of ownership have been building up over time, and these factors are now reaching critical mass," said Ankur Bisen, senior partner at The Knowledge Company. Fuel inflation has also accelerated adoption. "People are looking for alternatives and ways to manage their fuel costs, which has become a primary driver of EV adoption," he said.



Festive Spends Drive Record 25.47 b UPI Transactions in Oct

Total transaction value up 16% ₹31.53 lakh cr

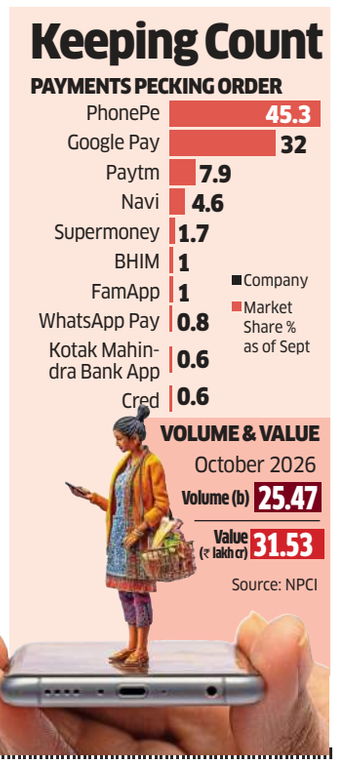
Ayanti Bera

Bengaluru: Festive spending drove a pickup in digital payments in October, with transactions on the Unified Payments Interface rising to a record 25.47 billion, up 23% year-on-year. UPI processed transactions worth ₹31.53 lakh crore during the month, a 16% rise from a year earlier and the highest on record, according to data released by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI).

The average daily transaction value increased to a record ₹1.01 lakh crore from ₹97,913 crore in the previous month while average transaction count also rose to 822 million per day in October from 802 million in September, signalling that UPI continues to expand even as consumers navigate higher prices of electronics and other festive purchases this year.

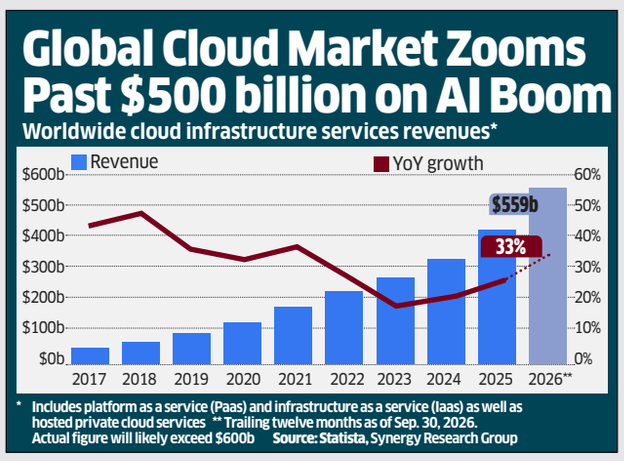
Beyond Navratri and Durga Puja, major ecommerce festive sales also began in October, boosting payment volumes and transaction sizes.

The record volumes come as the government has deferred the proposed merchant discount rate (MDR) on UPI transactions until after Diwali, keeping the festive-season payments ecosystem free of additional charges for now.



Tech Trotter

Meanwhile in tech...



Google Gets 1st AI Reply from Space Under 'Suncatcher'

New Delhi: Google has successfully run an AI model on a satellite in orbit and received its first complete response back on Earth, marking a key milestone in its Project Suncatcher initiative to explore the possibility of running AI computing infrastructure in space. Google CEO Sundar Pichai, on X, described it as a "hello world' milestone for Project Suncatcher". He said the team had sent a command to the satellite, booted up its Tensor Processing Unit, run a prompt and received the response back on Earth. – **Agencies**

OpenAI's Funding Target Cut by $10b as Interest Wanes

OpenAI has cut its fundraising target by $10 billion as an AI stock selloff and rival Anthropic's impending public listing complicate its efforts to secure investor commitments, the Financial Times reported. The company is now seeking about $20 billion at a $1.25 trillion valuation, down from $30 billion at a $1.4 trillion valuation last month, the FT said, citing people with knowledge of the matter. Some investors have reduced their commitments to OpenAI's funding round, report said.– **Bloomberg**

Sam Altman Meets Samsung Top Brass as Chip Crunch Hurts

OpenAI Chief Executive Officer Sam Altman met with Samsung Group's top executives in South Korea on Saturday to deepen cooperation on memory chips and AI infrastructure as global shortages intensify.

Samsung hosted Altman for talks with about 50 executives from its electronics, financial and biotechnology affiliates in Yongin, south of Seoul, the Korean company said in a statement. The discussions focused on how artificial intelligence can reshape industries, corporate decision-making and business opportunities over the next decade.

The meeting comes as shortages in a broad array of memory products strain the global electronics industry and send chip prices soaring. Demand from data-center operators is intensifying competition for supplies. —**Bloomberg**

Micro Occasions Spark Massive QComm, Beauty Services Boom

Instant delivery & impulse buying fuel a year-round, occasion-led biz

Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Micro occasions are driving up orders on quick commerce platforms and rapid fashion delivery apps, with some categories recording more than double the usual demand on Karva Chauth and Halloween last week, as consumers increasingly turn to them for last-minute purchases, industry executives told ET.

Quick commerce firms like Blinkit, Instamart and Zepto are stepping up marketing efforts and creating dedicated in-app pages to drive demand around these micro occasions, particularly in select localities, executives said.

"Festive moments are driving sharp spikes in quick commerce demand. For Karwa Chauth, mehndi surged 16X, while havan items, kalash and pooja thalis rose 5X. Alta, bindis and saris went up 3X, and gift sets, perfumes and deos grew 2X," said a spokesperson for Flipkart, which offers quick deliveries under its Minutes service.

For Halloween, which is popular in some major cities in India, Flipkart Minutes saw a threefold increase in orders for candies, while demand for masks and body art grew sixfold and children's costumes doubled on October 31. On Myntra Now, the rapid delivery service of online fashion platform Myntra, orders rose about 70% on October 29 compared with regular days.

QCOMM WANTS TO JOIN THE PARTY

Qcomm companies are stepping up marketing efforts to drive demand around the micro occasions

Accountability Tames AI Autonomy as DSCI Outlines its Liability Framework

Splits responsibility into 5 tech layers based on real-time ops control

Tanya Pandey

New Delhi: The Data Security Council of India (DSCI) has outlined an industry framework for assessing liability when autonomous AI agents cause harm, proposing that responsibility be traced across the technology value chain based on the decisions each participant makes and the controls it can enforce.

ET earlier reported that DSCI is working on a liability framework for autonomous AI agents.

In its framework titled AI Liability, Industry Guidance for Agentic AI, DSCI said assigning liability solely to the organisation deploying an AI system or to an upstream technology provider would be legally flawed.

Agentic AI systems involve multiple layers of models, instructions, integrations, tool calls and human decisions, making it difficult to isolate where responsibility lies when something goes wrong. The guidance identifies five groups in the AI value chain. These include organisations using AI, service providers, product companies, tool developers and infrastructure providers. It also sets out the role of model providers.

Each participant should be responsible for what it's able to decide and enforce, the council said. The decision to use an AI system ultimately rests with the deploying organisation.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO
www.economictimes.com

Consent Managers Hunting for Viable Revenue Models as Registration Nears

Debate intensifies over who should foot the bill for the privacy infra

Suraksha P

Bengaluru: Companies preparing to register as consent managers starting November 13 under India's data protection framework are yet to settle on a commercially viable revenue model, with industry players divided over who should bear the cost: data fiduciaries, technology companies, consumers or the government.

Consent managers are intended to help individuals manage, review and withdraw consent for the processing of their personal data, and they are required to be registered with the Data Protection Board of India. A consent manager is data-blind, and processes metadata, consent artifacts and cryptographic routing instructions.

The uncertainty comes as prospective consent managers assess the financial and operational demands of building a nationwide, cross-sector network through which individuals can give consent. While several companies expect data fiduciaries, organisations that collect and process personal data, to pay through platform fees and usage-based charges, others have warned that large banks, insurers and technology companies may build their own consent management systems. This could leave independent providers dependent on small and medium-size enterprises.

"The economics piece of it is still a little grey area because who will pay for it," said Shashank Karincheti, chief product officer at Redacto, which is planning to register as a consent manager.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO
www.economictimes.com

Jargon Buster

Agent Sprawl

The messy proliferation of too many autonomous AI agents running across a company without central oversight

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New-age Logistics Firms Cash in on Faster Deliveries
DISRUPTION: AI, STARTUPS & TECH ▸▸ FACING PAGE

PM to Meet Niti Aayog Leadership on Thursday
ECONOMY: MACRO, MICRO & MORE ▸▸ 11

Mass-market Segment Gives Liquor Cos a Hangover
BRANDS: CREATING DESIRE ▸▸ 10

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Introducing, CHARTISTRY

Data is everywhere; meaning is harder to find. **ET presents Chartistry** – a new data visualisation feature that will reveal the fascinating stories beneath complex numbers, with clarity, brevity and flair. Watch out for the spot, Monday to Friday. For today's chart on top overseas travel destinations preferred by Indians, see ▸▸ PAGE 10

PUREPOLITICS

PM will Face Legal Action for Vote Chori: Rahul

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi said Narendra Modi would not have become PM without CEC Gyanesh Kumar and "vote chori." Modi "will not be able to go anywhere," and will face legal action, he said at INDIA Bloc's rally in the national capital. ▸▸ 2

■ BJP Counters Oppn with 'Save Democracy, End Anarchy' March ▸▸ 2

■ NEET-UG may Continue in Pen & Paper Mode with Online Option ▸▸ 3

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7.30%* p.a.
For others
*T&C Apply.

■ ED Registers Report against Subhash Chandra in LIC HFC Loan Fraud ▸▸ 5

■ CBI Brings Back Mahadev Betting Syndicate Promoter from Oman ▸▸ 5

FESTIVE CONSUMPTION UNDAUNTED BY INFLATION OR GLOBAL CONCERNS

Demand Fires All Cylinders; Indicator Panel in the Green

Tax mopup climbs 23% for Oct; car sales, payments hit highs; other data also up

Our Bureau

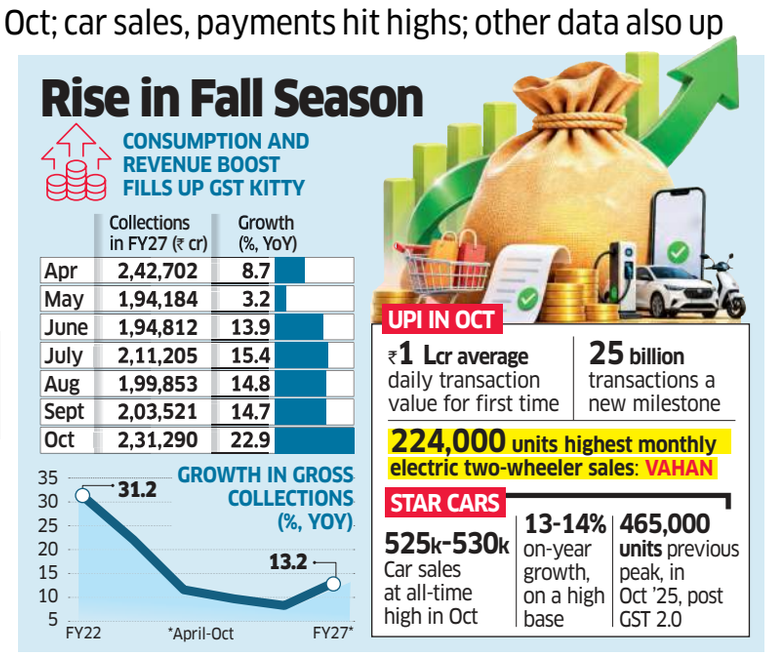
New Delhi: India's gross goods and services tax (GST) collections surged 22.9% year-on-year in October to ₹2.31 lakh crore, suggesting strong festival-season consumption despite rising inflation, higher interest rates and an adverse global environment.

Other high-frequency data backed India's strong consumption story. Passenger car sales soared about 14% to an all-time high of over 525,000 units last month.

DETAILED REPORTS ▸▸ FACING PAGE, 10

Digital payments hit a record 25.47 billion in October, up 23%, while transaction value rose 16% to ₹31.53 lakh crore, according to National Payments Corporation of India data. Power consumption surged nearly 22% in October from a year earlier, hitting 160 billion units. Diesel sales surged 11.7% on-year in the month.

Strong Start to Q3 ▸▸ 4



FPIs Return to Indian Stocks amid AI Blues

Foreign portfolio investors have turned net buyers of Indian equities, investing nearly $1.2 billion over the past 10 trading sessions. This reversal comes after aggressive selling in September and the first half of October, reports **Ravindra Sonavane**. Concerns over the AI outlook could have prompted some FPIs to shift allocations to beaten-down Indian equities. But this may be positional flows rather than a renewed bullish call on India by global investors. ▸▸ 13

FOCUS ON FIXING VULNERABILITIES

Fintechs Tighten Field to Choke Cyberattackers

Digi payment cos fortify security systems, put stricter checks in place for transactions

Nikhil Patwardhan & Ayanti Bera

Bengaluru: Digital payments companies such as PhonePe, Razorpay, Cashfree and PayU are strengthening cybersecurity systems, automating responses to attacks and tightening controls over financial transactions as a series of breaches exposes vulnerabilities across the financial services industry, multiple senior executives told ET.

These fintech companies are shifting their focus from preventing intrusions to detecting and containing them before customer online data or funds are compromised, the executives said.

At Bengaluru-based Cashfree, attempted attacks have been taking place repeatedly over the past three weeks, occurring at least 10 times as frequently as a year ago, chief technology officer Ramkumar Venkatesan told **ET**. Attackers are increasingly combining multiple vulnerabilities to attack systems, he said.

Eye on Unusual Activity ▸▸ 4

On the Defensive

WHAT MEASURES ARE BEING TAKEN

Cashfree Attack attempts up 10-fold; accelerating security fixes and isolating compromised systems

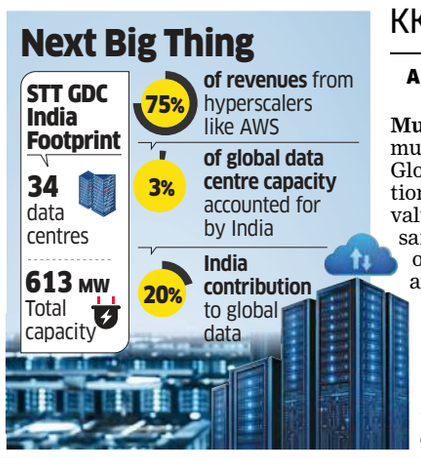
PhonePe Real-time fraud detection, automated transaction curbs & settlement holds

PayU Using AI for threat analysis, security checks and monitoring internal AI tools

Razorpay Stepping up simulated cyberattacks and round-the-clock security monitoring

STT Global to Sell India Data Centres

KKR, Singtel, Tata eye $5.5b valuation to unlock value



Arijit Barman & Himanshi Lohchab

Mumbai: KKR, Singtel and Tata Communications are looking to sell STT Global Data Centres India at a valuation of more than $5.5 billion to unlock value, people familiar with the matter said. The potential transaction is part of a dual-track initiative – alongside an earlier plan to list the business in India – to find ways to rebalance capital requirements as well as help Tatas streamline their data centre plans, they said.

STT GDC India, one of the top three co-location providers in the country, currently has 34 data centres spread across 10 centres with a total capacity of 613 MW.

This will be the first time such a large portfolio is up for grabs in India even as hyperscalers and data centre infrastructure providers are frenetically building capacity to meet increasing demand for cloud computing and artificial intelligence.

The shareholders are working with their adviser to tap global players either present or planning an Indian entry, as well as deep-pocket Indian conglomerates who have announced mega investments in the space, for the sale, people cited above said.

Evaluating IPO ▸▸ 4

RBI, FIU Lens on Crypto Card Payments

Crypto card transactions, which are prohibited in India, have caught the attention of RBI and the Financial Intelligence Unit. Over the past few days, several Indian residents' access to pre-paid crypto cards and websites of service providers has been blocked. **Sugata Ghosh** reports. ▸▸ 5

FINANCIAL INSTITUTIONS' SUSCEPTIBILITY IN FOCUS

Cyberattacks Worry Insurers

After a spate of cyberattacks on FIs, insurers are worried about banks' growing vulnerability and scale of losses, reports **Shilpy Sinha**. ▸▸ 14

SHYAM METALICS ORE TO METAL
SEL TIGER

SHYAM METALICS REPORTS PHENOMENAL GROWTH IN REVENUE, EBITDA & PAT AND SUBSTANTIAL GROWTH IN ROE & ROCE IN Q2 FY27

Q2 FINANCIAL HIGHLIGHTS

REVENUE ₹ 5,960 Cr Y-o-Y: 33.4%
EBITDA ₹ 857 Cr Y-o-Y: 40.9%
OPERATING EBITDA ₹ 823 Cr Y-o-Y: 52.6%
PAT ₹ 511 Cr Y-o-Y: 96.2%

H1 FINANCIAL HIGHLIGHTS

REVENUE ₹ 11,415 Cr Y-o-Y: 28.4%
EBITDA ₹ 1670 Cr Y-o-Y: 34.4%
OPERATING EBITDA ₹ 1588 Cr Y-o-Y: 41.9%
PAT ₹ 862 Cr Y-o-Y: 56.4%
ROE 14%
ROCE 20%

EXTRACT OF CONSOLIDATED UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND HALF YEAR ENDED 30TH SEPTEMBER 2026

CONSOLIDATED (₹ in Cr.)

PARTICULARS	QUARTER ENDED			HALF YEAR ENDED		YEAR ENDED
	30.09.2026	30.06.2026	30.09.2025	30.09.2026	30.09.2025	31.03.2026
	Unudited	Unudited	Unudited	Unudited	Unudited	Audited
Total income from operations (net)	5994.34	5502.18	4536.53	11496.52	9013.13	18755.82
Operating Earning before Interest, Depreciation and Amortisation, Share in Profit / (Loss) of associates and Joint Venture and Tax	822.93	765.31	539.44	1588.24	1119.09	2333.14
Net Profit(+)/Loss(-) before tax	658.37	469.23	347.09	1127.60	736.03	1462.37
Net Profit(+)/Loss(-) for the period after tax	510.99	350.73	260.45	861.72	551.12	1060.17
Total Comprehensive Income for the period {comprising profit/(loss) f or the period after tax and other comprehensive income after tax}	509.29	456.64	237.75	965.93	568.57	1061.51
Paid up Equity Share Capital (Face Value Rs.10/- per share)	278.39	278.38	278.23	278.39	278.23	278.29
Other Equity	-	-	-	-	-	11244.52
Earnings Per Share (EPS) (not to be annualised)						
(a) Basic (Rs.)	18.36	12.60	9.36	30.96	19.81	38.10
(b) Diluted (Rs.)	18.30	12.56	9.33	30.86	19.74	37.97

VISION 2031
- Revenue: ~Rs. 42,500+Cr (~18% CAGR/~2.3x)
- EBITDA: ~Rs. 6,600+ Cr (23% CAGR)
- Capacity: ~27 MTPA
- RoE: 16%; RoCE: 24%
- Net Cash Positive
- Value-added downstream products.
- The Phutamura Coal Block in Chhattisgarh strengthens coal security through strategic backward integration, with an expected incremental EBITDA contribution of approximately ₹400 crore by FY31.

EXTRACT OF STANDALONE UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND HALF YEAR ENDED 30TH SEPTEMBER 2026

STANDALONE (₹ in Cr.)

PARTICULARS	QUARTER ENDED			HALF YEAR ENDED		YEAR ENDED
	30.09.2026	30.06.2026	30.09.2025	30.09.2026	30.09.2025	31.03.2026
	Unudited	Unudited	Unudited	Unudited	Unudited	Audited
Total income from operations (net)	1919.17	1623.25	1703.86	3542.42	3488.28	7103.75
Net Profit(+)/Loss(-) before tax	264.04	184.81	179.17	448.85	403.90	743.79
Net Profit(+)/Loss(-) for the period after tax	198.13	138.96	135.61	337.09	303.25	552.85

OUR COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE
- AMONG TOP 10 STEEL PRODUCERS
- 20+ YEARS OF EXECUTION TRACK RECORD
- 210% RETURN SINCE IPO
- SELF-FUNDED GROWTH
- 2.3X REVENUE & 2.8X EBITDA BY FY31
- HIGHER-MARGIN VALUE-ADDED PRODUCTS
- EFFICIENT WORKING CAPITAL

- The above is an extract of the detailed format of the Unaudited Consolidated and Standalone Financial Results for the Quarter and Half year ended September 30, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of these Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchanges website: www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and on the Company's website: www.shyammetalics.com
- The above results have been reviewed by the Audit committee at its meeting held on October 31, 2026 and approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on October 31, 2026.

Scan this QR code to download Unaudited Financial Results for the Second Quarter and Half Year Ended 30th September, 2026

Place : Kolkata
Date : 31.10.2026

For Shyam Metalics and Energy Limited

Sd/-
Sanjay Agarwal
Joint Managing Director

SHYAM METALICS AND ENERGY LIMITED
Registered Office : P-19, Plate No. D-403 CPT Colony, Taratala Road, Kolkata, West Bengal, India, Pin: 700088
Tel No: 033-6521 6521, E-mail : compliance@shyamgroup.com, Website : www.shyammetalics.com , CIN: L40101WB2002PLC095491
Further contacts:pankaj.harlalka@shyammetalics.com, investor.relations@shyammetalics.com, diwakar.pingle@in.ey.com, binay.sarda@in.ey.com

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₹1,00,000 Crore+
in Total Business

A Quarter of Strong Performance - Q2, FY26-27

Total Deposits ₹52,483 Crs ▲ 19% YoY
Gross Advances ₹50,669 Crs ▲ 30% YoY
Disbursements ₹7,450 Crs ▲ 38% YoY
Net Income ₹1,313 Crs ▲ 32% YoY
Profit After Tax ₹218 Crs ▲ 803% YoY Highest Ever Quarterly PAT
ROA 1.31%*
ROE 13.50%*
*Annualised

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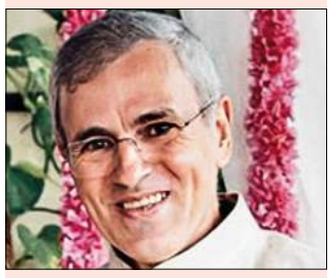
OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY



MLAs SEEK CHANGES

NC Faces Internal Strife

'If our concerns are not addressed, we may be forced to think of next step'

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Anantnag: The ruling National Conference is facing a challenging internal strife as around 20 MLAs of the party have prepared a memorandum seeking changes within the party structure as well as removal of some of the office-bearers.

Senior NC MLA Abdul Majid Larmi said the party is in dire need of "a cleansing process" to get it back on its track and free it from the "corrupt hands". This "attack is not a rebellion", Larmi said, adding the changes will bring NC "together and make it stronger".

The crisis came to the fore after CM Omar Abdullah reshuffled and expanded his council of ministers, disappointing leaders like Mubarak Gul, Larmi and Nazir Gurezi. The crisis exacerbated when Farooq Abdullah appointed Gul as party general secretary to calm his tempers but removed him within two days following a meeting of the disgruntled NC MLAs in Srinagar.

As of now, several NC MLAs don't seem convinced by any of the efforts of leadership

"We need to get rid of some people who have hijacked the party. People like Nasir Sogami, Surinder Choudhary and Showkat Mir have ruined NC," said Larmi.

Senior MLAs Larmi, Hasnain Masoodi, Farooq Shah and Aijaz Jan will present the memorandum to party president Farooq Abdullah, who is in Delhi for Omar Abdullah's one of the wedding functions.

"Our party has lost track because of some selfish, corrupt people. We are hopeful that our concerns will be addressed or else would be forced to think of the next step," another senior NC leader told **ET**. A senior NC leader said that by "merely adjusting a few people in some roles won't solve problems.

"Our party leadership is reaching out and promising advisory roles and speakership to several MLAs but that won't solve the issue. How many advisors and speakers can they appoint," he said. As of now, several MLAs don't seem convinced by any of the efforts of party leadership.

Poliloquy R PRASAD

Odisha DG Prisons Booked for Sexual Harassment

BHUBANESWAR: Odisha's DG prisons Susanta Kumar Nath was booked for allegedly sexually harassing a subordinate staff member and was **shifted from the post pending an investigation**, officials said on Sunday. Along with the senior IPS officer, who is one of the aspirants for the DGP post, a friend of his was also booked in the same case. The government transferred Nath as an OSD in the home department, officials said. – PTI

INDIA BLOC'S 'VOTE BACHAO, DESH BACHAO' RALLY

CEC will have to Quit and Go to Jail: Rahul

Legal action will be taken against PM and HM: Congress leader

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: At the Opposition INDIA bloc's 'Vote Bachao, Desh Bachao' rally at Delhi's Ramlila Maidan on Sunday, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi claimed that Narendra Modi would not have become prime minister without CEC Gyanesh Kumar and 'vote chori'. He further said Modi "will not be able to go anywhere" and would face legal action.

"Amit Shahji said Narendra Modi is not going anywhere. I am telling you the opposite: Narendra Modi cannot go anywhere. Even if he wants to leave, we will not let him go. After Gyanesh Kumar, we are going to stand right in front of you. Legal action will be taken against Modi and Shah," Gandhi said at an impressive rally at a ground with an official capacity of 50,000. He also reiterated that Kumar would have to quit and go to jail. He alleged that the 2024 Lok Sabha polls were "illegal", given that "13.5 crore voters" have been deleted since then from the rolls via SIR.

Akhilesh describes the rally as 'the Haldighati of democracy'

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav used the rally to sound the bugle for the UP assembly elections, taking a dig at the "double-engine BJP sarkar" over its "double-zero defeats" in Varanasi against SP in the recent MLC polls. He alleged "even the state BJP, fearing defeat, is now talking about 1.27 crore instances of 'vote chori' in UP to shift blame to Delhi".

In a show of unity, INDIA bloc leaders, including Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi, KC Venugopal (Congress), Akhilesh Yadav (SP), Mamata Banerjee and Abhishek Banerjee (AITC-M), Tejashwi Yadav (RJD), Farooq Abdullah (NC), Mehbooba Mufti (PDP), Sanjay Raut (SS-UBT), Supriya Sule (NCP-SP), MA Baby, D Raja and Dipankar Bhattacharyya (Left), arrived at the rally venue in an open vehicle from Rajaji Marg via Minto Road to Ramlila Maidan. Party workers accompanied them on foot, turning the journey into a boisterous march. Sonia Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge joined the leaders on the stage.

Kharge says 'Modi should be removed to save democracy'

Accusing the BJP government of spreading hatred and handing over the country's assets to two industrialists, Gandhi said the Opposition stood for unity and the welfare of all. "Anyone can join 'Shiv ki Baraat'. We want that kind of India. If a farmer works hard, he should reap the rewards. If a student studies for 18 hours, they should get employment. We do not want a country that belongs only to two or three people," he said.

Akhilesh said if BJP had come to power at the Centre through UP, it was now time for the party to take the exit route. Mamata said, "Bengal is the victim of SIR, and we will fight it out." Kharge said, "Modi should be removed to save democracy."

RULING PARTY'S BIG GUNS SPEARHEAD YATRAS

BJP Counters With 'Save Democracy, End Anarchy' March

If 2024 elections were illegal, then Rahul is an illegal LoP and all his MPs are illegal: BJP

Our Political Bureau

Democracy will run in accordance with the Constitution, not the Gandhi family's law

NITIN NABIN
BJP President

New Delhi: BJP on Sunday deployed its top guns to counter INDIA bloc's rally, with party chief Nitin Nabin, Union ministers and senior leaders leading a series of yatras across the country under the banner 'Loktantra Bachao, Arajakta Hatao' (Save Democracy, End Anarchy).

While Nabin led a march in Haryana's Rohtak, accompanied by Union minister and RLD chief Jayant Chaudhary, a prominent Jat leader from western UP, senior party leader Dharmendra Pradhan spearheaded a yatra in Faridabad.

In Delhi, Union minister Hardeep Puri, accompanied by CM Rekha Gupta, led a march from Hari Nagar to protest the 1984 anti-Sikh riots. BJP accused Congress of hurting Sikh sentiments by choosing November 1, the anniversary of the violence, for its rally. In Mumbai, Union minister Bhupender Yadav led a similar march alongside Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis and BJP ally, Shiv Sena chief and deputy CM, Eknath Shinde.

The marches were followed by a sharp attack from BJP headquarters, where party spokesman Sambit Patra accused Rahul Gandhi and Congress leadership of pursuing personal political interests at the cost of democratic institutions. Playing visuals that he claimed showed vacant spaces and empty chairs at the rally, Patra questioned Congress' claim of mobilising 10 lakh people. "Forty per cent of the Ramlila Maidan was vacant. Out of 28,000 chairs, around 5,000-7,000 were empty at 3:30-4 PM. This is the reality behind Congress' claim of 10 lakh attendees," he said.

Patra said: "Rahul Gandhi said 2024 elections were illegal. Gyanesh Kumar was not even there in 2024. He became CEC in 2025. If 2024 elections were illegal, then Rahul Gandhi is also an illegal Leader of Opposition and all his MPs are illegal."

ALL SIX REGIONS OF THE STATE WILL BE COVERED

Senior BJP Leaders to Hold Padyatras in Election-Bound UP Before Diwali

Kumar Anshuman

New Delhi: It will be a week of padyatras for Uttar Pradesh BJP, with senior party leaders set to cover all six regions of the state through scheduled marches. The programme is part of BJP's ongoing month-long 'Save Democracy, End Anarchy' campaign.

Senior BJP leaders, including national president Nitin Nabin, UP CM Yogi Adityanath, Union ministers JP Nadda and Shivraj Singh Chouhan, and deputy CMs KP Maurya and Brajesh Pathak, will participate in the yatras.

On November 3, Union minister Chouhan will lead a padyatra in Lucknow's Awadh region while Nadda will lead a march in Bareilly in the Braj region. On November 4, Nabin will lead a padyatra in Gorakhpur while Maurya will lead the march in Prayagraj.

'People of UP will not let them (Oppn parties) succeed in their malafide intentions'

On November 5, the CM will lead a similar yatra in Ghaziabad while Pathak will lead the march in Kanpur.

Sources in BJP told **ET** that the party plans to involve members of civil society in the yatras to send a message that the Opposition is attempting to destabilise the country and create anarchy through its protests.

"The people of this country have faith in the constitutional authorities and have repeatedly rejected this bunch of Opposition parties. It is the same players who are now trying a different template, but the people of UP will not let them succeed in their malafide intentions," Rakesh Tripathi, UP BJP spokesperson, told **ET**.

One Nation, Many Opportunities

At a time when people around the world are taking to the streets over one issue or another, India isn't an exception. Still, there is a difference. While protests in other countries have mostly turned violent, agitations in India have generally remained peaceful. There could be various reasons for this, but a significant one might be 'one nation, multiple elections'.

The 'one nation, multiple elections' framework — while leaving some more satisfied than others — ensures that everyone receives at least something. It doesn't bestow all the benefits upon a single party. A winner may not truly be the victor and the defeated may not exactly be the loser.

Everyone receives a share, whether large or small. Furthermore, the model always keeps governments on the public radar. A wise man once said, "There are times when fear is good. It must keep its watchful place at the heart's controls. There is advantage in the wisdom won from pain."

The fear of losing elections keeps governments proactive and on their toes. If someone falls prey to overconfidence, any election can shake things up. These staggered polls are a blessing in disguise as people get to vent their pent-up frustrations through a seemingly simple but important act of pressing a button or ticking a box.

Multiple elections work in several ways — if the governing parties win, protesters lose energy; if the Opposition triumphs, the movement diminishes naturally; and if the Opposition manages some talking points, protesters see the glass as half full.

When politics is centred on perception, multiple elections lead to repeated sensations of power and empowerment each time someone steps into a polling booth.

R PRASAD

POLIMMICK

Pravir Kumar

MINISTER FLAGS OFF B'LURU-MUMBAI VANDE BHARAT SLEEPER TRAIN

India to Export Vande Bharat Trains in 3-4 Years: Vaishnaw

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: India will begin exporting Vande Bharat trains within the next three to four years, railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said on Sunday, expressing satisfaction with the performance of the latest generation of the indigenous train set and the improvements made over earlier versions.

Speaking after flagging off the Bengaluru-Mumbai Vande Bharat Sleeper train, Vaishnaw said Indian Railways was continuously upgrading the service with each new iteration. "In the next three to four years, we will start exporting Vande Bharat trains from India," he said. The launch event was attended by Union ministers HD Kumaraswamy and Pralhad Joshi, ministers of state V Somanna, and Shobha Karandlaje.

Vaishnaw said the sleeper version has been designed with special features for passengers using middle and upper berths. It also incorporates advanced couplers to minimise jerks during travel, enhancing passenger comfort.

Karandlaje said the service would provide an affordable alternative to air travel, particularly during festive seasons when airfare tends to surge. "College students and people engaged in small jobs can travel comfortably and enjoy good facilities," she said.

The Southwestern Railway sad in a post on X that the train will improve connectivity between Bengaluru and Mumbai through key centres including Raichur, Yadgir, Kalaburagi, Guntakal, Kurnool, Solapur and Pune, boosting regional development.

The 1,118-km journey will be covered in about 16 hours, reducing travel time by nearly eight hours, Somanna said in a post on X. The train comprises 16 fully air-conditioned coaches with 823 berths and is aimed at providing a premium overnight travel experience.

The Bengaluru-Mumbai service is India's second Vande Bharat Sleeper train. The first was introduced earlier this year between Howrah and Kamakhya.

In a written reply in the Lok Sabha in March, Vaishnaw said fares for Vande Bharat sleeper trains are calculated on a per passenger-km basis. AC three-tier fares are fixed at ₹2.40 per km, excluding GST, implying a fare of about ₹2,400 for a 1,000-km journey. The minister had also informed the Parliament that Vande Bharat sleeper services do not offer Reservation Against Cancellation (RAC) tickets.

Railways has said Vande Bharat sleeper fares, ranging from ₹2.40 to ₹3.80 per km, are lower than comparable services in countries such as China, Japan and France.

Union ministers (from right) Ashwini Vaishnaw, Pralhad Joshi and HD Kumaraswamy during the flagging-off ceremony in Bengaluru– PTI

FOR MUMBAI-AHMEDABAD CORRIDOR

Minister Visits BEML Facility Building India's 1st Bullet Train

Our Political Bureau

BCCL

Bengaluru: Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Sunday reviewed the manufacturing of India's first indigenously built high-speed train, the Bharat Bullet Train (B-28), at BEML's Aditya manufacturing facility in Bengaluru.

The train is being developed for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High Speed Rail corridor and is being positioned as a major step towards building indigenous high-speed rail technology in India. The project combines advanced engineering, local manufacturing capabilities and passenger-centric design tailored to Indian operating conditions, an official press release said.

During the visit, Vaishnaw reviewed the specialised manufacturing infrastructure, including precision-engineered jigs and fixtures used for carbody fabrication. He witnessed key stages of production, such as underframe, sidewall and roof assembly, final car assembly, surface preparation and treatment processes that are critical to meeting the stringent quality and safety standards required for high-speed rail operations, the release said.

The minister also witnessed a "squeeze test", a critical quality-assurance process in which the train carbody is subjected to controlled compressive and tensile forces to assess structural strength, rigidity and dimensional stability.

He reviewed the manufacturing of side and roof modules and observed their integration into the final assembly process.

Vaishnaw inspected passenger seating and reviewed key onboard systems, including the heating, ventilation and air-conditioning (HVAC) system, couplers and other critical train equipment.

The Centre also provided passenger fare subsidies worth ₹60,239 crore in 2024-25, amounting to an average concession of 43% for travellers, according to the minister.

NOD FOR BULLET TRAIN CORRIDOR

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has approved the Southern Bullet Train Corridor connecting Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Amaravati and Chennai, Vaishnaw said on Sunday.

Speaking after flagging off the Bengaluru-Mumbai Vande Bharat sleeper train, Vaishnaw said the proposed high-speed rail corridor would bring some of the country's biggest technology and economic hubs closer, helping create an integrated economic region.

He said the corridor would significantly cut travel time, with the Bengaluru-Chennai journey expected to take just 73 minutes and Bengaluru-Hyderabad about two hours and 10 minutes.

The project forms part of efforts to expand high-speed rail connectivity and strengthen regional economic integration.

FS AT A KASHMIRI PANDIT CONCLAVE

China's Int'l Criticism on Covid Toughened its Attitude, says Misri

'India never pointed fingers at China over the pandemic'

Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: Foreign secretary Vikram Misri has said that international criticism and perceived stigmatisation of China over Covid-19 toughened Beijing's attitude towards the global community, contributing to its harsh response to the outside world and a prolonged, draconian lockdown at home.

Addressing the Iqwat Global Business Conclave, organised by an association of Kashmiri Pandits on Saturday in Mumbai, Misri said China felt that the international community was determined to blame it for the pandemic.

"Covid had already created a lot of stress multilaterally, internationally, but also bilaterally because the Chinese felt they were being stigmatised and were being blamed for Covid-19," he said.

Misri said India had never pointed fingers at China over the pandemic, but Beijing believed that the international community was trying to paint it black. "Anytime you flew out of China during Covid, returning meant a mandatory 21-day quarantine, 21 days of 'vanvaas' every time you visited Delhi for a day," he said. Following the lockdown in China, supply chains of critical items, including industrial goods and other raw materials that originate in China, faced constraints, creating challenges for recipients, including India. Subsequently, China has been weaponising supply chains, impacting global trade and production.

It may be recalled that Misri was India's envoy to Beijing during Covid and Galwan clash of 2020.

Recalling his tenure as India's ambassador to China, Misri said the Galwan crisis in eastern Ladakh posed an unprecedented diplomatic challenge, particularly as it occurred at the height of the pandemic. For the first time in nearly five decades, soldiers on both sides lost their lives along the Line of Actual Control (LAC), he noted.

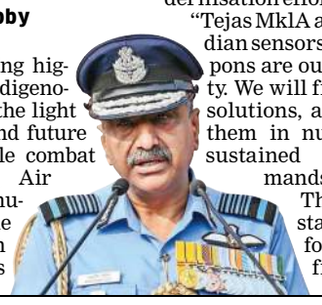
The situation was further complicated by restrictions on travel and interactions during the pandemic, making it difficult to understand domestic perceptions in China and travel between Beijing and New Delhi.

FIRST OF LCA MK1A JETS LIKELY TO BE INDUCTED THIS YEAR

LCA, AMCA Top Priority: IAF Chief Dixit After Taking Charge

Says 'we will fight with Indian solutions, and will hold them in numbers'

Manu Pubby



New Delhi: Placing highest priority to indigenous platforms like the light combat aircraft and future advanced multirole combat aircraft (AMCA), Air Chief Marshal Ashutosh Dixit said the aim is to fight with Indian solutions and hold them in numbers to conduct sustained operations.

The officer, who assumed command as the 29th Chief of Air Staff on Sunday, has been a champion of Make in India and has been closely associated with modernisation efforts.

"Tejas MkIA and II, AMCA, Indian sensors and Indian weapons are our highest priority. We will fight with Indian solutions, and we will hold them in numbers to meet sustained operations demands," he said.

This marks a stamp of approval for the Tejas LCA fighter jet that has been ordered in large numbers by IAF. The first of the LCA Mk1a fighter jets are likely to be inducted this year, after missing several deadlines due to issues with supplies of engines and integration of missiles and radars.

The top officer also clearly mentioned that the Mk2 version of the LCA is a priority, laying to rest all speculation that the project may get impacted due to delays and urgent requirements of the air force. The air force is also acquiring 114 additional Rafale jets, the deal for which is likely to be signed in the current financial year.

At present, IAF has less than 30 squadrons of fighters against a sanctioned strength of 44.

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GOVT LIKELY TO ISSUE ORDER, SAYS CM, AMID LOCAL JOBS ROW

Private Cos may have to Fly State's Flag on their Offices

Pro-Kannada outfit announces drive to collect data on locals employed by tech, mfg cos

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Karnataka will make it mandatory for private companies to hoist the state's bi-colour flag on their premises, chief minister DK Shivakumar said on Sunday, amid a row over employment for Kannadigas in the IT/BT firms.

The government is likely to issue an order this month, Shivakumar said after launching the Kannada Rajyotsava celebrations in Bengaluru. The move comes as the state faces renewed complaints of bias against locals in hiring by IT and other private companies.

Pro-Kannada outfit Kannada Rakshana Vedike (KRV), meanwhile, announced a statewide drive to collect data on the number of Kannadigas employed by private technology and manufacturing companies.

The KRV said its teams would visit companies this month seeking details of local employment. The organisation warned that it would stage protests outside firms that refuse to share the information.

"We are not asking for a share in companies' profits. We only want them to respect the right of Kannadigas to employment," KRV state president TA Narayana Gowda said.

The developments come days after Shivakumar urged pro-Kannada organisations not to take matters into their own hands or create problems for IT companies. The issue gained traction after a social media video alleging discrimination against Kannadigas in recruitment went viral.

The CM had earlier said complaints of discriminatory hiring would be examined directly by the state government and action taken against companies found violating norms. The controversy has once again brought the focus back on local employment in the private sector. Last year, the state government shelved a proposed law mandating reservations for locals in private-sector jobs after facing strong opposition from the technology industry and industry body Nasscom.

ALLEGATIONS OF BIAS

The move comes as the state faces renewed complaints of bias against locals in hiring by IT and other private companies

SIDDU 'STING' PROBE

'Phone Changed Hands at HDK's Delhi Residence'

PTI

Bengaluru: The mobile phone allegedly used in the sting operation targeting former Karnataka chief minister Siddaramaiah was purchased in New Delhi and changed hands at the official residence of Union minister HD Kumaraswamy there, Bengaluru Police commissioner Seemant Kumar Singh said on Sunday. The handover took place on the instructions of one Prajwal Prasad, who was present at the Union minister's residence, he said, citing the statement of accused Ritesh Pandey.

Handover took place on instructions of one Prajwal Prasad, present at Union minister's residence: Police

Delhi-based Pandey was arrested on October 24 in connection with uploading the video of an alleged sting operation on social media, marking the first arrest in the case. He was apprehended by Bengaluru Police's Central Crime Branch (CCB) in Delhi and was brought to the city for questioning. According to Singh, Pandey and Vinod Sharma purchased the phone from a shop in Delhi's Karol Bagh area and later handed it over to Prasad at Kumaraswamy's official residence.

NILEKANI PANEL RECEIVED OVER 54,000 SUGGESTIONS & FEEDBACK ON EXAM REFORMS

NEET-UG May Retain Pen & Paper Mode Amid Southern States' Oppn

Anubhuti Vishnoi

New Delhi: The Centre's ambitious examination reform plan, being formulated by the Nilekani panel, has hit a roadblock, with strong reservations from southern states, **ET** has learnt. This means the possibility of NEET-UG 2027 continuing in the pen-and-paper format cannot be ruled out, despite the 2026 paper leak fiasco. Essentially, the much-anticipated comprehensive exam reforms will now be rolled out from 2028-29 onwards, after a consensus is reached with the states.

The High-Powered Task Force (HPTF) is learnt to have divided its recommendations into two segments — long-term measures, which will come into effect from the 2028-29 cycle, and immediate measures outlining the way forward for the 2027 cycle. The latter is now likely to involve the continuation of the pen-and-paper format alongside computer-based testing (CBT) for NEET-UG. Under the proposed arrangement, NEET-UG could be conducted in multiple shifts in the CBT format, similar to JEE, with the pen-and-paper exam being conducted in such shifts, it is gathered. The JEE exam structure will remain unchanged for 2027 and has already been notified by the NTA. While the ultimate objective is to shift NEET-UG to the CBT mode and, over the longer term, to Computer Adaptive Testing, a JEE-like gradual transition in the next two to three years is now being considered to ensure familiarising students with CBT while also preparing exam infrastructure across states for a full transition, **ET** has reliably learnt.

NEET-UG 2027 Prep

NTA likely to notify exam pattern soon

1.5 Lakh CBT centres identified

40,000+ more centres likely

22 Lakh+ NEET-UG candidates

9-DAY WINDOW LIKELY IN CBT & PEN-PAPER MODE

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VEDANTA LTD Q2FY27 HIGHLIGHTS

HISTORIC BEST QUARTERLY RESULTS

REVENUE	EBITDA	PROFIT AFTER TAX
₹25,812 Cr	₹9,938 Cr	₹6,202 Cr
▲57% YoY	▲106% YoY	▲151% YoY
EBITDA MARGIN	**FREE CASH FLOW**	**INTERIM DIVIDEND**
60%	₹5,803 Cr (pre-capex)	₹5/share
▲1,055 bps YoY		
NET DEBT/EBITDA	**CREDIT RATING**	
0.1x	AA+/Stable	
Net Debt reduced by ₹4,624 Cr	by ICRA and CRISIL	

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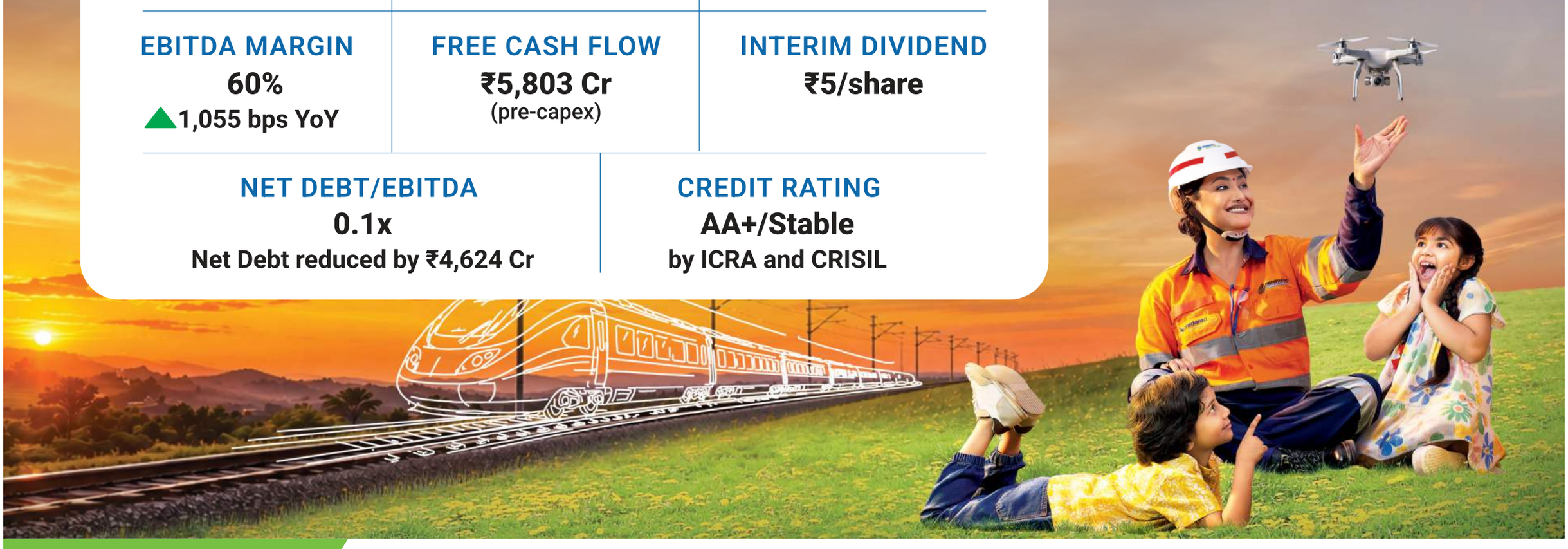

GROWTH MILESTONES | Gamsberg Phase II commissioned in South Africa | First chromite ore produced from underground mines in Odisha

VEDANTA LIMITED | METALS | CRITICAL MINERALS | RENEWABLE ENERGY | TECHNOLOGY

Eye on Unusual Activity

▸▸ From Page 1

Cashfree is tightening controls to prevent attackers from finding their way through one front and gaining access to other areas, while using AI to identify vulnerabilities and accelerate security fixes. "We are also prepared for the worst case," Venkatesan said.

India's largest UPI platform, PhonePe, is deploying machine-learning systems that assess transaction risks within milliseconds. Unusual merchant activity can trigger tighter transaction limits or temporary settlement holds, executives familiar with the matter said.

The company has also put in place automated mechanisms to isolate compromised banking connections and reroute transactions through other partners.

The urgency follows a series of raids by attackers who have weaponised artificial intelligence tools to detect vulnerabilities and overcome defences in India and globally. ET reported on October 15 that cyberattacks had hit about 20 Indian financial institutions, with stolen credentials being used to bypass disbursal and fund-transfer checks.

On Friday, global cryptocurrency exchange Binance disclosed losses estimated at $6.3 billion following unauthorised withdrawals while AU Small Finance Bank said it was investigating a potential data leak on a Salesforce-hosted platform.

The stakes are high in a financial system where the unified payments interface (UPI) alone processed a record 25.47 billion transactions worth ₹31.53 lakh crore in October.

Cashfree has also brought forward planned security fixes, restricted access to testing environments and introduced short-lived credentials. It is automating procedures to isolate and rebuild compromised systems, scanning public software repositories for exposed merchant authorisations and revoking them.

At PhonePe, AI agents are not permitted to independently initiate refunds or settlements, which remain subject to predefined rules and multiple verification checks, one of the executives said.

The increasing speed of attacks is also forcing companies to reassess how they identify emerging threats and deploy safeguards before vulnerabilities can be exploited.

Prosus-owned payments and credit company PayU has established processes to assess emerging threats and security advisories, while implementing the necessary controls. The company is also using AI tools for security analysis and compliance checks, strengthening oversight of AI use across employee and production systems, and developing AI-based security tools, people familiar with the matter said.

Razorpay has stepped up simulated attacks on its own systems and is monitoring unusual merchant transactions more closely.

"Attackers are using AI to move from finding a weakness to exploiting it in minutes, so we test our own systems the way they would, design on an assume-breach basis, and monitor around the clock with an AI-based security operations centre," said Prabu Ram, senior vice president of engineering at Razorpay. "Security testing and real-time monitoring are a continuous part of how we operate, and we keep strengthening these controls as threats evolve."

The shift toward automation extends to stockbroking platforms, where compromised credentials could expose customer accounts and trading systems. One of India's largest stockbrokers has automated incident-response procedures that previously required manual intervention, according to a person familiar with the matter.

Its trading and fund-movement systems are segregated from developers' routine access, while multiple approvals limit what compromised credentials can do. Recent breaches elsewhere have also prompted internal simulations to assess potential exposure, although several of these safeguards predate the latest attacks.

Evaluating IPO

▸▸ From Page 1

They may also tap financial sponsors such as infrastructure-focused funds and buyout private equity investors. They had also appointed advisers around July to evaluate an Indian IPO for the business at a $6-7-billion valuation.

STT GDC India is a 74:26% joint venture of ST Telemedia Global Data Centres (STT GDC) and Tata Communications.

In February, KKR and Singtel announced a $5.2-billion cash buyout to take full control of STT GDC at an implied enterprise value of $10.2 billion. KKR currently owns 75% of the firm with Singtel owning the rest.

KKR and STT GDC India declined to comment. Mails to Singtel and Tata Communications did not generate a response until press time on Sunday.

MULTI-BILLION BETS

Data centres in Asia Pacific have been valued at 18-20 times their contracted Ebitda, said industry watchers. Blackstone and CPPIB's $16-billion acquisition of Australia's AirTrunk in September 2024 had valued the target even higher at 22-23x its contracted Ebitda.

STT GDC is expecting similar multiples for its India business which could translate into a slim discount to its IPO value expectations.

STT Group is looking to monetise its India assets to balance its global capital requirement, a senior data centre executive familiar with the company's operations said.

"With mega expansions in Singapore, Indonesia, Korea and Europe lined up, the investment pipeline for STT has gone up substantially," the person explained.

"On the other hand, big groups like Reliance, Bharti and Adani have all announced significant investments and ramp-ups in India, as have many of the standalone players like NTT, CtrlS etc. So, they may choose to buy and get scale," the executive said. "Beyond a few global players, the data centre industry is fragmented and therefore open to consolidation."

STT Group has a significant presence across Asia and Europe and runs over 100 data centres with a cumulative capacity of over 2 GW.

Tata group, meanwhile, has decided to pursue its data centre plans with TPG and group flagship TCS joining hands to launch an independent platform.

Strong Start to Q3

▸▸ From Page 1

However, petrol sales grew a moderate 3.1%, while jet fuel and LPG sales declined.

Net GST collections, after adjusting for refunds, rose 25.6% to ₹2.03 lakh crore in October. Total refunds increased 6.5% during the month.

"This robustness is expected to continue as it ties in with leading macroeconomic indicators, all of which point to a domestic consumption-driven economy growing at a steady pace, not significantly impacted by global headwinds," said MS Mani, partner, Deloitte India.

The data suggests a strong start to the third quarter of the current fiscal year. India's economy grew at a faster-than-expected 7.8% in the June quarter, triggering a raft of upgrades by international agencies.

The IMF raised India's growth forecast for FY27 to 7%, up from its earlier estimate of 6.4% in July.

Demand hasn't been dented by high inflation and interest rates, and a poor monsoon, the data suggest.

Consumer inflation rose to a 23-month high of 5.5% in September from 4.8% in August.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) last month raised the policy repo rate by a quarter of a percentage point to 5.5% while changing its stance to "calibrated tightening," seeing evidence of broadening inflation. The central bank Monetary Policy Committee's next meeting is scheduled for December 2-4.

GST COLLECTIONS

Domestic GST collections rose 15.8% to ₹1.59 lakh crore, while that from the levy on imports grew 42.2% to ₹72,246 crore.

The average monthly gross GST collection for the current fiscal year is ₹2.11 lakh crore.

RBL BANK LTD.
Registered Office: Shahupuri, Kolhapur, Maharashtra - 416001
CIN: L65191PN1943PLC007308 Website: www.rbl.bank.in

CORRIGENDUM

Invitation for Expression of Interest for the sale of listed Non-Convertible Debentures issued by Shristi Infrastructure Development Corporation Limited through the Swiss Challenge Method

This refers to the Invitation for Expression of Interest **("EOI Notice")** published by RBL Bank Limited **("Bank")** in The Economic Times and Assomiya Pratidin on 16th October 2026. The EOI Notice invited Expressions of Interest **("EOI")** from eligible participants for the purchase of the Bank's holding of listed 10% Non-Convertible Cumulative Redeemable Debentures (aggregate face value 145 crore) issued by Shristi Infrastructure Development Corporation Limited.

Interested parties are informed that the Bank has decided to extend the timelines under the EOI Notice. The revised last date for submission of EOI shall be 6th November 2026 till 6:00 p.m.

EOIs already submitted under the EOI Notice will continue to be treated as valid. Participants who have already submitted an EOI do not need to submit it again, but may withdraw or supplement their EOI under the Process Document.

All other terms and conditions of the EOI Notice and the Process Document remain unchanged. The detailed Process Document, eligibility criteria, formats and the revised timelines are available on the Bank's website at https://www.rbl.bank.in/news.

The Bank reserves the right, in its sole and absolute discretion, to:

- accept or reject any or all EOIs/Bids;
- modify, extend, suspend, cancel or withdraw the process at any stage; and
- decide not to proceed with the sale,

without giving any reasons and without any liability. Any further corrigendum, addendum or extension will be published only on the Bank's website.

For any queries, please contact: **Email:** Anil.dalmia@rbl.bank.in ; Ratnesh.shukla@rbl.bank.in **Address:** RBL Bank Limited, 20th Floor, One world Center, Tower 2-B, 20th Floor, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel (West), Mumbai 400013 **Contact Person:** Anil Kumar Dalmia – 9819226840; Ratnesh Shukla – 83691 08176

Place: Mumbai
Date: 2nd November 2026

Authorised Officer
RBL Bank Limited

ASRTU
ASRTU BHAWAN, Plot No.4-A, PSP Block Pkt.14, Sec-8, Dwarka New Delhi - 110 077
Ph.: 011-43294294 Extn. 406/414

NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BID NIT NO. 2/2026 - 275th SC (S&C)

A	Tender Commencement Date	02/11/2026	11 00 Hrs
B	Tender Forms request Last Date	30/11/2026	11 00 Hrs
C	Tender Closing Date (CAT-1 e-submission)	01/12/2026	11 00 Hrs
D	Tender Closing Date (CAT-2 - Manual submission)	01/12/2026	17 00 Hrs

Cost of Tender form including GST Rs 3,540/- to be paid only at www.tenderwizard.com/ASRTU
for more details of Tender Notice Visit **www.asrtu.org**

CHHATTISGARH TOURISM BOARD
UDYOG BHAWAN, 2nd FLOOR, TELIBHANDHA RAIPUR - 492 006
दूरभाष : (0771) 4024600, 4024611, 4224630 फैक्स : (0771) 4066425 ई-मेल : visitcg@gmail.com

NIT No. I/724935/2026 Notice Inviting Tender (NIT) Date: 30-10-2026

Subject - Notice Inviting Request for Proposal (RFP) for Selection of Contractor for Balance work with external development for Pandrapath Resort, Dist. Jashpur, Chhattisgarhas mentioned in below table The Chhattisgarh Tourism Board (CTB) (the "Authority") has decided to Select a Contractor for Balance work with external development for Pandrapath Resort, Dist. Jashpur, Chhattisgarh. In this regard, CTB is inviting eligible bidders to submit Bid Online through Chhattisgarh e-Procurement website https://cgeproc.cgstate.gov.in/nicgep/app in Two cover Bid System, for the subject Project in compliance with the NIT. Any further changes/ alterations in the aforementioned tender document shall be communicated through the e-procurement website https://cgeproc.cgstate.gov.in/nicgep/app.

Sr. No.	Name of Project	Date of issue of tender document	Last Date for sending Pre-Bid Queries	Date of Pre-Bid Meeting	Last Date for Submission of Bid (Online)	Last Date for Submission of Bid (Offline)	Date of Bid Opening
1.	Selection of Contractor for Balance work with external development for Pandrapath Resort, Dist. Jashpur, Chhattisgarh	02.11.2026	12.11.2026 Till 12:00 PM	12.11.2026 at 12:00 PM	03.12.2026 Till 06:00 PM	03.12.2026 Till 12:00 PM	05.12.2026 At 12:00 PM

Managing Director,
Chhattisgarh Tourism Board

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real estate

BANGALORE PROPERTIES

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BTM LAYOUT

BDA COMMERCIAL SITE FOR SALE @ BTM- 4th Stage. SITE AREA - 40 X 60. SOUTH FACING Property type- Commercial. Mob- 9071033356.

CUNNINGHAM ROAD

4BHK 3Balcony, 1unit/ floor, 3200Sft High end Flats Govianu Cunningham, 100mtr frm Cuningham Rd, Last 1unit avlb. 8088330330, www.govianu.com

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DOLLARS COLONY

3BHK, 2000 SQFT Luxury High-end Flat for Sale, DOLLARS COLONY. For details contact: 8088330330. www.govianu.com

GIRINAGAR

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promaxdreamvillehome.com
9353084848 / 9901834205

HSR LAYOUT

SITE for SALE at 3rd sec HSR Layout 40 x 60 East facing 8.64cr & West facing 8.50cr, Near HSR Club, BDA Site with clear titles. Call. 9916773711.

SALE, at HSR 3rd sec, east facing, 3 bhk premium flat, 2 & 3 flr, on 40 x 60, 1900 sft builtup, possn 15 months, Rs.3.75cr. For brochure. 7676040354.

INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT - AROUND

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JP NAGAR

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JP-NAGAR 2nd Phase, near Rameshwaram Cafe, Site for Sale 30×35 (1050sft) Facing: West, Price: 33,000/- sft. (Nego) call: 9741220544 / 9731311966

JPNAGAR 2ND PHASE Prime Location 30x40 & 30x50 Old House BDA Property Clear Titles Price 4.3CR Call Classic Estates: 98453 02589

JUDICIAL LAYOUT

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3BHK, Luxury High End Flats Sale, Govindarajnagar Magadi Rd, Next to Royal Enfield shrw, OC received Last 2 units only, 8088330330, www.govianu.com

MG ROAD & AROUND

SALE
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WITH ELEVATOR & car parking, all Burma teak doors & windows with fully furn. interiors & furniture. Ct 9880347774

NANDINI LAYOUT

SALE 40X60 south facing Site in Jai Maruthi Nagar Near Nandhini Layout 1.5km From Mahalakshmi Metro Station @ 10000/- sqft Contact: 99000 35430

OTHERS

UNDER BANKS, BDA, High Court, Civil/ DC/ AC/ Tribunal/ Tahsildar Courts pending cases. Contact: 96202 53180.

OUTER RING ROAD

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tender & notices

TENDERS

OPG POWER GENERATION PRIVATE LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

OPG Power Generation Private Limited invites tenders from eligible contractors for the following work:

Tender Title: Construction of Railway Siding including track linking, earthwork, blanketing, civil structures, signaling, and telecommunication works under Gati Shakti Cargo Terminal (GCT) of M/s OPG Power Generation Pvt. Ltd. with Take-off from Gummidipoondi Station, Chennai Division, Southern Railway.

Tender No.: OPG/RLY/GPD/26-27/001

Cost of Tender Document: ₹10,000/- (Rupees Ten Thousand Only, Non-Transferable).

BANK ACCOUNT DETAILS FOR TENDER DOCUMENT FEE:

Bank Name: Union Bank of India, Branch: Chennai Industrial-Finance Branch,

Account Number: 530705010010052, IFSC: UBIN0553077

Payment Reference: Tender No. OPG/RLY/GPD/26-27/001

Interested bidders shall share the NEFT/RTGS payment transaction details along with their company name and contact details to the below mail ID obtain the tender document.

CONTACT DETAILS

Commercial / Tender Contact:
The Purchase Head
+91 9790985260
OPG Power Generation Private Limited
No. 6, Sardar Patel Road, Guindy, Chennai – 600032.
Email: Madhavan.jayapal@opgpower.com

Technical contact:
The Vice-president
+91 8754566644
OPG Power Generation Private Limited
No. 6, Sardar Patel Road, Guindy, Chennai – 600032.
Email: sabari@opgpower.com

shopping

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Min. 5 yrs experience.
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Min. 2-3 years experience in 2D/3D Designing,
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9930980843
ROUNAQH

personal

CHANGE OF NAME

I Deepa Kamath N D/o Jayaprakash Kamath and W/o Akhil D Prabhu R/o 116 1st Stage 5th Phase 3rd Main, West of Chord Road Sri Mahaganapathi Nagar, Bangalore North, Rajajinagar, Bangalore North Bangalore, Karnataka- 560010, have changed my name to Anandi Akhil Prabhu

I, Anantha Murthy Hegde S/o Shivarama residing at No. 32, Ground Floor, 2nd Cross, Balaji Nagar, Uttarahalli Main Road, Bengaluru-560061 have changed my name to Ananthamoorthy Hegde for all purposes.

I, Manish S/O Girish H C born on 09/03/2001 residing at 1483, maharaja park road, northern extension, Hassan 573201 have changed my name to Manish H G vide affidavit dated 31/10/2026

I, Deepak Gupta, residing at No. 18, 10th street, Prakruthi township, Babusabpalya, Bangalore — 560043, have changed my minor son's name from Krishvansh gupta to Samrat gupta , born on 24/07/2024 vide affidavit dated 16th September 2026 at Bangalore

I, Thriveni M B D/o Late M Balasundaram (Army No. JC 21749) and Late M Mahalakshmi, R/o No. 60/3, New Road, Jeevanahalli, Cox Town, Bangalore, Fraser Town Post, Bangalore - 560005, have corrected my name from "MB Thriveni" to "Thriveni M B." for all purposes.

I Yellappa Pillai A S/o Appu Pillai R/o 318, 9CM, HRBR I Block, KalyanNagar, Bangalore-43 have changed my name to Yellappa Appu Pillai vide affidavit dated 25/10/26 at KalyanNagar, Bangalore

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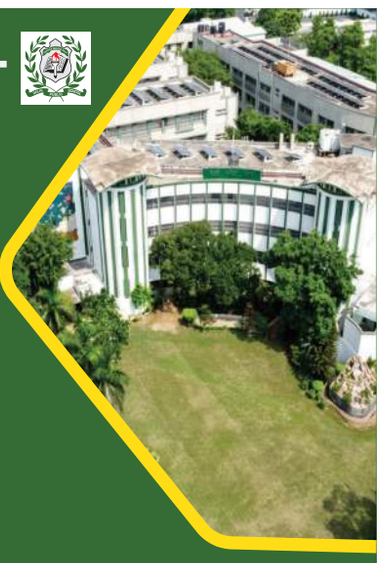

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PRINCIPAL

Crypto Cards Face Scrutiny, Some Blocked

RBI, FIU were alerted to residents' use of overseas prepaid cards to pay local merchants, bypass regulators & taxman

Sugata Ghosh

Mumbai: A new animal, which had crept into the world of Indian payments, is now being hounded out. Unbeknownst to most, crypto cards, which are prohibited here, had landed in the hands of several tech-savvy residents. Familiar with crypto wallets, they figured out how to obtain these prepaid crypto cards and use them for any transaction within India—online purchases, recharging mobile, and booking flights.

For local merchants selling goods and services, crypto cards come across as regular debit cards from Indian banks. Just as money is debited from a bank account, cryptos, like stablecoins, lying in users' wallets are converted into rupees to pay merchants.

Accessed from international fintech service providers like RedotPay, crypto cards are supported by global payment processing networks like Visa and Mastercard.

But unlike ordinary debit cards, crypto card transactions may escape the radar of Indian banks, regulators, the tax department, and other authorities. Persons with undisclosed crypto may store it in designated wallets to spend without leaving a pattern. The cards cost $40-50, have a three-year validity and have high daily transaction limits.

This seemingly furtive payment mode has now caught the attention of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Financial Intelligence Unit (FIU), the agency tracking suspicious transactions, two people told **ET**.

Significantly, over the past few days, several Indian residents' access to prepaid crypto cards and websites of service providers have been blocked.

This may have been triggered by alerts from organisations like Digital South Trust, a Bengaluru-based blockchain research entity, which obtained a virtual Visa-backed RedotPay crypto card to carry out multiple domestic online transactions in August. The company shared the card and online purchase details with Indian authorities.

The cards cost $40-50, have a three-year validity and have high daily transaction limits

"Today, even routine Visa or Mastercard payments in India can be funded by cryptocurrencies or dollar-backed stablecoins through offshore card programmes, some of which advertise limited or no KYC requirements. We independently examined multiple crypto-card programmes, documented their use for everyday payments in India, and submitted the findings to relevant authorities. We trust the government to examine the risks," said Sudhakar Lakshmanaraja, founder of the non-profit Digital South Trust.

Sources said RBI and FIU are understood to be in touch with VISA and Mastercard on the matter. However, no confirmation was available from the payment firms or the central bank as none of them responded to ET's queries.

"Users can only deposit, not transfer coins from designated wallets unless cards are used. What's significant is the technology working seamlessly in the background. Besides online purchases within India, there are videos doing rounds on the use of physical crypto cards to withdraw cash from ATMs of large Indian banks. Users have no bank accounts, but cryptos from their wallets are converted to pay banks the amounts withdrawn," said another person.

DEACTIVATION OF CARDS

Since Thursday, there have been social media posts by a number of users complaining that their crypto cards could not be used in India. Sources do not rule out the possibility that firms like VISA may have started deactivating crypto cards for transactions within (or from) India.

Though kosher and popular in many jurisdictions, crypto cards trample multiple Indian laws. Linking a crypto wallet with a foreign service provider, paying with cryptos (which are banned as currency) for purchases, and using cryptos to pay overseas residents or merchants may violate the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA) among other statutes.

"The pre-paid crypto card phenomenon has been around for some time, but many individual users are clueless about FEMA implications. Of late, internationally, there are questions around fund source and beneficial ownership of tokens, including whether they were stolen or hacked. While some cards can be procured with little KYC and AML checks, agencies can use tools like chain analysis to trace token use and path to go after users. The risk is cross-border, not just domestic," said Manavendra Mishra, white-collar crime and investigations partner at the law firm Khaitan & Co.

According to Harshal Bhuta, co-founder and country co-head (international tax and FEMA) at Ascentium India, a foreign crypto debit card effectively circumvents the prepaid instruments (PPI) and payment and settlement systems (PSS) regulatory frameworks and raises concerns under FEMA regulations, given that crypto wallet balance is held through a foreign custodian account and is automatically converted from cryptocurrency into fiat currency to facilitate merchant payments in India and abroad. Further, it also leads to tax evasion as crypto conversion to fiat happens without tax payment in India by Indian residents, said Bhuta.

Global growth in crypto card spend is largely driven by stablecoins. This is increasingly visible on traditional rails, with Visa disclosing more than 150% growth in volume across 5 million cards and a stablecoin settlement run rate surpassing $25 billion in annualised volume, said Vedang Ratan Vatsa, founder of Hashtag Web3, a Web3 research and career resource platform. These cards, he said, seem to function less as a parallel payment system and more as an added funding layer on traditional networks that convert crypto balances to local currency.

PLAN FOR GLOBAL LISTING

Gulf Oil Plans Return to Mexico, US Next Yr Amid Global Push

Lubricant maker is eyeing acquisitions in Southeast Asia and South America

Kalpana Pathak

Mumbai: Gulf Oil Lubricants plans to return to Mexico in 2027, the market where the Gulf brand's journey began, as the Hinduja Group-owned company accelerates its international expansion, scouts acquisitions in new markets and prepares for a possible global listing in the next three to five years.

The company also plans to re-enter the US market in 2027 through a master-licensing arrangement covering 11 states, with discussions under way to expand into other parts of the country, Sanjay Hinduja, non-executive chairman of Gulf Oil Lubricants India, told **ET**.

The US was excluded when the Hinduja family acquired Gulf from Chevron Corp in 1984. The planned entry will mark the company's return to a market it had not been permitted to operate in under the original acquisition arrangement.

The group also intends to list Gulf Oil International in the next three to five years, although the listing venue and timing have not been decided.

"We are still busy expanding, acquiring and growing," said Hinduja, adding that the company was still a few years away from going public. Gulf Oil International remains privately held and does not disclose its revenue figures.

Its Indian entity is listed and has a market capitalisation of ₹5,113 crore. Last week, Gulf Oil Lubricants India reported a 34.48% year-on-year increase in net profit to ₹117 crore in the second quarter of FY27, from ₹87 crore in the corresponding period last year. Profitability was supported by volume growth across consumer, commercial and industrial segments.

Revenue from operations rose 44% to ₹1,379 crore from ₹957 crore. Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation increased (Ebitda) 37.29% to ₹163 crore from ₹118 crore, while its Ebitda margin contracted 58 basis points to 11.8% from 12.4% a year earlier.

Hinduja said the company was also scouting for acquisitions to strengthen its international presence. It has appointed banks to identify potential targets in South America and Southeast Asia, although investment commitments have not been finalised.

Gulf Oil International has established facilities in Argentina and Brazil and is developing operations in markets including Chile, Paraguay and Bolivia. Its marine lubricants business has emerged as a key international growth driver, servicing more than 1,000 ports globally. Hinduja said the business was now the world's second-largest marine lubricants player.

In India, Gulf Oil Lubricants plans to invest ₹55 crore to expand mfg capacity at its Silvassa and Chennai plants by 70%

The group is also exploring acquisitions in Vietnam and other Southeast Asian markets.

In India, Gulf Oil Lubricants plans to invest ₹55 crore to expand manufacturing capacity at its Silvassa and Chennai plants by 70%, as it seeks to accelerate growth and strengthen its domestic market position, Ravi Chawla, MD and CEO of Gulf Oil Lubricants India, said.

OMAN EXTRADITION

CBI Brings Mahadev Betting Syndicate Promoter Back to India to Face Probe

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Sunday said it had secured the extradition of Sourabh Chandrakar, promoter of the Mahadev online betting syndicate, from Oman.

A CBI team that travelled to the Sultanate escorted him to India. He is expected to be produced before a special court in Raipur on Monday.

Chandrakar was wanted in two CBI cases in which chargesheets have been filed, as well as in a case being investigated by the Enforcement Directorate (ED), in which a prosecution complaint has been filed, the agency said in a statement.

Platform was among the country's largest illegal online betting syndicates, operating outside India

The accused will undergo a medical examination and be taken to Raipur after the CBI obtains transit remand. He will be produced before the CBI Special Judge in Raipur on November 2, the agency said.

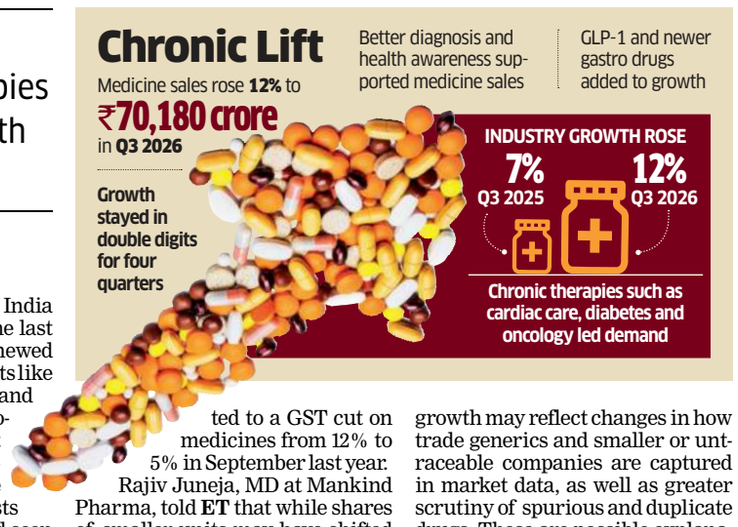
The CBI said it had taken up the investigation into the Mahadev Online Book cases on a request from the Chhattisgarh government. Its investigation found that the platform was among the country's largest illegal online betting syndicates and operated from outside India.

According to the agency, the syndicate offered betting on cricket, football, card games and other events through a network of franchised "panels" and "branches" across India.

Well, Medicine Sales are Rising in Double Digits

Renewed surge in chronic care therapies lifts industry growth to 12% in Q3 2026

Rica Bhattacharyya & Vikas Dandekar



Mumbai: Medicine sales in India grew in double digits over the last four quarters, fuelled by a renewed surge in chronic care segments like heart issues, hypertension, and diabetes, an ET analysis showed. Industry experts expect the high growth rate to continue over the next two to three years. The uptick contrasts with the slower growth trend seen during most of 2025, which hovered around 6-8%.

According to PharmaTrac, the industry grew 12% year-on-year to ₹70,180 crore in the September quarter in value terms. The growth rate was 11% in the preceding two quarters and 10% during October-December 2025. The third quarter of 2025 saw a growth of 7%.

The Central Drugs Standard Control Organization (CDSCO) ordered the shutdown of several hundred non-compliant small and medium-scale units over the last two years, and their sales may have shifted to larger players, industry experts explained, noting that PharmaTrac, a prescription sales tracking agency, does not audit small and medium units.

Over 60% of roughly 8,500 small and medium-sized pharma units were feared to face closure due to non-compliance with the revised Schedule M provisions of the Drugs and Cosmetics Rules, 1945.

The growth is also partly attributed to a GST cut on medicines from 12% to 5% in September last year.

Rajiv Juneja, MD at Mankind Pharma, told **ET** that while shares of smaller units may have shifted to bigger players, a key reason for the higher growth is better healthcare facilities and availability of tests and diagnosis of chronic diseases like diabetes and cardiac issues. "People are becoming conscious about their health. A strong demand is also seen in multivitamins and supplements like proteins and magnesium," he said.

Mankind Pharma posted close to a 15% rise in its sales for the September quarter at ₹3,657 crore while Torrent Pharma's domestic revenue vaulted by 20% to ₹2,181 crore. India's biggest drugmaker Sun Pharma reported a 17.3% increase in its domestic formulations sales to ₹5,552 crore during the same period. Its domestic business accounted for 34.5% of consolidated sales.

Amit Bakshi, managing director of Eris Lifesciences, which is among the leading players in anti-diabetes drugs, said growth came on category-building efforts in cardiovascular, diabetes, and chronic kidney disease segments. "The growth may reflect changes in how trade generics and smaller or untraceable companies are captured in market data, as well as greater scrutiny of spurious and duplicate drugs. These are possible explanations rather than individually established causes," he added.

Bakshi noted that the audit agency records prescription data without identifying companies and includes them in the 'untraceable' or 'others' category. "This category was around 12-13% at one point a few years ago, but the current figure needs to be checked. If these factors persist, they could support an additional 2-3 percentage points of structural growth," he said.

Vishal Manchanda, pharma sector specialist at Systematix, said the growth over the last four quarters is not broad-based. It is being driven largely by chronic therapies such as oncology, cardiology and diabetology, while segments such as anti-infectives are not showing much growth, he said.

"If you look at a few companies, the picture is different," Manchanda said. "Cipla reported 12% quarterly growth, but excluding the inorganic contribution, its growth would be around 6-8%."

Digi Yatra Trials for Intl Flyers Begin at Seven Airports; Full Rollout in 2027

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The Ministry of Civil aviation on Sunday said Digi Yatra trials for international passengers have started at seven airports and the wider rollout of the facility is expected in 2027.

It will be available on a trial basis for Indian nationals holding e-passports for select international flights of Air India and IndiGo.

Based on facial recognition technology, Digi Yatra provides for contactless and seamless movement of passengers at various checkpoints at airports. It is currently available at various domestic airports.

Trials cover Indian e-passport holders on select Air India, IndiGo international flights

The ministry said Digi Yatra trials for international passengers are being conducted at seven airports —Delhi, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Cochin, Mumbai, Chennai and Amritsar.

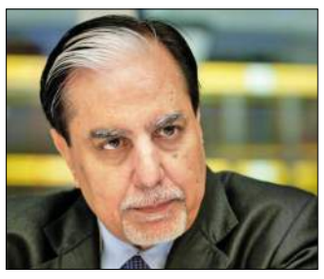
Feedback received during the trial period from November to December this year will be utilised for the planning of the wider rollout of the technology in 2027.

According to the ministry, the trials will allow eligible Indian nationals holding e-passports to use the Digi Yatra at designated airport touchpoints while travelling on select international flights operated by Air India and IndiGo.

"Eligible passengers will be able to use the facility at terminal entry points, Security Hold Areas (SHA) and boarding gates, wherever the required infrastructure is available," the ministry said.

ED Registers ECIR Against Chandra in LIC HFL Fraud

Our Bureau



Mumbai: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has initiated a case against Essel Group chairman Subhash Chandra in connection with an alleged ₹1,322 crore loan fraud involving LIC Housing Finance.

According to people familiar with the development, the ED filed an Enforcement Case Information Report (ECIR) against Chandra after the Central Bureau of Investigation registered an FIR against him and eight others.

The ECIR is an internal document at the ED to formally initiate an investigation, but is not mandatorily required to be shared with the accused. A predicate case filed by the police or other investigative agencies is a must for the ED to probe money laundering.

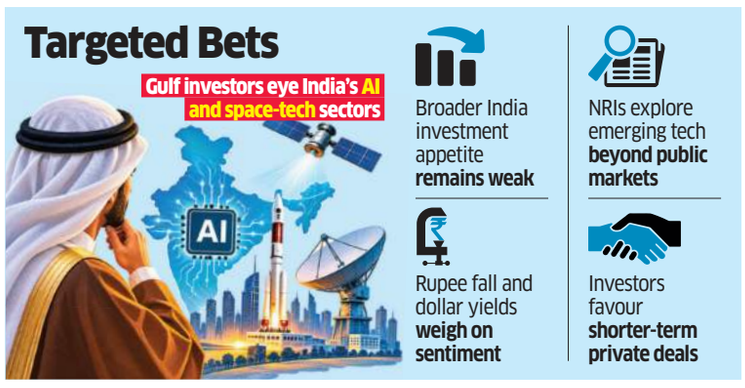
Zee Entertainment Enterprises, which is part of the Essel Group, said on Sunday that the ECIR related to Chandra in his personal capacity and certain promoter entities and had no bearing on the listed company's operations.

The CBI registered the FIR in August based on a complaint by LIC Housing Finance over two loan facilities aggregating ₹980 crore sanctioned in 2018 to four Essel Group-linked companies.

Gulf Investors Take a Liking for India with AI Infra, Space Tech on Radar

Selective interest in emerging tech sectors contrasts with a subdued appetite for Indian assets

Dilasha Seth



Dubai: Gulf-based investors, including the non-resident Indian diaspora, are selectively exploring opportunities in India's artificial intelligence (AI) infrastructure and space technology sectors, even as broader interest in Indian investments remains subdued amid currency depreciation and a shift towards dollar-denominated assets, according to wealth managers in the region.

Data centre operator Yotta, the Hiranandani Group company which is learnt to be making a $150-200 million pre-IPO fundraising, recently tapped the Gulf market and held a roadshow in Dubai earlier this month. "It was a very successful event with a great turnout of both NRI diaspora and local families," according to an industry source. The company is expecting $30-35 million worth of commitments from investors in the region, he said.

Yotta earlier this year raised $150 million at a valuation of $3.9 billion to fund expansion of its AI infrastructure. The company is expected to file its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) in the coming weeks with plans for a listing in the first quarter of 2027. It did not respond to queries emailed by ET.

The interest in Yotta comes as Gulf investors seek exposure to India's emerging technology businesses, even as wealth managers indicated limited appetite for broader Indian equity and private-market investments.

Pixxel Space Technologies, an Indian space technology startup, is also exploring fundraising opportunities in the UAE, as per ASK Wealth Advisors.

"We've seen a very strong investor appetite for AI play in India. The broader Indian market is extremely challenging right now. That's why the FCNR(B) window seemed very exciting, and a lot of money from the region flowed into it, while the broader Indian market continues to face headwinds," said Prateek Pant of DIFC-based ASK Wealth Advisors.

The Reserve Bank of India's special Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) (FCNR[B]) dollar deposits scheme mobilised about $133 billion by the window close on August 31. "Corporate earnings are not particularly bad; it is more a question of sentiment at the moment, driven partly by the rupee," Pant added.

The Indian rupee has depreciated by about 5.87% against the US dollar so far in 2026, moving from about 89.96 a dollar at the start of the year to around 95.24.

"Last year, there was much more interest in the Indian market, when investors were discovering the market and were considerably more excited. Until recently, activity had been subdued, though not completely absent," said Ashish Marwah, director and chief investment officer at Neovision Investment Fund Management in Abu Dhabi.

"Investors remain very interested in AI and technology. We manage funds that have investments from banks, and these investors are still very excited about the technology opportunity. But there is no broad-based interest in India yet," he added

Meanwhile, Bengaluru- and Los Angeles-headquartered Pixxel, a planetary infrastructure company, raised $100 million in a Series C round, co-led by Temasek and Seraphim, in September is learnt to be raising more capital.

"The NRI diaspora is increasingly interested in such opportunities, whereas traditionally, NRIs have largely invested in public markets. Emerging sectors are now becoming accessible to offshore investors through fund vehicles based in jurisdictions such as Mauritius," Pant said.

Investors tend to follow market momentum, and few are willing to commit capital at the bottom of a cycle, Marwah said. "Indian fund houses looking to raise money in the Gulf need to establish a presence and build relationships before sentiment improves, rather than expect immediate commitments", he said. "When market momentum picks up, that is the time to step up fundraising efforts, but it is important to have a presence in the market before that happens," Marwah said, adding that fund houses needed to take a medium- to long-term view.

The cautious approach is also reflected in investors' preference for dollar-denominated fixed-income assets. US dollar bonds are looking attractive, particularly for investors able to lock in yields of around 6.5%, Pant said.

"Many investors in the region have already invested heavily in real estate in Dubai. At the moment, however, confidence in real estate is low. That is prompting them to explore other asset classes and investment opportunities," said a wealth manager who did not wish to be named.

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Need Better Shelter From the Storms

Shorten the time to get back to normalcy

India experiences an average of 5 cyclones a year, of which 2 become severe cyclonic storms. There is a pattern to cyclonic activity with Bay of Bengal generating 4 for every 1 in Arabian Sea. Bay of Bengal has a shape and surface water temperature that favour formation and intensity of tropical cyclones. There is also a seasonality with frequency rising during April-June and October-December. This predictability, along with better detection and tracking, has improved India's cyclone response. Timely evacuation has significantly brought down fatalities. But there is wide scope to shorten the time it takes to get normal life post-storm.

Destruction can be reduced through a combination of structural engineering and environmental protection. Buildings have to be retrofitted to strengthen their hurricane-resistance structure. Utilities like electrical panels and generators must be protected against flooding. Sea walls, storm surge barriers and drainage channels need regular maintenance in low-lying areas. Mangrove belts that help slow down surface wind and waves have to be expanded to reduce coastal erosion. Community training must be regularised to practise rapid orderly evacuation. Local communities must be made part of capacity building. Restoration of livelihood involves timely provision of farm inputs, cash-for-work programmes in reconstruction, and wider access to subsidised credit.

The metric for disaster management is dynamic because climate change is impacting cyclonic activity. Global warming of ocean surface temperatures is putting populations at greater risk. Advances in satellite imaging and data analytics help predict origin, intensity, course and landfall of cyclones. But structural and environmental defences remain inadequate. Successive heatwaves the country is experiencing drive high-pressure systems called 'anticyclones' and work in tandem with tropical cyclones to form destructive weather patterns. This reduces cyclone predictability through atmospheric steering, timing shift and post-landfall hazard.

'Foreign Hand' or Not, Address the Concerns

CBI is probing alleged foreign funding of an Arunachal Pradesh activist, claiming that four overseas entities transferred ₹20.9 lakh to sustain protests against the Siang Upper Multipurpose and Dibang hydropower projects. Whether FCRA violations have occurred must, of course, be investigated. But to infer in all this that 'foreign money' explains opposition to a mega-dam risk obscures a more key question: why are local communities opposed to it?

Proposed in 2008-09, the 11,200 MW project has faced opposition from indigenous communities for nearly 2 decades. Their concerns go beyond displacement to the loss of ancestral land, livelihood, cultural identity and sacred sites. Estimates suggest that nearly 1.5 lakh people could be affected. Nor are fears about consequences of large hydropower projects in the Himalayas fanciful. Uttarakhand's 2021 flash floods devastated the Rishiganga hydel project and damaged the under-construction Tapovan-Vishnugad project. Nepal's devastating August floods buried a dozen hydropower plants, exposing the vulnerability of infra built pell-mell in fragile mountain valleys. These disasters do not establish that dams caused the floods. But they do show how dams can become destructive missiles when unleashed by raging floodwaters.

The Siang project also raises questions about rehabilitation, compensation, disaster preparedness and long-term security of downstream communities. These deserve transparent, credible answers, not knee-jerk conspiracy theories. A government confident of its development case should be confident of subjecting it to public scrutiny. Not every critic is an agent of a foreign hand. And even if foreign funding is found to be present, the concerns need to be answered, not eclipsed.

JUST IN JEST

Enough of bad foreign press about this energy-saving kitchen device

Enough of PC About Pressure Cookers

Few civilised instruments have suffered as much reputational damage outside India as the pressure cooker. To millions, it's the reassuring sound of a hot, cooked meal. To many nervous foreigners, it's an object best approached by a bomb-disposal squad. This is an extraordinary injustice to an appliance whose principal ambition is to turn obstinate lentils into dal. The PC is a triumph of applied physics, culinary efficiency and household economics. It saves time, fuel and patience. Its whistle is not a declaration of hostilities, but an announcement that succour is borne every few whish-es. Yet, outside the subcontinent, the cooker frequently acquires sinister associations of a suspicious package. By this logic, cars should be regarded primarily as getaway vehicles.

More troubling is the cultural dog whistle. An Indian harbouring a PC may send out non-existent signals about pressurising Western culinary traditions. This is rubbish. The difference lies less in engineering than in imagination, assisted by prejudice. Westerners — and West-aping Indians — should reconsider. Here is an invention that reduces energy consumption, accelerates productivity and delivers excellent returns on investment. Wall St should be putting its money where its lid is. The PC deserves not surveillance but a standing ovation. Ideally, after three whistles.

With G-sec yields rising, countries have no alternative but to increase their bullion holdings

INDIA, GO FOR GOLD!

Mythili Bhusnurmath

O mere sona re sona re sona re

When the Global Financial Crisis hit in 2008, RBI deputy governor Rakesh Mohan tried hard to rechristen the crisis as the 'North Atlantic Crisis' on the grounds that it was essentially a, well, North Atlantic crisis. But that crisis subsequently engulfed the world. All the talk of decoupling did nothing to save the rest of the world from the chaos that followed.

Likewise with the bond crisis now engulfing much of the advanced world. It's not often that developing countries like India can hold a candle to the developed world. The bond market is proving an exception. For a change, the developed world looks like it's drowning even as the developing world, particularly India, looks the picture of mature fiscal management. Why? The first core principle of the 1989 Washington Consensus — observe fiscal discipline — has been taken to heart by countries like India, while the West ignored it.

What is likely to be the effect of this? Will the developed world get away this time round? According to IMF, long-term sovereign yields have increased across several major advanced economies. Between February and September, G7's average 10-yr government bond yield increased by over 1 percentage point, reaching its highest level in nearly two decades.

Higher benchmark yields in major economies can also spill across borders, worsening debt dynamics elsewhere. Effects of rising yields on capital flows into India are already visible

In India, in contrast, yield on T-year G secs has increased by 0.4 percentage points over the same period. Unfortunately, governments are confronting these higher borrowing costs precisely at a time when debt is elevated, with global public debt expected to exceed 100% of GDP by 2030, a level last reached in the immediate aftermath of WW2.

But in India, total government borrowing is expected to remain at less than 100%. India's general government debt-to-GDP ratio stands at 81.8-83.5% when combining central and state government obligations. For GoI alone, it is expected to fall to the mid-50s. Though the number might change post-Trump tariffs and hike in international oil prices, it is nowhere near where Western governments now find their debt-GDP ratios.

Europe is where the danger of a debt crisis is real. The AI boom is raising its cost of capital. But, in contrast with the US, Europe is enjoying far less of a boost to economic growth. In the US, apart from the oil price shock and persistent inflation, there is now heightened competition between government and companies for capital as large AI companies borrow aggressively to fund their expansions.

The bottom line is there's no getting away from fiscal fundamentals. In major advanced economies, the combination of high debt, spending pressures and prospect of large bond issuance in the years ahead are putting upward pressure on yields investors demand to hold longer-term bonds.

The problem is higher benchmark yields in major economies can also spill across borders, worsening debt dynamics elsewhere. We've already seen the effect of rising yields on capital flows into India. And while schemes like FCNR(B) might buy time, they are expensive and all they do is buy time, nothing more.

But beyond immediate issue of implications for debt inflows as yields rise elsewhere, what does all this mean for deployment of our reserves? Remember, price moves in the opposite direction as yield. Sure, the US has the 'exorbitant privilege' of issuing debt in currency that the rest of the world still wants. But what is certain is that the world will have to invest its reserves in other instruments.

As of August 2026, India was 14th-largest holder of US treasuries (though India's holding of $219.7 bn was dwarfed by No. 1 holder Japan's $1,068 bn). But as worries about the US capacity to repay, without inviting inflation, mount, countries will have to look to other avenues.

What might these instruments be? It could be Chinese government bonds. But the lingering fear of China means this is likely to be a no-no. We've seen governments move away from investing in US treasuries and the higher yield is a measure of what the US has to pay to attract investor interest. Consider.

The yield on 10-yr US treasury rose by close to 4.7 percentage points during 2020-26, even as the yield on comparable T-bills in India's rose by about 1.4 percentage points. No wonder China's holdings of US treasuries fell to $659.3 bn in May 2026, down from $732.7 bn a year earlier. Likewise, RBI reduced India's holdings of US treasury securities to $181 bn in April 2026, marking a near-6-yr low and a sharp drop from $232 bn in April 2025.

In 2025, the market value of gold held in official reserves overtook the value of US treasuries held by central banks

So, what's the alternative? Gold.

According to World Gold Council in 2025, the market value of gold held in official reserves overtook the value of US treasuries held by central banks. Gold reserves in India averaged 544.18 t from 2000 to 2026, and reached an all-time high of 880.52 t in Q1 of 2026.

However, RBI has not added to its reserves since. But with yields on government bonds rising across the world, India, along with many countries in the world, will find there is no alternative but to invest in gold.

ChatGPT SHAIRI OF THE DAY

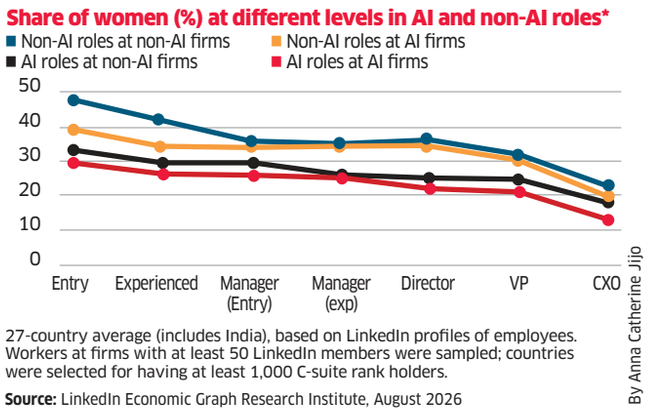
There once was a Donald called Trump,
Who feared that his ratings might slump.
'If the Democrats win,
It's electoral sin!'
And tomorrow democracy goes in the dump.

...

AI Brings A New Glass Ceiling

Women's representation in the budding AI economy is lower than even in conventional jobs. Senior positions in AI-related roles at AI companies have the lowest female presence: 21% at the vice-president level and just 13% at the CXO level. In comparison, non-AI roles at conventional firms had 23% women at CXO roles.

Share of women (%) at different levels in AI and non-AI roles*

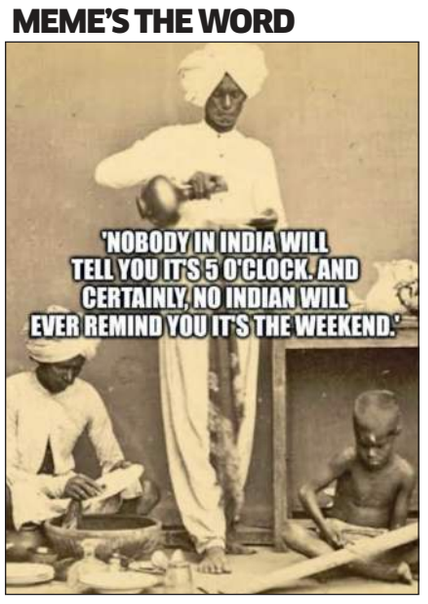


27-country average (includes India), based on LinkedIn profiles of employees. Workers at firms with at least 50 LinkedIn members were sampled; countries were selected for having at least 1,000 C-suite rank holders.

Source: LinkedIn Economic Graph Research Institute, August 2026

By Anna Catherine Jijo

MEME'S THE WORD



Tax-Wise, $-Foolish

P R Srinivasan

It's déjà vu all over again. Nifty and rupee are under pressure, FPIs are net sellers, and there's talk of tax cuts to stabilise markets. While band-aid solutions exclusively for listed markets have been tried in the past, India has evolved to a point where a listed market-only solution would impose significant long-term cost on the economy by damaging domestic risk capital and startup ecosystem.

A decade since Startup India's launch, India has over 2 lakh recognised startups, and nearly 125 unicorns. Domestic AIF commitments stand at ~₹16 lakh cr. Sidbi Fund of Funds for Startups (FFS) has committed ₹12,000 cr across 150 AIFs. SBI Caps Self-Reliant India (STI) fund has deployed ₹22,000 cr across 72 AIFs. The ₹1 lakh cr Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) scheme has made its initial allocations of ₹7,000 cr. Successive policy changes have permitted EPFO, NPS and insurers to invest in AIFs within prudent limits — pools so large that even small allocations represent significant long-term domestic institutional capital.

Entrepreneurs are no longer competing on labour arbitrage and price, but building companies that represent the frontier in deeptech and R&D-driven innovation. A generation of fund managers has grown alongside, pooling government capital with private capital, taking commercial risk, rather than administering a scheme. This ecosystem — ambitious founders, commercially-minded managers, co-invested public and private capital — is hard-won intangible infrastructure.

India's entrepreneurial successes of the last two decades were funded almost entirely by Mauritius-routed foreign capital. Without those funds, the entrepreneurship ecosystem would have been abysmal. With LTCG on listed equity at zero from 2004 to 2018, domestic investors sensibly preferred public markets, and private risk capital was ceded to Mauritius-routed foreign funds under the 1982 India-Mauritius DTA.

From the 1990s, the establishment welcomed foreign capital without questioning Mauritius substance, a position Supreme Court endorsed in 'Union of India v. Azadi Bachao Andolan' (2003). India exported the fund management industry in the 90s, and only in the last decade has it imported it back.

In 2017, the Mauritius treaty was closed for new investments, with grandfathering protecting prior investments — in the same spirit as the grandfathering that accompanied the 2018 reintroduction of LTCG on listed equity. Both were examples of the state honouring terms under which capital had been invested.

But the consensus in the establishment on grandfathering has broken with the recent judicial reversal in the Tiger Global case, the pledge by policymakers not to use Gaar, and invocation of Jaar by some tax officials. Given this history, a listed market-only solution, which will need to be closed later, would be an avoidable misstep.

Rationale for a tax cut is that global capital has choices, and Indian taxation lags Asian peers. But domestic capital has choices too. If rates are cut for listed shares only, listed exposure becomes more attractive than risk capital for every investor at once. Domestic HNIs will sensibly reallocate away from private markets. Even foreign capital may prefer listed companies and leave a gap in private markets. Indian entrepreneurship suffers.

AIF managers raise government anchor commitments but struggle to match them with private capital. Fund-raises stretch, fund sizes shrink, and next-gen fund managers can't launch.

If, instead, the FM cuts rates for listed shares only for FPIs, honest domestic capital feels like a hostage and a round-tripping arbitrage opens for the dishonest. Tax enforcement spends the next decade trying to catch evaders. Foreign capital also shifts focus to listed companies as a competitive low-tax route to private markets is not available.

There should be a universal cut — applied equally to listed and unlisted shares, and to foreign and domestic investors — which would address immediate pressure points without recreating wedges India has managed to close. If the FM wants to address foreign investor concerns specifically, they can be taxed on dollar gains rather than rupee gains, a proposal that compensates for a real economic asymmetry — only foreigners bear exchange rate risk.

A separate, complementary move would be to expand investment avenues for tax-exempt foreign pensions and sovereign funds beyond infrastructure. This wouldn't be a favour. These entities are tax-exempt in their home jurisdictions, and we would want the same treatment for EPFO and NPS whenever they invest abroad.

While competitive tax policy is required, the larger goal is for Indian policy to be perceived as calm waters, not rough seas. A fair policy ruthlessly enforced is necessary. An unfair policy with whimsical enforcement corrodes the social contract. The FM has an opportunity to signal that India's commitment to a vibrant risk-capital ecosystem is settled policy, and not something to be traded away for one cycle of foreign portfolio flows.

The writer is founder, Xponentia Capital

My advice? Stay slow & steady

MELODY FOR MONDAY

Mayonaise

The Smashing Pumpkins

There is something impossibly beautiful about The Smashing Pumpkins' 'Mayonaise' — spelt without the customary double n's — a song that seems to discover its own power, rather than summon it. From the band's magnificent 1993 album Siamese Dream, Billy Corgan's creation is a glory of musical architecture: delicate, bruised, incandescent, yet possessing the unforced grandeur of something occurring naturally, like a gathering storm.

Its opening guitar figures gives off strong whiffs of tenderness. Then the distortion arrives. James Iha's and Corgan's guitars swell, retreat, shimmer and roar, their extraordinary textures giving the song a breathing, hyperventilating quality. Jimmy Chamberlin's drumming provides muscular propulsion.

Corgan's lyrics are fragmentary, elusive, occasionally almost childlike — 'Cool enough to almost be it/ Cool enough to not quite see it/ Doomed./ Pick your pocket, full of sorrow/ And run away with me tomorrow/ June.' They tell us about the exhausting business of becoming oneself, and the desperate wish to be heard.

What makes 'Mayonaise' sublime is its refusal to distinguish fragility from strength. Its tremendous sonic force never overwhelms its tenderness. Rather, each makes the other possible. Few rock songs have made vulnerability sound so effortlessly, devastatingly enormous.

THE SPEAKING TREE

Technological Fasting

K V RAGHUPATHI

Our world is moving at a frantic speed, causing so much tension and stress in our lives. The mobile phone has almost become an extension of the human body. We talk while driving, listen while walking, watch videos while eating, scroll through shorts while waiting, and check notifications during conversations. Eventually, we are distancing ourselves from nature, human relations and everything else.

Technological fasting involves limiting the use of mobile devices and observing a nightly digital detox from 10 pm to 6 am. Reading on mobiles and browsing can be replaced by traditional reading of books. It includes being passionate about doing traditional works such as gardening, painting, playing music on instruments, or writing our memories without relying too much on technology. Engaging in these activities can foster a deeper connection to ourselves and our surroundings. We improve our mental health and cultivate our creativity with practical experiences, enjoying life in a more meaningful way. The purpose is not punishment but recovery of time, attention, silence, presence and creativity.

It also means returning to activities in which the hands, senses and imagination participate together. Taking long walks and observing nature around is an excellent antidote to our smartphones and their notifications constantly clamouring for our attention.

Chat Room

Discern Students' Class Struggle

Apropos the Edit, 'Institutions Need Fixing for Our Youth' (Oct 31), from Paris and London to New Delhi, young people share strikingly similar concerns: poor public services in schools and colleges, exorbitant fees, inflation and the rising cost of living. Their growing assertion, especially the voices of educated youth, is welcome, and digital media has enabled these concerns to travel far beyond local protests. Yet, rhetoric must now translate into tangible action. If institutions continue to ignore legitimate grievances, disillusionment may deepen into unrest and, in extreme cases, violent upheaval. Governments must ensure affordable, quality education; efficient public services; employment opportunities; and institutions that respond to citizens rather than merely manage dissent.

Nawal Thorat
Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

Regenerative Chatterbox

This refers to 'Hola Senior! Companionship has a Price' by Lijee Philip (Nov 1). India must awaken to the sunset years of an increasing share of its population. By treating ageing as an opportunity rather than a burden, India must build a sustainable, inclusive and economically vibrant ecosystem for its growing silver generation. Home healthcare, assisted living like companionship, physiotherapy, accessible housing, age-friendly transport, assistive technologies and lifelong learning can improve elderly lives, while creating dignified jobs for younger workers. Transforming care economy is an economic strategy waiting to be unlocked.

Pradeep Kumar
Surat

Cannot LMAO a Nation's Culture

Apropos 'Red Card for Maobappé from Mai-Bappé State' by Indrajit Hazra (Nov 1), Mbappé's joke on Mao was careless, and his apology was appropriate. However, the punishment that followed was a bit harsh, with China terminating brand partnerships, placing restrictions on social media and Spain's LaLiga broadcasts. This has turned a football meme into a diplomatic spectacle. Global stars cannot treat cultural and political sensitivities as harmless props for a joke, particularly in markets where their popularity sustains lucrative endorsements. A footballer's greatness should be measured by conduct as much as by goals scored.

Gregory Fernandes
Mumbai

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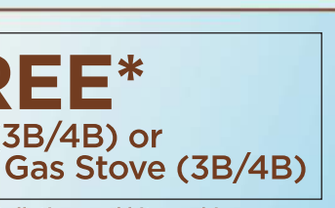

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Record Oct Sales to Brighten Motown's Diwali Celebrations

HIGH SPEED Car sales see double-digit growth; cos boost dispatches to meet fresh demand

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India's car sales likely rose in double digits to a monthly record in October, as manufacturers stepped up dispatches to dealerships ahead of the Dhanteras and Diwali festivals. Two-wheeler makers also posted strong growth, indicating demand from entry-level buyers this festive season. Replacement demand boosted sales of commercial vehicles.

According to initial industry estimates, 525,000-530,000 cars, utility vehicles and vans were dispatched from factories last month, a 13-14% increase from a year earlier. The previous record was 465,000 units reported in October 2025, when a reduction in goods and services tax had boosted demand. Maruti Suzuki, Mahindra & Mahindra, Hyundai Motor India and Kia India all posted record monthly sales in October. Market leader Maruti Suzuki reported a 21% increase, selling 212,384 vehicles in the domestic market in October.

"This is the highest-ever sales we have recorded in a month in the domestic market since inception. We have seen strong growth across categories, be it small cars or SUVs," said Partho Banerjee, senior executive officer (market and sales) at Maruti Suzuki.

Demand for Maruti Suzuki's CNG vehicles rose 40% from a year earlier. The company currently has pending bookings for 245,000 units and network stocks of 12 days. At Tata Motors, passenger vehicle sales volume increased 21% to 73,894 units last month. Rival Mahindra posted a 2% increase at 73,338 units.

The local unit of Korean auto major Hyundai, which recently launched a new model in the fast-growing mid-SUV segment, dispatched 62,799 units to domestic dealerships, registering 16.7% growth. Including exports, its sales grew about 18% to 82,299 units in October. "Strong festive demand, coupled with healthy momentum in both domestic and export markets, helped us set this new sales record," said Hyundai Motor India chief executive Tarun Garg.

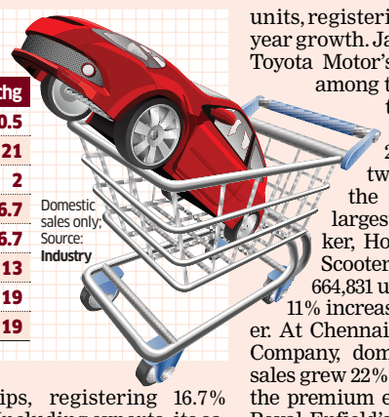
Kia India dispatched 33,462 units, registering 13.22% year-on-year growth. Japanese auto major Toyota Motor's Indian unit was among the few to buck the trend, reporting a 27% fall in sales to 29,521 units. In the two-wheeler market, the country's second largest two-wheeler maker, Honda Motorcycle & Scooter India (HMSI), sold 664,831 units last month, an 11% increase from a year earlier. At Chennai-based TVS Motor Company, domestic two-wheeler sales grew 22% at 514,764 units. At the premium end of the market, Royal Enfield's sales grew 4% to 121,527 units.

In commercial vehicle segment, market leader Tata Motors reported a 13% increase in dispatches to 39,784 units in October. Eicher-branded trucks and buses recorded sales of 9,676 units last month in India, up nearly 37% from a year earlier.

Fifth Gear

Company	Oct 2025	Oct 2026	% chg
Maruti Suzuki	176,318	212,384	20.5
Tata Motors PV	61,134	73,894	21
Mahindra & Mahindra	71,624	73,338	2
Hyundai Motor India	53,792	62,799	16.7
Toyota Kirloskar Motor	40,247	29,521	-26.7
Kia India	29,556	33,462	13
JSW MG Motor	6,734	8,013	19
Honda Cars India	6,394	7,609	19

Domestic sales only; Source: Industry



Electric Car Sales Double Amid Rising Fuel Prices

New Delhi: Sales of electric cars in the Indian market almost doubled from a year earlier to 35,777 units last month, according to vehicle registration data from the government's Vahan portal, indicating an increasing shift among consumers to electric amid high fuel prices. EV sales were 18,055 in the same month last year, as per vehicle registration data from the portal. EVs accounted for about 7% of total passenger vehicle sales in October, compared with 3.2% a year earlier. While the increase in fuel prices due to geopolitical tensions accelerated a customer shift to electric vehicles, sales also got additional support from improving charging infrastructure and launch of models across price points. Tata Motors retained its lead in the EV market with a 40.7% share in October. Mahindra had a 23.7% share, followed by JSW MG Motor India (16.4%), VinFast (7.2%) and Maruti Suzuki (3.3%). Electric car registrations in the first 10 months of the calendar year totalled 287,453 units. **—Sharmistha Mukherjee**

Chartistry

TRAVEL & TOURISM

Westward Ho!

THE HIGHLIGHT

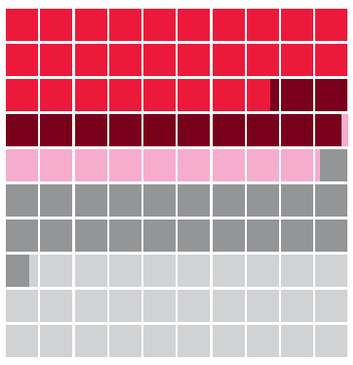
Unfazed by the war, West Asia is still the prime hotspot for outbound Indian travellers. Half of all Indians going on a foreign trip are headed to one of five countries in this region.

KEY NUMBER

40% of Indians' foreign trips were destined for the UAE and Saudi Arabia alone, even more than 37% in pre-war 2025.

Where Indian Travellers are Headed: Top 10 foreign destinations

Aug 2026, % of departures



- UAE **27.7**
- Saudi Arabia **12.1**
- Qatar, Kuwait, Oman **9.4**
- **WEST ASIA: 49.3**
- Thailand, USA, UK, Singapore, Malaysia **21.6**
- All other countries **29.1**

Chart guide: ■ 1 square = 1 in every 100 trips

Shares don't add up to 100 due to rounding off. Source: Ministry of Tourism
Data: Anna Catherine Jijo; Design: Samir Kumar

In A Nutshell

BYD Sales Rise 11% in Oct on Strong Exports

BEIJING Chinese electric vehicle maker BYD posted a sixth straight month of sales growth in October, relying on overseas markets to counter sluggish demand and intense price competition at home. Vehicle sales grew 11% from a year earlier to 490,168 units last month, cooling from a 17% gain in September, while overseas shipments rose 102.8% on year to 170,194 units, according to Reuters calculations based on a company disclosure on Sunday. **Reuters**

Xiaomi's October EV Deliveries Top 50k Units

BEIJING Chinese smartphone maker Xiaomi said it delivered more than 50,000 electric vehicles in October, highest monthly total this year, as it ramps up production to meet its 2026 target. Deliveries reached about 336,000 vehicles for first 10 months after topping 30,000 units in August and 40,000 in September. **Reuters**

Reliance Retail Expects Margins to Grow from Next Fiscal as Ecomm Bets Pay Off

Writankar Mukherjee

Kolkata: Reliance Retail expects its earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortisation (Ebitda) margins to improve from next fiscal year as investments in scaling up ecommerce operations begin to pay off, chief executive officer Jeyandran Venugopal said.

The country's largest retailer is ramping up investments in dark stores in large cities to enable 15-20-minute deliveries, while remodelling existing stores and warehouses to serve online customers. The spending has weighed on profitability over the past three quarters, with net profit either declining or growing marginally.

Speaking to analysts on Friday after the company reported its September-quarter results, Venugopal said the targeted improvement in operating Ebitda was realistic once the current investment phase was completed.

"Even though it may look very, very aggressive, it is not starting from zero. It is not a bootstrapping story. It is about how do we leverage our existing large asset base that we already have by doing these incremental investments, which are significant, but we get the high leverage effect once we do the investments on the existing base," he said.

Reliance Retail reported a 24.5% year-on-year decline in net profit in the September quarter, following a 14.2% drop in the June quarter. Profit had grown just 0.5% in the March quarter.

The company is accelerating its push into ecommerce and quick commerce as online platforms account for a growing share of sales across grocery, electronics and fashion. Its digital commerce business grew 42% year-on-year in the latest quarter, driven by higher average order values and a 24% increase in units per order at JioMart, its ecommerce and quick-commerce platform.

Venugopal said online growth across the industry was being fuelled partly by heavy spending on customer acquisition, coupons and discounts. Reliance Retail intends to pursue growth without matching competitors' spending indiscriminately—will do it on a much more "measured and meaningful way".

A Digital Shift

Existing stores & warehouses are being redesigned for online orders

JioMart's digital commerce business grew **42%** during September quarter

Reliance plans measured spending rather than matching competitors' discounts

Irdai to Weigh Feedback on Insurance Selling Fee

Shilpy Sinha

Mumbai: The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) will now evaluate stakeholder responses to its proposed overhaul of insurance commissions and distribution expenses, as the window for giving feedback closed on October 31.

The regulator had extended the deadline earlier by a week after receiving more than 650 responses to its September 23 consultation paper, which proposes tighter commission limits, changes to expense-of-management rules and a new distribution architecture.

The proposed commission caps could make parts of insurance distribution economically unviable

The industry is now awaiting the draft guidelines followed by the final framework.

Both insurers and intermediaries are expecting the new rules to take effect from April 2027, allowing time to prepare for changes to distribution arrangements and business models.

Irdai chairman Ajay Seth had told **ET** in an interview that he would like the framework to be implemented from either January or April. The final date will be decided after the regulator examines the feedback.

The consultation paper seeks to curb distribution costs and improve transparency by linking remuneration to the nature of products, distribution channels and the effort involved in selling them.

It also proposes reducing expense limits over a five-year period.

In case of credit life, commission will fall to 2% from the current 40%.

Stakeholders have raised concerns over loss of revenue and jobs following the implementation of the proposed rules, with brokers saying their revenue could fall by 60% if those were implemented in the current form.

According to brokers, the proposed commission caps could make parts of insurance distribution economically unviable.

Acquiring term insurance customers involves significant upfront costs, including technology, call centres and customer servicing, they say.

Online aggregators have warned that the proposed changes could reduce revenue economics to nearly a third or 40% of current levels.

PB Fintech, which runs the Policybazaar platform, said lower income could push distributors towards manufacturing or managing general agency models.

McDonald's India Steps Up Investments in North, East to Take on Competition

NEW NORMAL Co to spend $80 m for store expansion and widen its digital footprint

Ratna Bhushan

New Delhi: Quick service chain McDonald's India's north and east business has revised investments upwards to about $80 million over the next two-and-a-half years on store expansion and digitisation, to meet consumer demand, and as competition from rivals such as KFC operator Devyani International and Burger King heats up, though it expects profitability to remain under pressure amid surging food and packaging inflation.

"This will be our highest investment in a two-year period. Up till now, we have invested $175 million in the business, through our own family offices; future investments will also be funded internally from group companies," Sanjeev Agrawal, chairman of McDonald's India (North & East), told ET in an interview. The chain had previously said it would invest US close to $100 million over the next four years to accelerate its business.

The north and east business of McDonald's operated by Connaught Plaza Restaurants (CPRL), was acquired by MMG Group in 2020 from the Chicago-based McDonald's Corp after the latter's prolonged legal tussle with CPRL's previous head Vikram Bakshi.

Similar to dozens of consumer companies from Apple to Unilever which are betting on India as a key growth bastion when their headquarters are seeing continued slowing sales, McDonald's too is placing bets on key markets such as India.

At its September 2026 Investor Day, McDonald's global chief Chris Kempczinski announced an "$8.5 billion franchisee support package" to bet on growth in franchisee-led markets, while cautioning that customer traffic in its developed western markets would remain flat as long as inflation stays elevated.

He had noted that of the total commitment, $5 billion is allocated for franchisees by 2030, through a mix of rent relief and direct capital assistance. In its last reported earnings for the June '26 quarter, McDonald's has reported US sales increase of 0.8% year-on-year, with its international developmental licensed markets growing 1.9%. The India business operates as a developmental licensee.

Up till now, we have invested $175 m in business, through our own family offices; future investments will also be funded internally...

SANJEEV AGRAWAL, Chairman, McDonald's India (North & East)

FILE PHOTO

Agrawal said chain has not taken pricing now and continues to operate in value segment, though inflationary pressures have escalated over past year. "Due to West Asia crisis, profitability has been under stress with costs of oil, transportation, packaging—all up and have had a cascading effect," he said. "We were waiting for crisis to end; but the inflationary impact continues. We will be taking marginal price increases on select items which will not impact value-conscious consumers, because the prices are unsustainable."

CPRL expects to close FY27 with revenues of ₹2,000 crore, up from ₹1,695 crore in FY26, and 12% Ebitda, filings showed. It operates over 320 stores and expects to cross 500 stores by 2028, which will be a mix of drive-throughs, highway stores and at government-run fuel stations, Agrawal said.

Fairfax-Backed Maxop Engg Buys Majority Stake in Faith Automation

Mohit Bhalla

New Delhi: Fairfax-backed Maxop Engineering has bought a majority stake in Pune-based Faith Automation Systems and Tooling, a design and engineering firm that automates the production lines for vehicle manufacturers including Maruti Suzuki, Toyota and Tata Motors, the companies said in a joint statement. Industry experts pegged the enterprise value of the deal at ₹400-500 crore.

The companies did not disclose financial details of the transaction or the post-deal shareholding structure.

Faith manages every stage of a project, from process planning and mechanical design through robot programming, system integration and on-site commissioning. It has revenues of around ₹300 crore. Its clients include Honda, Mahindra & Mahindra and Stellantis.

Faith automates production lines for its customers like Maruti Suzuki, Toyota, Honda, M&M and others

The company's founding team led by Nilesh Pandhare and six of his colleagues previously worked at Italian firm Comau, which was part of Stellantis.

Maxop Engineering makes aluminium die cast components for the automobiles, electrical and consumer engineering sectors. Fairfax India Holdings Corporation had acquired a 67% stake in Maxop Engineering in 2021.

The company is helmed by Shailesh Arora. The acquisition is expected to help Maxop and Faith Automation tap synergies such as expanding solutions to existing customers and bringing in new customers.

"Our robotics and systems-integration expertise will be expanded to industrial segments such as warehousing and logistics automation, heavy engineering, FMCG manufacturing and electrical equipment production," said Pandhare, managing director of Faith Automation Systems and Tooling.

ON THE ROCKS

AB InBev Sets Aside $30m in Unpaid Dues

Dues from Telangana highlight financial risks for cos operating in controlled markets

Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: Anheuser-Busch InBev, the world's largest brewer, has set aside $30 million against outstanding payments from the Telangana government, highlighting the financial risks of operating in India's state-controlled alcohol market, where delayed payments and restrictions on price increases are squeezing brewers.

The disclosure comes amid wider industry concerns over nearly $400 million Telangana owes to alcohol companies in dues. Industry groups have accused the state of breaching accounting rules over the outstanding payments.

Under the state's system, liquor companies supply products to government-run depots, which then distribute them to retailers, leaving manufacturers dependent on the government for payments.

Telangana is one of India's biggest beer-consuming states by volume. AB InBev chief financial officer Bernardo Novick said the company's total receivables from Telangana had remained relatively stable during the year, but some payments had been outstanding for an extended period.

"We decided to recognise this provision of $30 million," Novick said during the company's earnings call, adding that the brewer was making its best efforts to recover the outstanding amount and protect shareholders.

OVERALL PENDING SUM

Disclosure comes amid wider industry concerns over nearly $400 m in dues owed by Telangana to alcohol companies

The company does not expect further meaningful one-off provisions from the situation, Novick said, while cautioning that circumstances could change.

The problem extends beyond AB InBev. United Breweries, which controls about half of India's beer market, had temporarily halted supplies to Telangana Beverages Corporation about a year ago because of operating losses and overdue payments. The brewer had said selling each beer at a loss had made continued operations in the state unsustainable, while substantial delays in payments for supplies to the state corporation had further complicated the situation.

Last week, United Breweries managing director Vivek Gupta said the company's business in Telangana had remained flat and it had lost some market share as a competitor continued to spend.

He said the company was reluctant to commit more capital until the state addressed pricing issues. "Till that pricing happens, it is very difficult to make more investments and also make investments which don't really drive the category expansion," he said.

Telangana is United Breweries' largest volume market. Gupta said the company would not chase market share there at the expense of profitability. "We are okay to lose share in Telangana if it is a question of buying shares to show very good numbers," he said.

Mass Brands Give Liquor Cos a Hangover

Overall volume sales growth slows to 4.6% in Sept qtr, premium end of the mkt expands 5.7%

Sagar Malviya & Aanya Thakur

Mumbai: Growth in India's spirits market slowed to 4.6% year-on-year by volume in the September quarter from 6.4% a year earlier, with the weakness more pronounced in the mass-market segment that is particularly vulnerable to inflation, officials said citing excise data.

Industry executives said the slowdown for the second consecutive quarter is difficult to explain in certain states.

"It is difficult to pinpoint the reasons for the slowdown, even in states such as Uttar Pradesh which had recorded strong growth earlier," said Amar Sinha, managing director of Allied Blenders and Distillers (ABD), maker of Officer's Choice whisky. There are "no clear factors explaining the weakness," he said. Prestige and above (premium) spirits grew 5.7% in the September quarter, while regular and other (mass) spirits expanded 3.7%. The overall market growth was higher than the 3% recorded in the preceding quarter. India's alcohol market remains heavily skewed toward lower-priced products. The country has more than 1.4 billion people, but its drinking population is estimated at around 300 million, with nearly half consuming low-cost or unbranded liquor, industry executives said.

"With the prolonged and continuing West Asia crisis, softer monsoons and inflation, consumer sentiment is not very upbeat," said Praveen Someshwar, managing director of United Spirits, the country's largest liquor company. "Rural may not have fully absorbed the impact of the weaker monsoon yet, but the bottom end of the urban consumer is feeling the inflationary pressure," he said.

Lower-income consumers, who form the target audience for the lower half of United Spirits' portfolio, are showing signs of fatigue as inflation squeezes household budgets, while middle- and higher-income consumers fare better, Someshwar said.

The company's prestige and above net sales value grew 6.3% in the quarter, compared with 12.7% a year earlier. It also said its popular segment faced policy-related headwinds in Maharashtra and Karnataka.

ABD posted an 11.1% increase in volumes to 10 million cases.

The market's premium end has been more resilient, although growth has moderated.

Radico Khaitan's total Indian-made foreign liquor volumes rose 7% to more than 10 million cases, with prestige and above volumes increasing 36%, managing director Abhishek Khaitan said. Mass-segment volumes, however, declined 15%.

"Regular volume degrowth was due to a higher base in quarter two of last year after the change in route to the market in the state of Andhra Pradesh and the impact of policy changes in Maharashtra and Karnataka," Khaitan said.

The timing of festivals also affected demand comparisons, with companies saying the festive season was later this year compared to the previous year. October-December is expected to capture the full festive demand, they said.

In Moderation

- Policy changes affected popular spirits in Maharashtra & Karnataka
- Later festivals weakened y-o-y comparisons during the quarter
- Higher packaging, energy, logistics, and input costs pressured margins
- State pricing controls limited cos' ability to recover costs

PM to Meet Niti Aayog Leadership on Nov 5

Modi is likely to hear sectoral priorities and review think tank's work as govt begins shaping the FY28 Budget

Yogima Seth

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi is set to meet Niti Aayog's new leadership on November 5, as the government begins shaping priorities for the 2027-28 Budget amid global uncertainty and the need to sustain growth, boost manufacturing and create jobs.

The meeting comes as India seeks to strengthen domestic manufacturing, improve infrastructure and expand employment opportunities amid rising geopolitical uncertainty. The prime minister is the chairman of the Aayog.

Niti Aayog vice chairman Ashok Lahiri, CEO Anurag Jain and members Rajiv Gauba, R Balasubramaniam, Joram Aniya, KV Raju, M Srinivas, Gobardhan Das and Abhay Karandikar are expected to attend, along with other senior officials of the Aayog.

The meeting comes as India seeks to boost domestic manufacturing, improve infrastructure and expand employment opportunities

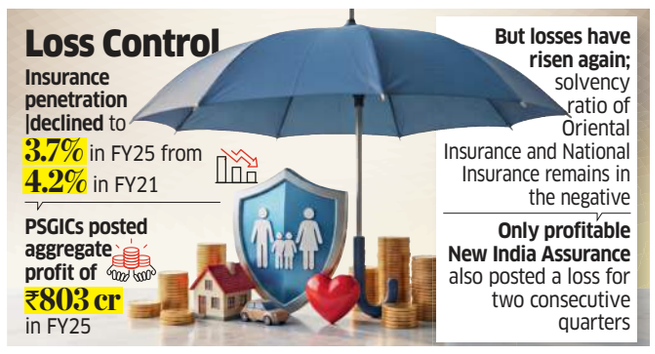
People aware of the development said the prime minister is expected to hear from sectoral experts appointed as members of the Aayog to understand key developments and requirements in their respective sectors, in line with India's vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047.

He is also expected to review the Aayog's work in relation to the country's long-term development objectives. The visit is unusual to meet officials, though the prime minister has regularly visited the Aayog in the past to chair the annual meeting of its governing council or meet economists ahead of the Budget for macroeconomic deliberations.

The interaction is expected to underline the importance of Niti Aayog's role in bringing together policy research, institutional coordination and strategic planning to address India's evolving economic and developmental challenges.

Niti Aayog, which replaced the Planning Commission in January 2015, is the government's principal policy think tank. It works with central ministries, state governments and other stakeholders to develop strategies for inclusive and sustainable development, while promoting cooperative federalism.

State-run General Insurers to Submit Turnaround Plans



Dheeraj Tiwari

New Delhi: State-run general insurers will submit board-approved plans to the government detailing how they will scale back or exit unprofitable business segments, according to people familiar with the development, as mounting losses in the sector add to pressure for an overhaul.

New India Assurance, the only state-owned general insurance company to have remained profitable, last week reported a net loss of ₹1,267 crore in the second quarter of FY27. It had recorded a profit of ₹63 crore a year ago. The insurer had posted a loss of ₹256 crore in the first quarter.

In August, a parliamentary standing committee had recommended that the government should prepare a time-bound road map for these companies to achieve organic solvency and move away from perpetual reliance on accounting adjustments or emergency capital infusions.

The executives cited earlier told ET that the government will evaluate the performance of the four general insurance public sector companies (GIPSA) on parameters specified in the road map, which also include improving underwriting capacity, improvement in technology and organisational restructuring.

"Some verticals, including government health schemes, need sensible pricing, tighter claims oversight and properly structured reinsurance, rather than leaving excessive risk on the companies' own books," said one of the executives, requesting not to be named.

Another executive said there is a need to find more linkages between the state-run banks and insurers, including retail products. "Property claims need independent scrutiny to tackle leakage. At the same time, capital and solvency training must reach branch and regional managers, not remain confined to the head office," he said.

The solvency ratio of three public sector general insurers — Oriental Insurance Company Ltd, United India Insurance Company Ltd., and National Insurance Company Ltd. — has remained below the prescribed norms. As per the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), all insurance companies need to always maintain a surplus of 1.5 times their liability. The solvency margin — the minimum margin of assets required by an insurer above its liabilities — is akin to a bank's capital ratio.

In September, the government had reviewed the financial and business performance of the state-owned general insurers for FY26, covering underwriting performance across all lines of business, key performance indicators, digital initiatives and other operational issues.

The finance ministry had said that insurers were asked to strengthen their focus on profitable lines of business and adopt suitable measures to bring down the incurred claim ratio (ICR). Performance monitoring is already conducted through a robust and standardised KPI framework across state-owned general insurers, said a government official, adding that capital requirements are reviewed on a quarterly basis, with any decisions regarding capital hinging on these parameters.

The parliamentary standing committee had also recommended that state-run insurers should aggressively scale up AI-powered assessments and 360-degree digital inspections for motor and property insurance to curb the high loss ratios due to fraudulent claims.

Solar Module Cos Seek More Time to Comply With Local Sourcing

Shilpa Samant

New Delhi: A group of solar module manufacturers have raised concerns over the availability of domestic cells and asked for an extension of the deadline to implement compulsory local sourcing of cells beyond January, people aware of the development said.

In a representation made to the Niti Aayog, the Renewable Energy Manufacturers Association of India, which represents non-integrated module manufacturers having a nameplate capacity of 160 GW, said local module capacity had outrun compliant cell supply and module-only manufacturers were carrying the cost.

Local sourcing rules, which seek to support domestic manufacturing, require procurement of equipment and components for solar projects from a list of approved domestic suppliers. The renewable energy ministry's Approved List of Models and Manufacturers (ALMM) List-II came into effect on June 1 this year. The list requires the use of solar cells, for making modules, from approved manufacturers in projects covered by the mandate.

For major projects, the deadline to comply with the rules was extended to December from June. The requirement was notified in December 2024, giving manufacturers and project developers time to prepare. In May, the ministry ruled out a blanket extension of the June 1 deadline but allowed project developers to seek case-specific relief.

Subsequently, in July, the government extended the exemption for net-metering and open-access renewable energy projects until December. The extension did not change the June 1 implementation date for ALMM List-II, which continues to apply to other projects covered by the mandate. The 'only module' makers now want this deadline to be extended till 2027 December, said one of the persons.

The module-only makers have now raised the issue of the gap between module making and the corresponding cells capacity. The industry body, which was earlier called the All India Solar Manufacturers Association, is seeking a time-bound and availability-linked bridge for this. There is 95 GW of producible TOPCon module capacity against 15.8 GW of enlisted TOPCon cells, the association said. It also pointed out that only under 2% of producible TOPCon module capacity was available in the open market while the rest were used in-house by integrated groups.

TOPCon technology now accounts for around 75% of global crystalline silicon solar cell production.

SIMPLIFYING THE RULES OF BUSINESS

CII Calls for GST-like Reforms in Land, Labour & Local Approvals

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The Centre and states should extend the approach adopted by the Goods and Services Tax Council in decriminalising certain GST offences to areas such as land, labour, construction and local approvals to reduce compliance costs and accelerate investments, industry body CII said.

The Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) said the GST Council's decisions at its October 8 meeting marked a shift towards trust-based governance and demonstrated how the Centre and states could overcome differences to deliver institutional reforms through consultation and consensus.

The next phase of reforms, it said, should focus on simplifying land-use regulations, speeding up construction permissions, streamlining labour administration, facilitating utility connections and reducing the multiplicity of local regulatory approvals – areas that constrain investment, manufacturing and enterprise growth.

Businesses often face overlapping requirements, multiple authorities and inconsistent procedures across states, adding to project costs and implementation timelines, it noted. "The GST Council has demonstrated that difficult institutional reforms can be achieved when the Centre and states agree on common objectives and work together to deliver them," said Chandrajit Banerjee, director general of CII. "We need similar coordination and reform commitment across land, labour, construction, utilities and local permissions to improve the ease, cost and speed of doing business."

The GST reforms included raising the prosecution threshold fivefold, from ₹1 crore to ₹5 crore, narrowing specified offences under Section 132 of the CGST Act, rationalising imprisonment provisions and removing arrest powers through the proposed omission of Section 69. The changes require legislative amendments for implementation.

CII said the measures would reduce uncertainty, legal costs and reputational risks for businesses, particularly MSMEs and first-generation entrepreneurs, while preserving criminal action against deliberate fraud and evasion. The clarification and circulars on registration, notices and adjudication, following the decision, offer greater clarity in tax administration and evidence-based treatment of fraud allegations, it said.

Industry body asks businesses to bolster internal controls, documentation and voluntary compliance as regulation becomes more trust-based

These, along with measures on refunds, input tax credit and compliance simplification, could improve working capital efficiency and reduce avoidable disputes. CII said the GST Council's experience offered a framework for the next generation of reforms, where the challenge would increasingly lie in aligning policies and administrative processes across different tiers of government.

It also called on industry to match the shift towards trust-based regulation with stronger internal controls, documentation and voluntary compliance, particularly among MSMEs.

THE ECONOMIC TIMES | BUSINESS VERTICALS

TECH500

27 November, 2026 | Grand Hyatt, Mumbai

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EXTRACT OF THE STATEMENT OF THE UN-AUDITED STANDALONE & CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND HALF YEAR ENDED SEPTEMBER, 2026

Rs. Millions

PARTICULARS	STANDALONE			CONSOLIDATED		
	Quarter Ended		Half Year Ended	Quarter Ended		Half Year Ended
	30.09.2026 (Un-audited)	30.09.2025 (Un-audited)	30.09.2026 (Un-audited)	30.09.2026 (Un-audited)	30.09.2025 (Un-audited)	30.09.2026 (Audited)
Revenue from Operation	5945.51	3421.11	8587.91	8081.73	5334.46	13635.37
Profit before tax (PBT)	782.63	824.26	1355.06	1303.39	955.86	2119.68
Profit after tax (PAT)	582.44	615.24	1007.58	972.81	678.64	1597.86
Total Comprehensive Income	584.30	614.95	1008.92	975.70	677.14	1598.34
Equity Share Capital	431.70	356.88	431.70	431.70	356.88	431.70
Total Equity (Excluding NCI)	431.70	356.88	431.70	431.70	356.88	431.70
Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 2/- each) Basic	2.70	3.45	4.67	4.35	3.59	7.19
Diluted	2.70	3.45	4.67	4.35	3.59	7.19

Notes:

The above are extracts of the Unaudited Consolidated and Standalone Financial Results for the Quarter and half year ended September 30, 2026, which have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on October 31, 2026, subjected to review by the Statutory Auditors, and filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended. The full format of the aforesaid Financial Results are available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges (i.e., www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and also on the website of the Company (www.pacedigitek.com).The same can also be accessed by scanning the following Quick Response (QR) Code from compatible devices:

Date: October 31, 2026
Place: Bengaluru
www.pacedigitek.com

For PACE DIGITEK LIMITED
[Formerly known as Pace Digitek Private Limited and Pace Digitek Infra Private Limited]
Meghana M P
Sd/-
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer
Membership No.: A42534

H1 FY27 Results Snapshot

Revenue from Operations: Rs. 13,635 Mn ▲ 51.4% YoY

Rs. 10,876 Mn 79.8% Energy Revenue Contribution

Rs. 2,759 Mn 20.2% Telecom Revenue Contribution

EBITDA: Rs. 2,447 Mn ▲ 40.5% YoY | Margin: 17.9%

PAT: Rs. 1,598 Mn ▲ 30.4% YoY | Margin: 11.7%

Balance Sheet & Returns

Net Debt / Equity: 0.35x

ROCE 12.6%

ROE 13.2%

Operational Highlights

BESS Commissioned: 875 MWh

BESS Manufacturing Output in H1 FY27: 844 MWh

Expanded Manufacturing Capacity to 5 GWh in H1 FY27: 2.5 → 5 GWh

H1 FY27 Order Inflows: Rs. 24,374 Mn

Executable Order Book: Rs. 107,353 Mn (As at 30 Sep, 2026)

End-to-End Infrastructure Platform : Design → Manufacture → EPC → BOO → O&M

PACE DIGITEK LIMITED

(Formerly Know Formerly Known As Pace Digitek Private Limited and Pace Digitek Infra Private Limited)
CIN: L31909KA2007PLC041949, Plot # V 12, Industrial Estate, Kumbalgodu, Bengaluru Mysore Highway, Bengaluru, Karnataka - 560074
Email: complianceofficer@pacedigitek.com;
www.pacedigitek.com

READYING FOR A POSSIBLE DEMOCRAT TAKEOVER

Don Veto's Way White House Looks to Advance Agenda by Executive Power if Cong Turns Blue

Democrats need net gain of four seats in both Houses to overturn Republicans' narrow majorities

President Donald Trump's White House has spent months preparing for a possible Democratic takeover of Congress, developing plans to keep advancing major parts of his agenda through executive power while bracing for investigations of his administration, according to a White House official and two people familiar with the plans.

Senior officials, including deputy chief of staff Stephen Miller and budget director Russell Vought, have been working with the White House Counsel's Office since April to identify executive actions on immigration, tariffs, housing costs and federal spending that Trump could pursue without congressional approval, said the three people, who spoke on the condition of anonymity.

White House counsel Will Scharf and his team also are looking at "what Trump can legally do on his own, where he could push the limits of his authority and how to defend those decisions in court,"the White House official said.

The planning underscores a paradox of Tuesday's midterm elections: Capturing control of Congress would give Democrats the power to investigate Trump, block legislation and constrain his spending priorities. But Trump would retain broad executive authority over trade, foreign policy and the federal bureaucracy that he has already used aggressively during his second term.

If Republicans lose control of Congress, Trump said he expects he could issue vetoes for "a month or two" before reaching compromises . "I guess I'll become Mr. Veto," Trump told the New York Post's Pod Force One podcast in an interview excerpt released on Sunday. "And then at some point, we'll probably make deals."

Democrats need a net gain of four seats in the US House of Representatives as well as the US Senate to overturn Republicans' narrow 218-214 and 53-47 majorities. Opinion polls favor Democrats to win the House, while the Senate remains too close to call. For the past month, Trump has held rallies across the country trying to preserve Republican control of Congress, even as his aides privately prepare for a very different political landscape in 2027.

The White House pushed back on the prospect of Republican losses and accused the media of promoting a false narrative. Among the executive actions under consideration are new tariffs on imports of critical minerals and wind turbines, tighter rules on visas for international students and temporary foreign workers, and measures aimed at lowering housing and construction costs.

CALIFORNIA GOVERNOR WARNS

California Governor Gavin Newsom on Saturday warned federal courts to be ready for potential attempts by President Donald Trump's administration to seize ballots during the upcoming midterm elections.

Newsom, a Democrat, sent the warning letter to federal judges as the state's legal fight with the administration, which demanded records from California as part of a criminal investigation into noncitizen voting. On Friday, a US appeals court rejected the administration's bid, potentially setting up a showdown at the US Supreme Court. **Reuters**

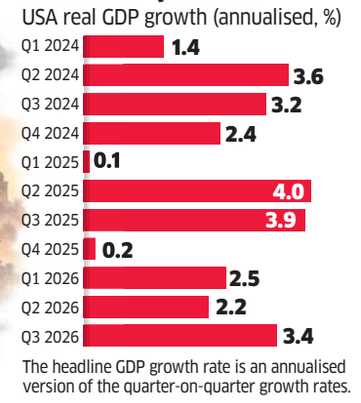
TRUMP'S TEST

A Mixed Report Card Before Midterms

The November 3 midterm elections in the US are being billed as a referendum on President Donald Trump's manner of governance and the war he has waged on Iran this year. A setback could derail his agenda in the Congress. While economic growth data is flashing green, energy inflation and the domestic impact of tariffs could be dampeners. Anna Catherine Jijo looks at the US' economic report card and Trump's dwindling approval ratings.

GDP GROWTH PICKED UP PACE IN SEP QUARTER...

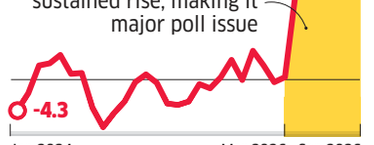
USA real GDP growth (annualised, %)



The headline GDP growth rate is an annualised version of the quarter-on-quarter growth rates.

...BUT SURGING INFLATION, ESPECIALLY ENERGY PRICES, COULD BITE TRUMP

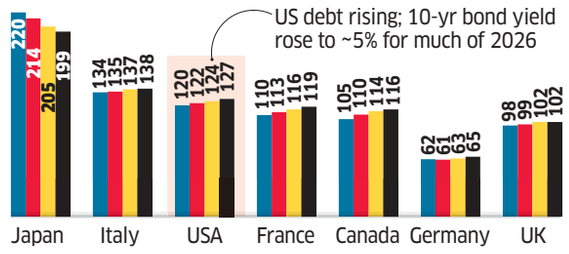
Energy price inflation, Y-o-Y (%)



Data for Oct 2025 not available.

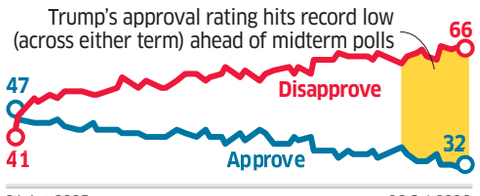
US REMAINS THE 3RD MOST INDEBTED G7 ECONOMY

General govt debt as a percentage of GDP, G7 countries



TRUMP'S APPROVAL RATINGS TANK THROUGH THE MONTHS

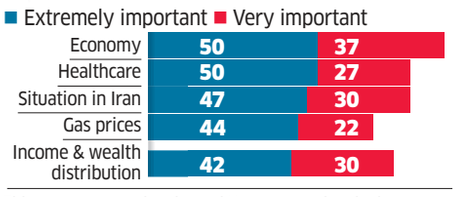
US voters' ratings for Donald Trump (%)



The survey was conducted online, and got responses from 1,679 US adults, with a margin of error of 2 percentage points.

ECONOMY WILL BE CRITICAL TO VOTERS' CHOICE

Share (%) of voters who said these issues are important for them in the 2026 midterms



This survey covered registered US voters and took place during Oct 1-19, 2026.

Source: US Bureau of Labor Statistics, Bureau of Economic Analysis, US Census Bureau, International Monetary Fund, Reuters/Ipsos Poll, Gallup

GRAPHIC: SAMIR KUMAR

POTUS: Bolsonaro Can Stay in US 'As Long as He Wants'

President Donald Trump said on Saturday evening that defeated Brazilian presidential candidate Flavio Bolsonaro can stay in the United States indefinitely.

The comments, made to reporters during a Halloween party at Trump's Mar-a-Lago club in Florida, suggest that relations between the Western Hemisphere's two largest democracies may remain strained for some time, even as US Secretary of State Marco Rubio spoke with Brazil's top diplomat earlier in the day.

"He can stay here as long as he wants," Trump said of Bolsonaro, who left Brazil after losing the election to leftist incumbent Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, despite leading in most opinion polls. "In my opinion, the election was a disgrace." The Brazilian embassy in Washington did not immediately return a request for comment.

Outside observers described the election as free and fair. **Reuters**

WSJ Wins Dismissal of $10b Defamation Suit

A federal judge threw out Donald Trump's renewed $10 billion defamation lawsuit against the Wall Street Journal and ruled that it can't be filed again, marking another setback for the president's legal fights with the press. Judge Darrin Gayles in Miami on Saturday granted the Journal's request to dismiss the suit. The newspaper was accused in the complaint of defaming Trump in an article saying that Trump once sent a suggestive birthday letter to the disgraced financier Jeffrey Epstein. Gayles had first tossed the suit in April for lacking evidence. **Bloomberg**

Prediction Mkt Bettors Meet Voters for a Midterms Edge

In the weeks leading up to the US midterms, a small group of prediction markets traders took field trips to Maine and Los Angeles, then reconvened online to pore over polls and early voter data out of Brazil, Israel and Texas.

They were hunting for scraps of intelligence about the voting public that might help them make more profitable bets on Kalshi and Polymarket, where they rank among the most successful traders wagering on the outcomes of the electoral races playing out across the country and the world.

The legwork has paid off so far. Douglas Campbell, a 46-year-old former economics professor and elections modeler for the Democratic National Committee, is the sixth most-profitable election trader on Kalshi, where he goes by the username AlexanderHam and has made over $800,000 of profits, according to his profile on the platform. There are, though, plenty of misses, like the $10,000 hit he took during the recent Israeli election.

Another trader who was in Maine and Los Angeles with Campbell, David Bensoussan, spends most of his time on Polymarket, where he has pulled in more than $1.5 million in profits under his main screen name Scottilicious. **Bloomberg**

TRUMP SAYS YET TO 'TAKE CARE OF' ONE OR TWO TARGETS IN IRAN

Tehran's Negotiators in Doha to Continue talks to End W Asia War

While talks continue for third consecutive day, both parties haven't ruled out more attacks

Iranian negotiators were in Doha on Sunday for a third consecutive day of talks with Qatari mediators aimed at pushing for a deal to end the US-Israeli war on Iran, according to an official briefed on this.

The talks come amid concerns that the conflict could escalate again after the November 3 US midterm elections. President Donald Trump has said the United States will not launch new attacks on Iran before the vote and that talks with Tehran have been productive, though he has not ruled out further military action thereafter. respond to any new attacks by striking US and Israeli targets in neighbouring countries.

US's PENDING TARGETS

President Donald Trump said on Saturday that the United States has knocked out much of Iran's military but still has to "take care of" one or two targets, as Tehran warned of reprisals if attacked.

Iran warned on Sunday that any renewed war with the United States could last longer than the previous round of fighting, after President Trump said he still had to "take care" of more targets.

OPEC+KEEPS DEC OUTPUT STEADY

OPEC+ oil-producing countries kept December production targets steady on Sunday, confirming expectations that more policy adjustments will not occur until next year, as the group continues to struggle with export disruptions from the Iran war.

OPEC+ oil-producing countries kept December production targets steady, confirming expectations that more policy adjustments will not occur until next year. **Agencies**

Crypto Heist Binance Covers 95% Tokens, Resumes Withdrawals

Binance, the world's biggest cryptocurrency exchange, resumed bitcoin, ether and some stablecoin withdrawals on Sunday and said others would follow in phases, after it covered 95% of the $6.3 billion in tokens stolen from its platform.

The heist, which the FBI has tied to North Korea and analysts believe may be the biggest financial robbery ever, adds to a string of recent crypto thefts. Last year, attackers stole $2.9 billion worth of cryptocurrency across nearly 150 attacks, according to researchers at TRM Labs. Binance, which was founded in China, said the first phase of withdrawals would cover 15 crypto assets including bitcoin, ether, XRP and dogecoin. Bitcoin withdrawals resumed shortly after 11:30 AM , while ether, BNB and some USDT and USDC stablecoin withdrawals were also restored.

Binance said it had covered $6 billion of stolen cryptocurrencies by using company money to buy replacement tokens. The remaining 5% of stolen tokens consist of assets that are less liquid and may take longer to source in the required amounts, according to the exchange. The FBI said on Saturday that the North Korean state-sponsored unit known as TraderTraitor was responsible for the attack.

Pyongyang has for years denied using state-linked cyber units for espionage, financial theft and revenue. Its mission in Geneva and embassy in China did not respond to requests for comment. **Bloomberg**

REUTERS

Now GenZ Takes to Streets in Germany

A group called "Gen Z regelt" (Gen Z sorts things out) called for demonstrations in Germany "for education, health, climate protection and an affordable life". The mass protests erupted in violence as night fell and rioters faced off against police in Frankfurt, Cologne, Hamburg and Berlin.

AIramco: Oil Firm Takes 49% in Saudi AI co

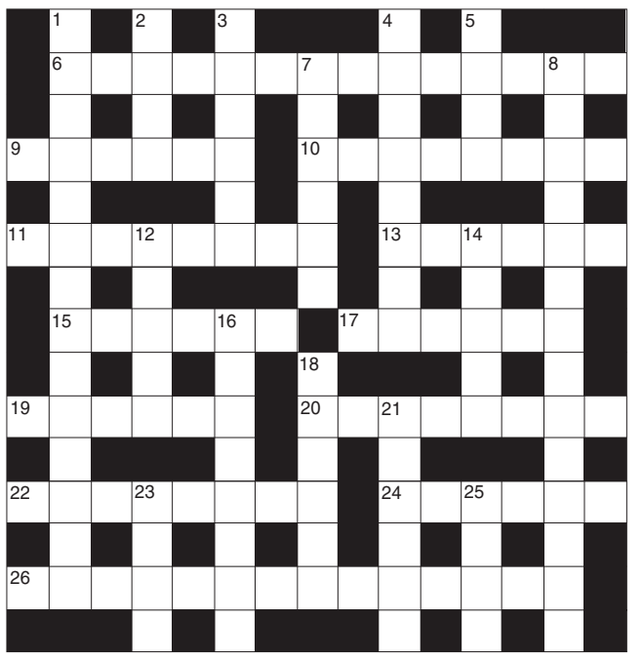
Oil major Saudi Aramco said it was taking a 49 percent stake in state-backed AI company Humain on Sunday, injecting cash and assets as the tech firm tries to scale up to meet rising demand.

The Public Investment Fund, the Saudi sovereign wealth fund driving economic diversification efforts, will retain the other 51 percent, they said in a joint statement.

Aramco, cornerstone of the oil-reliant Saudi economy, has been planning a significant minority stake for at least a year in Humain, which launched in May 2025.

"The transaction will further accelerate Humain's growth and advance its full range of AI capabilities globally, with PIF and Aramco contributing AI assets, capabilities, and talent," the statement said. Humain is planning to deploy three gigawatts of AI data centre capacity by 2030. **AFP**

Crossword 9745



ACROSS

6 Canadians hurt badly after tension on remote islands (7,2,5)
9 A crowd surround base with a tiny animal (6)
10 'Drink!' announced author of welfare report (8)
11 Idle, stupid, eating liberal greasy solid? Doomed (3-5)
13 Tactless pampas cowboy yields nothing to Spain (6)
15 Barney's surprisingly close ... (6)
17 ... behind boat, like diving bird (6)
19 Descend using stomach muscles, lie back (6)
20 What editor did to big read laid out on desktop (8)
22 Cornet played in church for real (8)
24 Old lady is absent from Gray's Inn? Strange (6)
26 They run round rooms, striking different trustees (8,6)

DOWN

1 Sun falling on British strand presents obstacle (9,5)
2 Old humour's not black in scripture (4)
3 Artist could spell danger for sailors (6)
4 Many gamblers here perhaps salvage last of chips (3,5)
5 Sound of luxury car turned up first (4)
7 He's insignificant, like poor-quality wine (6)
8 Domineering attitude of winning poker player? (14)
12 Force red pigment into chip (5)
14 Turn over more expensive object (5)
16 Brief report of missile still burning (8)
18 Nasty guy offered horse (3,3)
21 Ignore devastated area (6)
23 Plug city (4)
25 Other way round river's twisty (4)

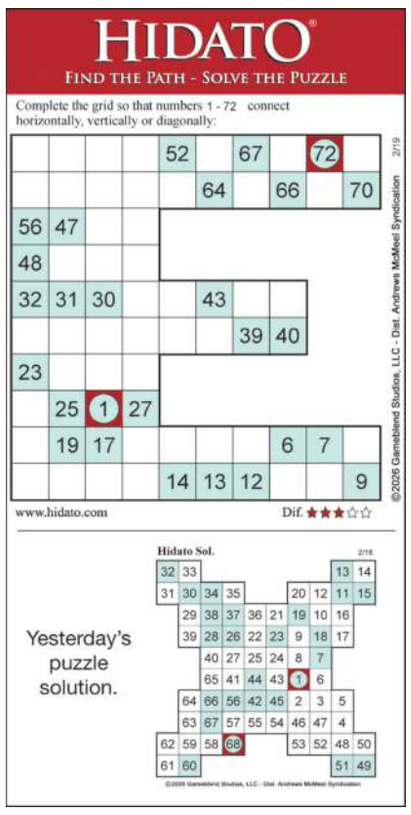
SOLUTION TO No. 9744:
ACROSS: **1** Bedroom. **5** Encode. **9** Alberta. **10** Pontoon. **11** Dot.**12** Basingstoke. **13** Panda. **14** Handcuffs. **16** Escalopes. **17** Ether. **19** Granularity. **22** Rim. **23** Rebecca. **24** Dreaded. **26** Grated. **27** Sporran.
DOWN: 1 Board up. **2** Debating chamber.**3** Oar. **4** Means. **5** Exponents. **6** Canes.**7** Drop off the radar. **8** Inlets. **12** Brawl. **14** Haphazard. **15** Chewy. **16** Edgers.**18** Ramadan. **20** Uncut. **21** Indus. **25** Ego.

©The Daily Mail

HIDATO

FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1 - 72 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally:



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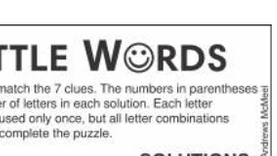
Yesterday's puzzle solution.



7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES	SOLUTIONS
1 poet's alternative to "ere" (5)	
2 "high points" (6)	
3 arousing, as interest (7)	
4 some outdoor timepieces (8)	
5 1990s pop star Paula (5)	
6 in a luxurious manner (9)	
7 dart player's competency (9)	

AF AB PI CR ING
TS ULE ION DUL PRE
OP LY DI QU ES
SUN CIS ORE NT ALS

Yesterday's Answers: 1. STRETCH 2. BESTOWED 3. SITTER 4. MALAMUTE 5. WHOOPED 6. PLOWED 7. ROCKED 12/13

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B'desh forms Wage Board as Garment Protests turn Violent

Bangladesh announced a six-member wage board on Sunday to review garment workers' pay and urged employees to return to work, but protests demanding higher wages continued across major industrial areas, disrupting transport and factory operations.

Workers in the nation are demanding a minimum monthly wage of $245, more than double the current, saying rising costs of food, housing, transport and healthcare have sharply eroded their purchasing power. The dispute has raised concerns about disruption to an industry that employs about 4 million workers. **Reuters**

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SMART INVESTING

Refining, Retail Should Keep RIL Ringing

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REVERSE AI SWING Recent net buys may be to seek refuge from AI sell-off, not a bullish call on India, caution some analysts

D-St Gets a Billion FPI Dollars, Ray of Hope

Ravindra Sonavane

Mumbai: After aggressively selling in September and the first half of October, foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have turned net buyers of Indian equities, investing nearly $1.2 billion over the past 10 trading sessions. Concerns over the outlook for the AI trade could have prompted some overseas investors to shift allocations to beaten-down Indian equities, which have lagged behind various regional peers recently in the absence of a dominant AI industry. The recent purchases, however, may be positional flows looking for avenues that are less impacted by the AI sell-off rather than a fresh bullish call on India by global investors.

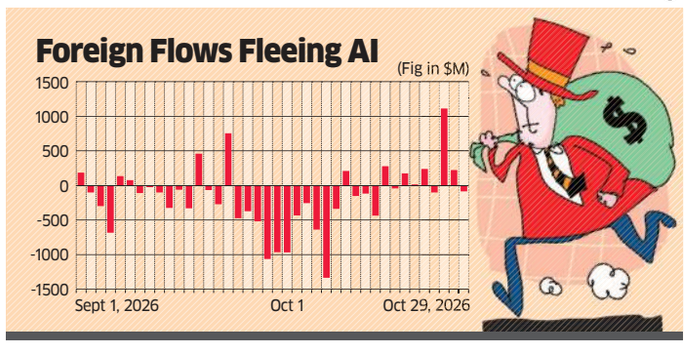
"Indian large-cap stocks, particularly banks and IT companies, are being viewed as an anti-AI trade, attracting model-driven flows rather than a broad-based return of long-only foreign investors, said Ritesh Jain, founder of Pinetree Macro.

Between October 16 and October 30, FPIs made net purchases of nearly $1.2 billion in the secondary market, according to NSDL data. On October 30, they bought equities worth ₹3,600 crore, according to provisional NSE data. In the primary market, they were buyers worth $600 million, with Jio Telecom's ₹30,188 crore IPO expected to have cornered a large chunk of these flows.

Sensex and Nifty gained 1.9% & 2.7% respectively; BSE Midcap 150 and BSE SmallCap 250 fell 4% and 6.3% in Oct

"There is a shift in global investment flows because of signs of a deflation in the artificial intelligence (AI) trade," said Jain. "When the AI trade is doing well, money moves from the rest of the world into the US as investors buy dollars to invest in US AI stocks. When they sell these stocks, they also move out of the US dollar."

Indian markets delivered a mixed performance in October. The Sensex and Nifty gained 1.9% and 2.7%, respectively, while the BSE Midcap 150 and BSE SmallCap 250 fell 4% and 6.3%. The Nifty IT index surged 17%.



Overseas markets, meanwhile, saw sharp corrections, with the Nasdaq and Japan's Nikkei falling 5% each, Hong Kong's Hang Seng declining 5.5%, Shenzhen dropping 13.7%, and Taiwan and South Korea's Kospi falling 8% and 14%, respectively.

Fund managers are seeing selective opportunities in India after the recent underperformance, said strategists. "A small portion of the inflows reflected selective foreign investors returning to India on a bottom-up basis, attracted by improving growth prospects and opportunities in certain technology sectors," said Gautam Chhaochharia, head of global markets, India, at UBS.

The recent buying follows a prolonged period of foreign outflows. Between January 1 and October 15, they sold equities worth over $32.7 billion amid the US-Iran war, rising crude oil prices, hardening bond yields, currency depreciation, earnings uncertainty and inflation. They had also sold equities worth over $18.8 billion in 2025.

Though overseas investors bought nearly $6.15 billion in Indian equities between mid-June and August, they pulled out $8.6 billion in September and the first half of October as a spike in global oil prices and hardening of US bond yields heightened risk-off sentiment.

"The recent pressure on Indian markets had been driven more by global factors, including the strength of the AI trade and higher energy prices, than by domestic fundamentals," said Ben Powell, chief investment strategist for Middle East and Asia-Pacific at BlackRock Investment Institute.

BlackRock remains strategically overweight on India and is closely monitoring the recent pace of foreign inflows. "We continue to closely watch the encouraging recent pace of inflows and remain strategically overweight India," he said.

Banks are Safe; AI Bubble is the Risk: Julius Baer CEO

ET Q&A

The biggest risk facing global markets is an AI bubble, with investors getting carried away by the AI boom, says Swiss private banking and wealth management group Julius Baer's chief executive, **Stefan Bollinger**. On India, he says the correction in equity valuations to 16-16.5 times the earnings from 21-22 times is healthy and that the country's growth story remains intact. In an interview with **Himadri Buch**, he also discusses India's investment prospects, foreign inflows and market risks. Edited excerpts:

"There are too many private equity firms chasing the same opportunity, and there will be a washout of players"
STEFAN BOLLINGER
CEO, Julius Baer

How do you think investments or preferences of wealthy Indians are changing when it comes to global diversification?
In the past five years, we have seen people seeking diversification, with offshore investments rising from 2-5% of their wealth to 15-20%. Every portfolio is tailor-made based on individual circumstances, risk appetite, consumption needs and investment horizon.

As investors diversify beyond the US, which markets and asset classes are attracting interest?
Hedge funds are back in focus. In private equity, we are focused on firms that can access specific industries or markets. Private credit remains an interesting asset class. Clients also invest through structured products that offer downside protection or levered upside.

What is your assessment of the US Fed's decision, and do you expect it to hike rates anytime soon?
The Fed, there were two members that were in favour of hiking and everyone else was not. Just before the midterm (elections in the US), raising rates would have caused a lot of tension. As you know, it's a fully priced thing for December as inflation is really high.

How do you assess the risks to the financial system and where could the next crisis emerge?
The risk of the next crisis stemming from a banking crisis is incredibly low. Banks are very safe. I think it's more likely that this is going to be through some off-balance sheet commitment that you see now in the AI ecosystem where the numbers that you talk about are just high.

Could rising yields trigger isolated problems in pension funds, insurers or other companies, similar to Silicon Valley Bank?
That is possible, but I don't think it poses a systemic risk. In countries like Japan, the hurdle rate for taking such risks is rising. As a result, some funds are expected to flow back to Japan, as domestic markets have become attractive. Japanese investors are rethinking their overseas allocations as interest rates rise in Japan.

Continued on ▸▸ Smart Investing

OIL, AI WORRIES HIT OUTLOOK FOR INFLOW REVIVAL

Foreign G-Sec Selling Halves, Risk Persists

Rozebud Gonsalves

Mumbai: Foreign selling of Indian assets slowed in October as debt outflows nearly halved and equity sales eased marginally, but high oil prices, elevated global yields and uncertainty around artificial intelligence investments cloud the prospects of a sustained revival in portfolio flows.

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) sold ₹5,400 crore of government securities under the fully accessible route (FAR) in October, 49% less than in September, according to data from Clearing Corporation of India (CCIL). Their net equity sales declined 3% month-on-month to ₹34,843 crore, National Securities Depository (NSDL) data showed. Combined selling across FAR securities and equities fell 13% to ₹40,243 crore last month from ₹46,390 crore in September, offering some respite after sustained foreign outflows through much of the calendar year.

Debt inflows seen in June and July failed to sustain after Bloomberg deferred a decision on including Indian government bonds in its Global Aggregate Index.

FPIs had bought more than ₹50,000 crore of FAR securities during those two months, including a record ₹41,774 crore in June, before turning sellers in August.

Continued on ▸▸ Smart Investing

Another Dhamaka in November? Unseasonal Headwinds a Drag

Festive demand, FPI buying, corp earnings could support a bounce

Ravindra Sonavane

Mumbai: Investors heading into November will have to weigh a historically favourable month for equities against a challenging backdrop of elevated crude oil prices, rising global bond yields and a weak rupee. November has traditionally been a strong month for Indian stocks, with the Sensex ending higher in seven of the past 10 years and the Nifty 50 gaining in six. Broader markets have also shown favourable seasonality. The BSE Midcap 150 index closed higher in eight of the past 10 Novembers, while the BSE SmallCap 250 ended with gains in six of those years.

Continued on ▸▸ Smart Investing

History Favours Bulls

Date	Sensex	Nifty	BSE 150 MidCap	BSE 250 SmallCap
Nov-25	2.1	1.9	0.7	-2.9
Nov-24	0.5	-0.3	0.1	-0.6
Nov-23	4.9	5.5	9.6	9.4
Nov-22	3.9	4.1	2.2	3.1
Nov-21	-3.8	-3.9	-1.5	-0.9
Nov-20	11.4	11.4	13.7	13.0
Nov-19	1.7	1.5	1.6	0.3
Nov-18	5.1	4.7	3.0	1.6
Nov-17	-0.2	-1.1	2.2	3.2
Nov-16	-4.6	-4.7	-7.4	-7.8
Average	2.1	1.9	2.4	1.8

Source: ET Data

SMART MONEY BETS IN A SLUMP

Six Stocks Mutual Funds Keep Adding in a Falling Market

Sanket Dhanorkar

The stock market is offering no respite from a prolonged slump, casting a shadow over investors' Diwali celebrations. Two years have passed since a stunning multi-year rally came to a grinding halt. Intermittent rebounds have proved to be short-lived amid despondency over persistent geopolitical tensions, inflationary pressures from soaring energy prices, hawkish shift in monetary policy, and more. The correction in individual stocks has been steeper than what the headline index fall suggests.

For most lay investors, this is uncharted territory. But for the market mavens at India's mutual fund companies, this is hunting season. Even as pessimism grips the broader market, these fund managers are seeing fertile ground for finding new investible opportunities as well as compelling entry points for high-conviction names. In our thirteenth edition of Most Wanted Stocks, **ET Wealth** has zeroed in on a few such stocks that have been consistently favoured by fund managers. The six stocks we have filtered out have seen a gradual rise in mutual fund holding for four consecutive quarters since September 2025.

For More Pick Up Today's THE ECONOMIC TIMES wealth

Mimicking fund managers' moves comes with caveats. They often build positions gradually at lower valuations and exit swiftly when market conditions or fundamentals change. Investors should do their own due diligence and invest only surplus money they won't need for the next few years.

This is how we zeroed in on the fund managers' favoured stocks: We identified stocks from the BSE 500 index whose share in mutual fund holdings has consistently risen over the past four quarters. Only those stocks in which mutual fund holding was at least 10% of the company's total share capital, and were held by at least 20 equity diversified schemes as of September 2026, were considered. These were further screened for a healthy return profile—boasting average return on equity (RoE) of more than 15% over the past three years. For the complete list and profile of stocks featured, pick up today's copy of ET Wealth.

Muthoot Finance

INDIA'S LARGEST GOLD LOAN NBFC

PARTICULARS	STANDALONE H1 FY 2027	STANDALONE H1 FY 2026	STANDALONE % Increase	CONSOLIDATED H1 FY 2027	CONSOLIDATED H1 FY 2026	CONSOLIDATED % Increase
	₹ in Crores					
Loan Asset (₹)	1,87,810	1,32,305	42%	2,09,317	1,47,673	42%
Total Revenue (₹)	16,445	12,153	35%	18,706	13,765	36%
Profit After Tax (₹)	5,527	4,391	26%	6,103	4,386	39%
Net Worth (₹)	42,015	31,843	32%	43,926	32,819	34%
Earnings Per Share (₹10/- each) (Basic) (₹)	137.67	109.39	26%	150.59	110.52	36%
Book Value Per Share (₹)	1,046.49	793.09	32%	1,094.05	817.33	34%

Extract Of Unaudited Standalone & Consolidated Financial Results For The Half-Year Ended September 30, 2026

Note: The above is an extract of the detailed format of Unaudited Half-Yearly Financial Results and is not a statutory advertisement required under **SEBI** guidelines. The detailed financials and investor presentation is available on the website of the Company at **www.muthootfinance.com**

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Muthoot Family - 800 years of Business Legacy

TWIN ENGINES Input costs are a drag on growing retail business, but global uncertainties are keeping oil on the boil

Refining, Retail should Keep RIL Ringing

Sachin Kumar & Ranjit Shinde

ET Intelligence Group: Reliance Industries (RIL) reported strong double digit growth in revenue and profits for the September quarter, led by the oil-to-chemicals (O2C) segment. However, operating profitability (Ebitda margin) was under pressure due to factors such as investments in the digital commerce by its retail division, the shift in festive season to the December quarter (compared with the previous year where it was split between the second and third quarters), and the effects of rising inflation and a weaker rupee against the dollar that drove overall costs of inputs, packaging and transportation. In the coming quarters, strong refining margins are expected to support O2C earnings amid supply disruptions, low fuel inventories and RIL's ability to source crude and feedstocks competitively. The retail business may provide a near-term lift depending on the trend in festive demand while investments in digital commerce are expected to translate into better earnings from FY28.

RIL's consolidated revenue grew by 27.8% year-on-year to ₹3.6 lakh crore. Though Ebitda of ₹62,409 crore was the highest ever in any quarter so far, it rose at a slower pace of 23.9%, reflecting pressure on profitability due to the retail segment. The O2C business led the growth, with Ebitda surging 67.9% to ₹25,203 crore and accounting for nearly 40% of the group's total Ebitda compared with 30% in the year-ago quarter.

Earnings Review

The O2C business is benefitting from higher fuel cracks—the difference between the prices of crude oil and refined products—aided by global refinery outages, low product inventories and supply disruptions arising from geopolitical tensions. On a per barrel basis, gasoline cracks nearly tripled to $24.9l year-on-year in the September quarter, gasoil cracks rose 3.5 times to $65.8 and ATF cracks increasing 3.7 times to $59.3. RIL's ability to diversify crude sourcing and redirect refined product exports across geographies should help it capture better realisations. During the quarter, it increased gasoline exports to East and South Africa.

The Retail division's Ebitda declined 10.2% year-on-year to ₹6,120 crore in September quarter, with margins under pressure from digital commerce investments, higher input costs absorbed by the company and the shift in the festive calendar to December quarter. The management expects the full benefit of the festive season to reflect in the December quarter. However, elevated inflation and uneven rural demand due to weak monsoon may constrain discretionary consumption in the near term.

JIO PLATFORMS

Jio Platforms, which recently debuted on the bourses and represents RIL's telecom and digital platforms business, reported double digit year-on-year revenue and net profit growth for the September quarter. It was aided by improved average revenue per user (Arpu) and steady traction in the subscriber additions and 5G adoption. Its customer base increased 7.1% year-on-year to 542.4 million while the proportion of 5G users increased to 55.3% from 46.3% a year ago. Arpu increased to ₹218.8 from ₹211.4 a year ago.

The company continued to report growth in monthly data consumption per customer. Jio's stock has gained 28% over its offer price of ₹1,119 in the three trading sessions after listing on October 28. This has raised its trailing P/E multiple to 42 from around 34 at the time of the IPO, narrowing the valuations gap with Bharti Airtel, which trades at a trailing P/E of 43. Jio Platforms is likely to sustain the growth momentum in the coming quarters, which should support the stock price.

Upwardly Mobile

Quarterly Consolidated Performance of RIL and Jio Platforms (₹ crore)

	RIL		Jio Platforms	
	Sep'26	YoY %	Sep'26	YoY %
Revenue	3,62,268	27.8	40,475	11.4
EBITDA	62,409	23.9	21,879	16.6
EBITDA Margin (%)	17.2	-60 bps	54.1	250 bps
Net Profit	29,550	33.8	8,387	13.7

Bps: Basis points (100 bps =1% point) SOURCE: Company Data, ETIG

INNOVATIVE MEDICINES A CRUCIAL FOCUS AREA

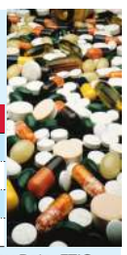
New Products may Keep Sun Bright

Under Treatment

Quarterly Financials of Sun Pharma (₹ crore)

	Sep'26	Sep'25	YoY (%)
Revenue from operations	16,199	14,478	11.9
EBITDA	4,744	4,527	4.8
EBITDA margin (%)	29.3	31.3	-200 bps
Net Profit	1,989	3,118	-36.2

Bps: Basis points (100 bps =1% point) SOURCE: Company Data, ETIG



Snehal Mergu

ET Intelligence Group: Sun Pharmaceutical delivered strong double-digit revenue growth in the September quarter, supported by robust performance in India, emerging markets and its specialty medicines portfolio. Its profitability was weighed down by one-off acquisition-related and litigation settlement costs. The company's medium-term growth outlook will be driven by specialty therapies such as Ilumya, Unloxcyt and Leqselvi. New specialty launches, expansion in cardiovascular therapies through Lerodalcibep, progress in late-stage clinical assets and continued market share gains in India are expected to offset pressure on the US generics business.

Earnings Review

The company's domestic market share rose to 8.6% in the September 2026 quarter from 8.3% a year earlier. A key focus area remains the innovative medicines portfolio, which contributes more than one-fifth to the company's overall sales. While growth in Ilumya moderated during the quarter, Sun attributed this partly to execution-related factors and expects momentum to improve following the recent approval of the drug for psoriatic arthritis in the US.

Sun is also advancing the innovation pipeline, with late-stage assets such as Fibromun and Nidlegy nearing key milestones, while diabetes candidate GL0034 remains under development. The company expects R&D investments to increase in the second half of FY27 as development activities accelerate. R&D spending was 4.8% of sales during the quarter compared with 5.4% in the year ago quarter.

Another significant growth driver is the proposed Organon acquisition, which is expected to be completed by the fourth quarter of FY27, subject to approvals. The transaction is likely to expand Sun's global footprint and strengthen its specialty and biosimilar capabilities.

Choice Equity Broking has retained a 'BUY' rating on the stock with a target price of ₹2,300, a 29.3% upside to Friday's closing price of ₹1,778.3, citing the company's specialty portfolio, innovation pipeline and proposed Organon acquisition as key growth drivers. However, it has lowered the FY27-28 earnings estimates by 1-3.6% amid weakness in the US business.

AT RISK Recent breaches at SBI, BoB and AU SFB highlight rising vulnerabilities, potential losses

Insurers Look around for Cover as Number of Cyberattacks Rises

Shilpy Sinha

Safety Net

SBI may seek a claim under its **₹1,425-cr cyber insurance policy** with **Oriental Insurance**

BoB holds a **₹750 cr enterprise cyber insurance programme**

BoB may have filed a preliminary claim after a suspected data breach exposed **nearly 1 TB of customer data**

AU SFB has a **₹100-cr cyber insurance cover** from **New India Assurance**

Mumbai: The spate of cyberattacks targeting financial institutions, including the one involving AU Small Finance Bank, is raising concerns about the growing vulnerability of banks and the potential scale of losses, with insurers reporting an increase in cyber incidents over the past three to four months.

AU Small Finance Bank said it's investigating a potential data breach involving a third-party software-as-a-service platform hosted by Salesforce that holds information related to auto loan customers. The bank has a ₹100 crore cyber insurance cover from New India Assurance, which could help cushion the financial impact. However, the lender has not yet intimated the insurer, according to people familiar with the matter. The extent of the potential data exposure and the number of customers affected are yet to be established.

This follows cyberattacks involving Bank of Baroda and State Bank of India, pointing to growing risks across the banking sector.

Insurers said they had witnessed a spate of attacks on financial institutions and manufacturing companies in recent months. Forensic investigations into several hacks are still underway, making it too early to determine the extent of the breaches and the potential claims.

"The spate of attacks we are witnessing is worrying because hackers are increasingly using artificial intelligence to breach even sophisticated security systems," an insurance industry executive said. "Our concern is that the depth of penetration could be much higher, which could translate into significantly larger losses."

While ransomware and business interruption remain major risks, financial institutions face potentially significant liabilities from the exposure of customer information, including know-your-customer documents and financial records. The costs could extend to forensic investigations, legal advice, customer notifications, public relations and credit monitoring for affected customers.

"The scale of the liability will depend on the nature of the information compromised, the number of customers affected and the findings of forensic investigations," said an executive at a state-owned insurer.

Cyber insurance policies typically cover expenses related to forensic investigations, business interruption, legal costs and certain data-related liabilities, subject to policy terms and exclusions. The adequacy of an institution's cover will depend on the scale of the breach and the liabilities arising from it.

The recent raids could also put pressure on cyber insurance premiums, which have remained relatively subdued at 0.75-1.5% of the sum assured in recent years amid low claims, as the threat landscape becomes more complex.

TECHNICAL VIEWS

Nifty's Near-Term Rebound Faces Key 23,200 Hurdle

Nifty rose nearly 2% last week to close around 23,050, but analysts remain cautious as the index approaches the key 23,200 resistance level. A breakout above this zone could pave the way for gains towards 23,500–23,600, while support is seen in the 22,600–22,800 range.

NAGARAJ SHETTI
AVP – TECHNICAL RESEARCH, **HDFC SECURITIES**

The Nifty has broken above the crucial resistance of 22,800 and formed a higher bottom near 22,400 after a series of lower tops and bottoms, signalling a potential trend reversal. The index is now testing resistance at 23,200.

Nifty Strategy: Create long positions at current levels and on dips towards support. A decisive move above 23,200 could trigger further short covering and limit downside risks.

For the November expiry, buy Nifty futures around 23,000–23,100 for a target of 23,400, with a stop loss at 22,800. Alternatively, buy the Nifty 23,200 call for the November 23 expiry in the ₹250–280 range, with a target of ₹450 and a stop loss at ₹160.

TOP STOCKS FOR THE WEEK

DLF: Buy | CMP: ₹687 | Target: ₹735 | Stop Loss: ₹655.
The stock has been forming higher lows and is attempting to break out of a broader trading range near ₹695. The recommended holding period is two to three weeks.

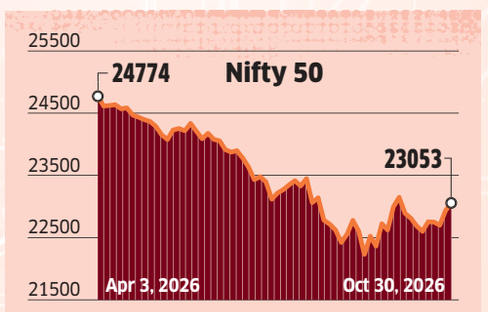
Zensar Technologies: Buy | CMP: ₹535 | Target: ₹580 | Stop Loss: ₹510.
The stock has reversed its recent downtrend after forming a significant bottom near ₹416 in September. The holding period is two to three weeks.

SACCHITANAND UTTEKAR
VP – RESEARCH (TECHNICAL & DERIVATIVES), **TRADEBULLS SECURITIES**

The Nifty has reclaimed its 20-day exponential moving average and closed above the 22,865 recovery threshold. The daily RSI has moved above 50, indicating improving momentum. However, the broader trend remains cautious as the index is still below its declining 50-day EMA near 23,170.

Nifty Strategy: Adopt a cautiously positive approach, taking selective long positions on sustained moves above 23,000. A decisive breakout above 23,170 could extend the recovery towards 23,350–23,500.

For a bullish view, buy one lot of Nifty November futures up to 23,020, with a stop loss at 22,882 and a target of 23,540.



TOP STOCKS FOR THE WEEK

Coforge: Buy | CMP: ₹2,059 | Target: ₹2,356 | Stop Loss: ₹1,972.
Sector strength and a weekly bullish-flag breakout support the stock. A close above the 2,000 call OI cluster and monthly ADX near 25 signal stronger momentum.

Radico: Sell | CMP: ₹4,120–4,166 | Target: ₹3,800 | Stop Loss: ₹4,255.
Negative divergence on the monthly RSI and a break below the 20-week EMA signal continued weakness, reinforced by daily ADX above 25.

MEHUL KOTHARI,
VICE PRESIDENT – TECHNICAL & DERIVATIVE RESEARCH, **ANAND RATHI SHARE AND STOCK BROKERS**

A decisive breakout above 23,200, accompanied by strength in the broader market, is necessary for a sustainable recovery. Immediate support is at 22,600, followed by 22,400. For Bank Nifty, a breakout above 56,000 could improve sentiment, while a breach of 53,000 may trigger significant weakness. Traders should avoid aggressive directional positions until either boundary is decisively breached.

Nifty Strategy: Consider buying Nifty futures once the spot index sustains above 23,200, with a put option as a hedge. Investors with a medium-term horizon can accumulate NIFTYBEES in a staggered manner around ₹262.

TOP STOCKS FOR THE WEEK

BSE: Buy | CMP: ₹3,500 | Target: ₹3,900 | Stop Loss: ₹3,300.
A hidden bullish divergence on the weekly chart suggests the prevailing uptrend could continue. The recommended buying range is ₹3,400–3,500.

ITC: Buy | CMP: ₹262 | Target: ₹295 | Stop loss: ₹250.
The stock is showing signs of accumulation after an extended period of underperformance and remains oversold on longer-term charts. A sustained move above ₹271 could trigger a recovery.

Policy Doctor: Health Insurance Guide

MAYANK GOSAR
CEO, SOFTCON CAPITAL

I underwent life-saving cancer surgery last year. While my insurer covered post-hospitalisation expenses for three months after discharge, I incurred over ₹1 lakh in subsequent follow-up scans, blood tests and doctor visits. Can I buy any policy now to cover such expenses? Or will I be denied coverage due to my past diagnosis?

Buying a new individual health policy may be difficult, as insurers may decline the proposal or impose cancer-related exclusions, depending on their underwriting guidelines. Routine OPD expenses, including follow-up consultations, scans and blood tests, are generally excluded unless specifically covered. Alternatively, check whether a working spouse's or child's corporate group policy covers pre-existing diseases without restrictive conditions, subject to policy terms and limits.

I am about to quit my current organisation and join another company shortly. The former offered adequate coverage for elderly parents under the group family floater health insurance plan, which is not the case with the latter. In addition, I also obtained top-up health coverage for my parents, with the premiums being deducted from my salary. Can I port both the group base health insurance and the top-up policies before my notice period ends?

Generally, employer-provided group health insurance remains active only during employment and may cease when you leave the organisation.

Some insurers may allow migration of the base and top-up covers to individual policies, subject to policy terms and continuity benefits. Direct porting from a group policy to another insurer's individual policy is generally not available in the usual manner. During migration, disclose your parents' complete medical history to avoid claim rejection due to non-disclosure or misrepresentation.

Have a health insurance query? Write to us at etwealth@timesofindia.com

Banks Put AI to Work, Unlock Productivity Doors

Lenders report 10-50% efficiency gains as AI adoption reshapes banking operations and workforce requirements

Saloni Shukla

Mumbai: Banks are reporting 10-50% improvements across productivity, turnaround time and operating costs from artificial intelligence-led initiatives, with some lenders handling up to 30% more servicing volumes without adding manpower as AI moves deeper into corporate banking, collections and tran saction processing.

The gains vary across operations: Axis Bank has recorded productivity improvements of more than 10% in selected customer journeys, Kotak Mahindra Bank can handle 20-30% more corporate-servicing volumes with the same headcount, while AU Small Finance Bank has cut the operating cost of AI-led voice operations by 50%.

Kotak has deployed AI across its wholesale banking operations. Under Project ACE, the bank has automated the classification and routing of corporate customer requests related to account servicing, payments, transaction disputes and inward remittances.

"The project has resulted in a massive efficiency gain, resolution tags have improved twice and because of this efficiency gain, there is surplus capacity, allowing the same headcount to handle 20-30% more volumes with the same capacity," said Anu Aggarwal, head-corporate and transaction banking, Kotak Mahindra Bank.

The lender is also developing predictive tools to forecast corporate cash inflows, upcoming payments and surplus liquidity, and recommend investment options for excess funds.

"We are moving from information to intelligence. Instead of just providing CFOs with dashboards and data, we want to use predictive models to help them anticipate collections, upcoming payments and surplus liquidity, while suggesting where excess funds can be invested," Aggarwal said.

HDFC Bank said digitisation and straight-through processing reduced service-delivery turnaround times by 30% during the September quarter, while customer visits per frontline employee increased nearly 50%. Former chief executive Sashidhar Jagdishan had indicated that greater AI adoption could reduce manpower requirements in back-office, credit and corporate-support functions.

Axis Bank is embedding AI across customer servicing, operations and decision-making through its enterprise-wide AXIOM platform. Its AI bots handled nearly 60% of collection calls during the September quarter. "AI-driven solutions such as Doc AI, Voice AI and GenAI-powered collections continue to enhance customer experience, improve operational efficiency and deliver better business outcomes," said Amitabh Chaudhry, MD and CEO, Axis Bank.

ICICI Bank has developed an enterprise AI platform covering customer onboarding, fraud detection, portfolio monitoring, document processing and customer servicing. "Together, these capabilities help simplify processes, improve turnaround times and support decision-making across multiple banking functions," said Sandeep Batra, executive director, ICICI Bank.

Tech Picks | AAKASH K HINDOCHA, Vice President – Research | Nuvama Wealth Management

ADANIENSOL — BUY TARGET ₹1,480
200-DMA reclaimed; stock nears 100-day trendline breakout, signalling early reversal signs.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹1,349 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹1,278

PHOENIXLTD — BUY TARGET ₹2,100
After June breakout from a two-year range, the stock retests breakout zone, supported by rising MVAs.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹1,957 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹1,890

HINDALCO — BUY TARGET ₹942
Monthly closing above the 50% retracement mark; bullish H&S, likely retest towards the 200-DMA.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹884 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹850

Another Dhamaka in Nov?

▸▸ From ET Markets Page 1

Kranthi Bathini, equity strategist at WealthMills Securities, said the extension of festive activity into November, encouraging corporate earnings and renewed foreign buying, could be tailwinds for equities.

"With festive activity extending into November, encouraging corporate earnings, including recent results from Reliance Industries and Jio Platforms, and FPI buying over the past two weeks, equities could find support," Bathini said.

This year, the extension of festive activity into November, improving corporate earnings and the return of foreign investors could support market sentiment. However, global uncertainties and elevated oil prices remain key risks.

In October, the Sensex and Nifty gained 1.9% and 2.7%, respectively, while the BSE Midcap 150 and BSE SmallCap 250 declined 4% and 6.3%, respectively.

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have turned net buyers over the past two weeks, purchasing nearly $2 billion worth of Indian equities. Experts said global investors had been chasing the AI and semiconductor trade in markets such as the US, Taiwan and South Korea, as part of a rotation towards growth opportunities and relatively cheaper valuations.

However, crude oil remains a key risk. Concerns over a possible resumption of US military strikes on Iran have kept oil prices elevated, with crude trading near $115 per barrel. Any credible de-escalation in West Asia could trigger a relief rally and provide further support to equities in November, experts said.

Aditya Agarwala, co-founder and CIO of InvestValue Capital, said investors should favour companies with strong domestic earnings visibility and pricing power, including private financials, select consumption stocks, capital goods and industrial companies with good order books.

Foreign G-Sec

▸▸ From ET Markets Page 1

Economists cautioned against interpreting the slowdown as a decisive turn in the foreign investment cycle, as global risk factors continue to influence flows into emerging markets. "Outflows have reduced and it's not as bad as it was a few months ago, but it's hard to say if the cycle is turning. Outflows are sporadic, and when they do happen it's a large chunk," said Dhiraj Nim, economist and foreign exchange strategist at ANZ Bank.

Political developments in other emerging markets could redirect some foreign capital towards India. "What's happening in some EMs politically could put India in a favourable position," Nim said. "Easing US yields and some wobble in AI investment are factors that are evolving. However, high oil prices are a big deterrent to inflows."

Foreign investors sold Brazilian equities and debt following the presidential election as they reassessed the country's fiscal outlook, according to Reuters.

Concerns are also growing over whether returns from AI will justify the substantial investments being made in data centres, chips and computing infrastructure. This has prompted some investors to consider markets that are less exposed to expensive AI-linked investments. "Some of the recent inflows appear to reflect the view of India as the 'anti-AI' trade, coupled with declines in global yields and flows associated with IPO activity," said Tanay Dalal, senior VP, economic research, at Axis Bank.

Banks are Safe

▸▸ From ET Markets Page 1

How risky are private equity and private credit? Could redemption pressures signal trouble?

There will be a lot of disappointment in private equity and private debt, but it doesn't create a systemic issue. Banks have de-risked and a lot of risk has gone into the broader market. Private equity has bought a lot of investments during Covid at inflated prices, and that will lead to some disappointment. There are too many private equity firms chasing the same opportunity, and there will be a washout of players. The gap between a first-quartile fund and a fourth will widen significantly.

Has the BRICS story lost its appeal, or do emerging markets still offer investment opportunities?

Maybe BRICS has lost a bit of its shiny toy feeling. But look at India and what has been created. India clocks in 6-7% growth every year, or even more. The progress is real and these are big economies. Maybe BRICS is out of fashion because Russia going in a different direction. But now it is not just an idea. It is real. If you want global investments, you cannot avoid being in India, China and these markets.

Russia has fallen off, but the growth in these economies has been real.

Despite strong GDP growth, why have investors seen weak returns and outflows from Indian equities? Is this a temporary cycle or a longer-term concern?

The PE multiples at which the Indian market was trading were 21-22 times. The re-rating to 16-16.5 times is a good thing. The Indian economy is affected by global commodity prices and rupee depreciation. These are cyclical headwinds. People continue to stay invested in these markets. This is a valuation question, not a reflection of the economic reality on the ground. Sometimes investors get carried away, and you need to deliver more than 7% growth to justify extraordinary multiples.

Three Hyundai, Kia Suppliers to Invest ₹1.6k cr in Andhra

South Korean auto component manufacturers choose AP over Tamil Nadu

Nidhi Sharma & Dia Rekhi

New Delhi | Chennai: In a significant win for Andhra Pradesh's efforts to attract global manufacturing investments, three South Korean automotive component manufacturers supplying Hyundai and Kia have chosen the state over Tamil Nadu for their expansion plans, committing a combined investment of ₹1,614 crore in Anantapur.

The development marks a setback for Tamil Nadu, which has been actively courting Korean companies to deepen its automobile manufacturing ecosystem and had held discussions with all three companies to set up or expand their operations in the state. Hwashin, Seoyon and Iwamet have signed memorandums of understanding (MoUs) with the Andhra Pradesh government to establish manufacturing facilities in Anantapur.

Hwashin has committed ₹850 crore and is expected to generate 100 jobs, while Seoyon will invest ₹514 crore and create 918 jobs. Iwamet has committed ₹250 crore, with an employment potential of 400.

Together, the three projects are expected to generate 1,418 jobs and strengthen Anantapur's position as an emerging automotive manufacturing hub.

The investments follow Andhra Pradesh IT, Electronics and HRD Minister Nara Lokesh's visit to South Korea in July, during which he held a roundtable with automotive component manufacturers in the Hyundai and Kia supply chain.

The three companies participated in the interaction, following which the Andhra Pradesh government undertook sustained follow-up through Economic Development Board to convert the discussions into investment commitments.

"During our visit to South Korea, we met automotive component makers from the Hyundai and Kia supply chain and invited them to Andhra Pradesh. Our teams followed up, and today Hwashin, Seoyon and Iwamet have committed significant investments in Anantapur. This shows the confidence global investors have in Andhra Pradesh, and we will support them every step of the way," Lokesh told **ET**. The developments come against the backdrop of Tamil Nadu's own efforts to retain and attract Korean investments. All three companies had earlier been in discussions with the previous DMK government over setting up or expanding their operations in the state, a person aware of the developments said. Queries sent to Guidance, Tamil Nadu's nodal investment promotion agency, remained unanswered as of press time Sunday.

"Iwamet had registered an entity in Tamil Nadu and both Hwashin and Seoyon have existing operations in Sriperumbudur and Krishnagiri, so the dialogue involved getting them to double down on their investments in the state," the person said.

South Korea has emerged as an important investment partner for Tamil Nadu, particularly in automobiles, electric vehicles, electronics, renewable energy, heavy engineering and advanced manufacturing. In February, barely a month before the state went to polls in April, the investment facilitation agency Guidance launched a dedicated Korea Desk to help Korean companies explore, invest and expand in Tamil Nadu.

The change of destination for the three suppliers, however, underlines Andhra Pradesh's ability to leverage direct political outreach and targeted engagement to compete with Tamil Nadu's established industrial ecosystem.

Tamil Nadu, now under the TVK government, is continuing its outreach to Korean investors. In June, Industries Minister S Keerthana visited South Korea and held discussions with MotiveLink, which subsequently signed an MoU in July for a ₹300 crore investment to manufacture advanced electric vehicle components for global markets.

The contrasting developments highlight the growing competition between southern states to attract Korean manufacturing companies, particularly those linked to global automobile supply chains. While Tamil Nadu has an established base of Korean manufacturers, Andhra Pradesh is seeking to build its own automotive ecosystem by attracting suppliers.

Andhra-bound

Hwashin, Seoyon & Iwamet sign MoUs with AP govt to establish facilities in Anantapur

Hwashin commits ₹850 cr, Seoyon to invest ₹514 cr, Iwamet to bring ₹250 cr

THREE PROJECTS TO GENERATE 1,418 JOBS IN TOTAL

Development comes amid Tamil Nadu's attempts to court South Korean firms

The three cos had earlier been in discussions with previous DMK govt

CALLS KUMARASWAMY'S CLAIM BASELESS

Honda not Moving out of State, Says Industries Minister Patil

'Such remarks could hurt the state's efforts to attract investment'

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Large and medium industries minister MB Patil on Sunday dismissed Union heavy industries minister HD Kumaraswamy's claim that Honda Motorcycle and Scooter India was planning to leave Karnataka, calling the allegation baseless and politically motivated.

Honda operates its second-largest production plant at Narsapura industrial area in Kolar district with an annual capacity of 2.4 million vehicles.

Patil, referring to Kumaraswamy's comments said such remarks could hurt the state's efforts to attract investment and promote industrial growth.

Kumaraswamy, who represents Mandya in the Lok Sabha, mentioned Honda's investments in Delhi on Saturday while responding to home minister Priyank Kharge's criticism of his performance as Union minister. The industries minister noted that Honda Motorcycle has maintained a strong presence in Karnataka for over a decade.

The company was allotted 135 acres in phases at Narasapura in Kolar district starting in 2011 and has been manufacturing two-wheelers there since 2013.

The facility currently produces around 10,000 vehicles a day and provides employment to more than 7,800 people. Patil added that Honda also runs a 35-acre spare parts warehousing and distribution center at Adinarayana Hosahalli in Doddaballapura taluk, serving the entire southern region. Given the company's long association with the state, Kumaraswamy should make statements responsibly, he said. The minister said Honda is now preparing to enter electric two- wheeler manufacturing and plans to commence production at its Narasapura facility in the coming days. "There have been no lapses on the part of the state government in its dealings with Honda, nor has the company expressed any dissatisfaction with Karnataka," the minister said.

Patil also questioned Kumaraswamy's remarks, saying a Union minister from Karnataka should focus on attracting more investments to the state.

"By making unsubstantiated claims that industries are moving to states such as Gujarat, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, and Odisha, is he not acting against Karnataka's interests?" he said. On Saturday, the Union minister had remarked that several entrepreneurs who meet him in Delhi become cold when he urges them to set up industries in Karnataka. They politely decline his request with a folded hand, he said, adding that Honda was also backing out on its investment plans.

Entrepreneurs are flocking to states like Pune (Maharashtra), Hyderabad, Andhra Pradesh, and Gujarat. Such a favourable environment does not currently exist in Karnataka.

Instead, they are heading to Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, and Kerala, Kumaraswamy said, while alleging that the state's Congress regime was preventing investors from establishing operations in Karnataka.

DECADE-LONG PRESENCE

Co allotted 135 acres in phases at Narasapura in Kolar district starting in 2011 and has been manufacturing two-wheelers there since 2013

AFTER FATAL CRASH

Two Pilots Now Mandatory for Char Dham Helicopter Flights

New Delhi: The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has made it mandatory for helicopter operators conducting charter services on the Char Dham routes to deploy two pilots on every flight from November 2, tightening safety requirements following a fatal helicopter crash in Uttarakhand that killed six people on Friday.

The move has, however, prompted 11 operators to threaten a suspension of services from the same date, arguing that additional crew and logistical costs would make operations commercially unviable.

The DGCA has also mandated that the co-pilot must be qualified to operate in hilly terrain. Also, operators will now have to obtain positive destination and en-route clearance from the control room at Sahastradhara before taking off for every flight sector. Pilots will also have to submit a pilot report (PIREP) after landing at each destination helipad, detailing weather conditions and other operational information encountered during the flight. —**Our Bureau**

SK FINANCE LIMITED

Registered Office: G 1-2, New Market, Khasa Kothi, Jaipur, Rajasthan - 302001
E-mail: info@skfin.in|Phone : 0141-4161300|CIN: U65923RJ1994PLC009051

Extract of unaudited financial results for the quarter ended September 30, 2026
[Regulation 52 (8), read with Regulation 52 (4) of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("LODR Regulations")]

(₹ in lakhs except otherwise stated)

S. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended		Year ended
		September 30, 2026 (Unaudited)	September 30, 2025 (Unaudited)	March 31, 2026 (Audited)
1	Total Income from Operations	75,937.97	70,032.57	2,82,360.06
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	16,127.84	11,927.09	56,724.98
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	16,127.84	11,927.09	56,724.98
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	12,031.40	9,158.56	43,088.62
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	12,252.78	9,633.97	44,667.55
6	Paid up Equity Share Capital	1,345.43	1,344.65	1,344.83
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	4,19,350.76	3,69,326.26	3,96,843.72
8	Securities Premium Account	2,12,989.56	2,12,637.57	2,12,716.24
9	Net Worth	4,18,667.78	3,69,488.06	3,96,282.87
10	Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	13,11,014.46	12,28,325.41	12,81,974.28
11	Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	Not Applicable
12	Debt Equity Ratio	3.13	3.32	3.23
13	Earnings Per Share (of ₹1 each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) #			
	1. Basic	8.95	6.82	32.08
	2. Diluted	8.87	6.77	31.80
14	Capital Redemption Reserve	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	Not Applicable
15	Debenture Redemption Reserve	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	Not Applicable
16	Debt Service Coverage Ratio	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	Not Applicable
17	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	Not Applicable

Earnings per share for the interim periods is not annualized.

Notes:

(a) The above is an extract of the detailed unaudited quarterly financial results filed with Stock Exchange under Regulation 52 of the LODR Regulations. The full format of the unaudited quarterly financial results is available on the websites of BSE Ltd. (www.bseindia.com) and the website of the Company (www.skfin.in).

(b) For the other line items referred in regulation 52(4) of the LODR Regulations, the pertinent disclosures have been made to the BSE Ltd. and can be accessed on www.bseindia.com.

(c) There is no impact on net profit / loss, total comprehensive income or any other relevant financial item(s) due to change(s) in accounting policies for the period ended September 30, 2026.

(d) The previous period's / year's figures have been regrouped / reclassified, wherever necessary, to correspond with the current period's / year's classification / disclosure.

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors

Sd/-
Rajendra Kumar Setia
Managing Director & CEO
DIN- 00957374

Place : Jaipur
Date : October 30, 2026

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STATEMENT OF UNAUDITED CONSOLIDATED & STANDALONE FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND SIX MONTHS ENDED SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

36.4% REVENUE* Consolidated YoY
75.1% EBITDA* Consolidated YoY
2172.2% PBT* Consolidated YoY
5029.7% PAT* Consolidated YoY
*H1-FY27

(All amounts in INR Crores, unless otherwise stated)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Consolidated						Standalone					
		Quarter Ended			Six Months Period Ended		Year Ended	Quarter Ended			Six Months Period Ended		Year Ended
		Sept. 30, 2026	June 30, 2026	Sept. 30, 2025	Sept. 30, 2026	Sept. 30, 2025	March 31, 2026	Sept. 30, 2026	June 30, 2026	Sept. 30, 2025	Sept. 30, 2026	Sept. 30, 2025	March 31, 2026
		(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)
1.	Total Inome	1409.62	1220.11	913.28	2629.73	1932.17	4251.20	1262.80	1101.68	808.93	2364.48	1750.03	3773.89
2.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before Tax	95.46	64.73	-10.27	160.19	7.05	84.02	91.74	71.47	0.49	163.21	29.87	116.71
3.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after Tax	70.59	46.88	-9.50	117.47	2.29	71.81	67.73	52.18	0.37	119.91	21.88	86.51
4.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period	69.34	47.51	-7.50	116.85	3.08	73.70	67.41	51.87	-0.04	119.28	21.06	85.25
5.	Equity Share Capital (Face Value : ₹ 2/- per share)	37.04	36.37	36.16	37.04	36.16	36.29	37.04	36.37	36.16	37.04	36.16	36.29
6.	Earnings per equity share (EPS) of ₹ 2/- each												
	(i) Basic	3.88	2.58	-0.53	6.46	0.13	3.97	3.72	2.87	0.02	6.60	1.21	4.78
	(ii) Diluted	3.80	2.53	-0.52	6.33	0.13	3.95	3.65	2.81	0.02	6.46	1.21	4.76

NOTES TO UNAUDITED STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED IND AS FINANCIAL RESULTS :

1. The above Unaudited Financial Results for the quarter and six months ended September 30, 2026 have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and thereafter approved by the Board of Directors of the Holding Company at their respective meetings held on October 30, 2026.
2. The Board of Directors of the Company has declared an Interim Dividend of Rs. 2/- per Share on Equity Shares of Rs. 2/- each.

For the Order of the Board
Naresh Jalan
(Managing Director)
DIN : 00375462

Place : Kolkata
Date : October 30, 2026

WHERE PRECISION RULES PRODUCTION

FORM G

INVITATION FOR EXPRESSION OF INTEREST FOR SNEH OLEFINS PRIVATE LIMITED OPERATING IN PLASTIC/ POLYPROPYLENE PRODUCTS AT JAIPUR

(Under sub-regulation (1) of regulation 36A of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (Insolvency Resolution Process for Corporate Persons) Regulations, 2016)

RELEVANT PARTICULARS

1.	Name of the Corporate Debtor along with PAN/CIN/LLP No.	**SNEH OLEFINS PRIVATE LIMITED** CIN: U24309RJ2022PTC079921 | PAN: ABHCS9679N
2.	Address of the registered office	424-425, 4th Floor, Ganpati Plaza, MI Road, Jaipur - 302001, Rajasthan
3.	URL of website	Not Available
4.	Details of place where majority of fixed assets are located	1, Rampuradas Deoliya, Ajmer Road, Near Pepsi Factory, Bagru, Jaipur, Rajasthan
5.	Installed capacity of main products/ services	0
6.	Quantity & value of main products/ services sold in last financial year	₹ 27,03,54,605.80 FY-25-26 As per GST Portal
7.	Number of employees/ workmen	0 (as on CIRP commencement date)
8.	Further details including last available financial statements (with schedules) of two years, lists of creditors, relevant dates for subsequent events of the process are available at:	May be obtained by sending an email to : **cirp@sneholefins.com**
9.	Eligibility for resolution applicants under section 25(2)(h) of the Code is available at	May be obtained by sending an email to : **cirp@sneholefins.com**
10.	Last date for receipt of expression of interest	**17.11.2026**
11.	Date of issue of provisional list of prospective resolution applicants	**27.11.2026**
12.	Last date for submission of objections to provisional list	**02.12.2026**
13.	Date of issue of final list of prospective resolution applicants	**12.12.2026**
14.	Date of issue of information memorandum, evaluation matrix and request for resolution plan to prospective resolution applicants	**17.12.2026**
15.	Last date for submission of resolution plans	**16.01.2027**
16.	Process email id to submit Expression of Interest	**cirp@sneholefins.com**
17.	Details of the Corporate Debtor's Registration Status as MSME	The CD is Registered as MSME

Date : 02.11.2026
Place: Jaipur

Sd/-
Garima Diggiwal
IBBI Regn. No.: IBBI/IPA-001/IP-P-02018/2020-2021/13158
AFA No.: AA1/13158/02/300627/109401 | **Valid upto:** 30.06.2027
Regd. Address: 91, Moji Colony, Malviya Nagar, Jaipur, Rajasthan, 302017
For Sneh Olefins Private Limited

TRANSIT-LED GROWTH

NCRTC Eyes Realty Hubs Along Namo Corridor

Faizan Haidar

New Delhi: The National Capital Region Transport Corporation (NCRTC) is planning to develop real estate hubs along the operational Delhi-Ghaziabad-Meerut Namo Bharat corridor and the proposed Delhi-Gurugram-SNB-Alwar and Delhi-Panipat-Karnal corridors, as it evaluates the development of mixed-use, transit-oriented growth nodes.

In collaboration with the National Capital Region Planning Board (NCRPB), NCRTC is consulting senior government officials, real estate developers, consultants and industry representatives on the planning, regulatory and financial frameworks required to make transit-oriented development (TOD) viable and implementable across the National Capital Region (NCR).

Corporation plans to leverage regional connectivity to create planned urban centres and attract private investment

The corporation plans to leverage high-speed regional connectivity to create planned urban centres and attract private investment in commercial, residential and institutional developments. The feasibility and policy requirements for such projects were recently discussed at a consultative workshop organised by NCRTC.

D Thara, secretary, Department of Capital Development, Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA), outlined the government's initiatives in this area and the way forward for such developments.

A key focus of the discussions was the policy and institutional support required to encourage private developers to invest in TOD zones.

Developers sought measures such as flexibility in determining the mix of uses based on market demand, higher floor area ratios , increased ground coverage, flexible development and delivery models, greater tenure security, streamlined land assembly and single-window clearances.

SECOND-HIGHEST TALLY ON RECORD

Mumbai Property Registrations Stay Resilient in October

City logged 12,690 transactions, up 9% YoY, while stamp duty collections rose 13%

Kailash Babar

Mumbai: Mumbai, the country's largest and most expensive property market, recorded its second-highest October tally of property registrations, sustaining transaction momentum despite the Shraddh period and fewer effective registration days during Navratri. The performance points to resilient housing demand as the city enters the peak festive season.

The city recorded 12,690 property registrations in October, up 9% year-on-year, while stamp duty collections rose 13% to ₹1,173 crore, according to data from the Inspector General of Registration and Controller of Stamps, Maharashtra.

Registrations remained above 12,000 for the ninth consecutive month, underlining steady transaction activity through 2026. The October tally surpassed only in October 2024, when the city recorded 12,960 transactions. The performance is notable given the overlap of the Shraddh period and Navratri. Shraddh, traditionally considered a subdued period for property transactions, extended until October 10, while Navratri had fewer effective registration days than last year.

"The Mumbai residential market continues to demonstrate exceptional resilience and depth. October's performance is encouraging because it was achieved despite the overlap of Shraddh and a shorter effective registration period during Navratri. The ability of the market to deliver year-on-year growth reflects the strength of end-user demand and sustained confidence among homebuyers," said Shishir Baijal, international partner, CMD, Knight Frank India.

According to Baijal, housing demand has remained stable through 2026, supported by economic growth, rising household aspirations, and the availability of housing options across multiple price segments.

"Demand is increasingly spreading across established and emerging residential micro-markets, with homebuyers evaluating connectivity, social infrastructure and long-term value alongside ticket sizes. Redevelopment is also bringing new housing options into established locations, widening the choice available to buyers. This is creating opportunities for developers across price segments," said Parthh K Mehta, CMD, Paradigm Realty.

The Shraddh period, which ran from September 26 to October 10, saw 3,419 property registrations, up 2% from the corresponding period last year. Average daily registrations rose to 311 from 306 a year earlier, indicating that buyers continued to conclude transactions despite traditional seasonal considerations. During the nine-day Navratri period, the city recorded 4,680 registrations. While volumes were lower than the exceptionally high levels recorded during the corresponding period last year, the comparison was affected by fewer effective registration days in October 2026.

Daily registration activity remained broadly stable, indicating sustained underlying buyer interest. October's performance builds on the transaction momentum seen throughout the year. Between January and October 2026, Mumbai recorded 132,040 property registrations, up 7% from corresponding period last year. Stamp duty collections during the 10-month period rose 5% to ₹11,756 crore from ₹11,186 crore.

Plot Thickens

Registrations stay above **12,000** for ninth straight month

Over **132,000** properties registered in Jan-Oct 2026

End-users continue to drive housing demand

Property registrations have more than **doubled** since 2013

Redevelopment, infra boost housing demand

Ascentium Eyes Acquisitions for Strategic India Expansion

Professional services co has completed seven deals here since 2019, more being planned

Vinod Mahanta

Mumbai: Ascentium, a Singapore-headquartered professional services firm, is looking to expand in India through acquisitions, stitching together specialist professional services firms into a larger platform as part of its ambition to build an Asia-centric global corporate services business, group CEO Lennard Yong said. Just three years old, Ascentium, backed by private equity firm Hillhouse Investment, has rapidly expanded its presence to 27 markets, with about 3,000 employees.

India, Japan, Singapore and Hong Kong are among the strategic markets central to the firm's growth, Yong told ET in an interview. "India is one of the key jurisdictions. It is virtually impossible to become the No 1 player in APAC without a dominant presence here."

The firm aims to establish a strong presence across Asia-Pacific, Europe, the Middle East and Africa, he said. Ascentium's strategy hinges on helping Asian companies expand internationally while assisting foreign companies entering India and other Asian markets. Many of Ascentium's competitors are based in the US, UK and the Netherlands and have traditionally provided services to western businesses looking to expand into Asia.

India is one of the key jurisdictions. It is virtually impossible to become the No 1 player in APAC without a dominant presence here

LENNARD YONG
Group CEO, Ascentium

"We have set up from this side of the world, helping Indian, Singaporean, Malaysian and Hong Kong companies go international. I think it is time," Yong said.

The group's India operations, rebranded Ascentium India after the Singapore-headquartered firm acquired InCorp in 2024, have nearly 350 employees, including more than 150 chartered accountants, across 17 offices in eight cities.

"The platform has completed seven acquisitions in India since 2019 and is currently negotiating one more, with discussions underway for a couple of others," said Manish Modi, CEO of Ascentium India.

Ascentium has evaluated more than 65 acquisition opportunities globally and completed 16, Yong said. In India, Modi said he had held 250 acquisition-related conversations over the past seven years, including at InCorp, reflecting the market's fragmentation, the difficulty of reaching agreements with local firms, and the group's selective approach to consolidation.

For Yong, the opportunity lies in a structural gap in India's professional services sector, where the Big Four—PwC, Deloitte, KPMG and EY—dominate the upper end of the market, followed by firms such as BDO and Grant Thornton, leaving room for rivals with scale and global networks. A crucial differentiator, Yong said, is Ascentium's corporate structure. Unlike global accounting networks, where member firms operate as independent partnerships with their own profit-and-loss accounts, Ascentium is a single corporation. "Manish (India CEO) and I share a single P&L. He and his leadership team are incentivised on the same P&L as I am. If I don't get paid, he doesn't get paid," Yong said. "We are not partners; we are shareholders in a corporation. Manish and I have not received dividend distributions because we are reinvesting the cash to grow the company."

Ascentium is creating its own data lake using expertise gained from corporate services engagements and intends to deploy agentic AI in specific business operations.

"AI is not free. It is expensive to invest in your own data lakes and develop your own AI tools," Yong said, adding: "If you don't retain money every year, how are you going to fund major structural investments?" Ascentium sees growth opportunities in advising foreign companies entering India, servicing GCCs, supporting Indian companies with overseas acquisitions across its 27 markets, and offering mid-market businesses integrated tax, corporate, M&A and IPO advisory services, Modi said.

House Panel to Review Media Law Implementation

OTT platforms, social media, TRPs and Pay-TV issues among key subjects on agenda

Javed Farooqui

New Delhi: The implementation of laws governing all forms of media, including print, television and digital platforms, will be the central focus of the Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology during its 2026-27 review of the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting.

The committee has selected 12 subjects relating to the ministry for examination, according to a Lok Sabha bulletin issued on October 28. The agenda also covers the functioning of Prasar Bharati, the film industry, OTT platforms, digital and social media, television rating mechanisms, and regulatory issues concerning the Pay-TV subscriber base, which has been shrinking amid viewers' migration to digital platforms and concerns over regulatory burdens. The proposed review comes amid the convergence of traditional broadcasting and digital platforms, raising questions about regulatory overlaps, accountability, and the enforcement of existing laws across media formats.

REGULATORY RESET

Review comes amid convergence of broadcast & digital platforms, raising questions over regulation and accountability

The idea of a common regulatory framework has figured in the committee's deliberations before. In its Eleventh Report on the ministry's Demands for Grants for 2025-26, presented in March 2025, the panel recommended that the government explore the feasibility of a comprehensive Media Bill and a Media Council covering print, broadcasting and digital media under one umbrella. It also suggested seeking inputs from related ministries and organisations, including the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), to improve coordination and implementation of laws.

The Press Council of India (PCI) has also supported the idea. In its 2021 annual report, the council recommended a single legislation covering newspapers, periodicals, e-newspapers, news portals, social media, television and radio, arguing that a mechanism parallel to the existing watchdog for print media was needed for the broader media landscape.

In its 28th Report, presented in August 2026, the committee highlighted the division of regulatory responsibilities between the Information and Broadcasting Ministry and MeitY. MIB administers Part III of the Information Technology Rules, 2021, covering digital news publishers and OTT platforms, while MeitY oversees intermediaries under Part II.

The report noted that the Bombay High Court had stayed Rule 9(1), concerning adherence to the Code of Ethics, and Rule 9(3), relating to the three-tier grievance redressal mechanism. The panel called for better coordination between the ministries and sought updates on proposed changes to the regulatory framework.

The committee will separately examine OTT platforms, digital and social media, and the mechanism for television rating points (TRPs).

Sebi to Delist Inactive Companies from Bourses, Tighten Penny Stock Oversight

Says companies with no economic activity pose dangers to investors; plans AI-based surveillance

Our Bureau

Kolkata: The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) will delist companies with no economic activity from stock exchanges to protect investors, particularly those investing in penny stocks.

"These companies pose a potential danger to investors, and therefore, it is necessary to remove them from the listed space. We are making efforts towards their delisting," Sebi chairman **Tuhin Kanta Pandey** said on Saturday in Kolkata.

Several companies with no economic activity remain listed, potentially creating scope for market manipulation.

Such firms could pose danger and should not continue to crowd the listed space, Pandey said. Investors with limited knowledge of the stock market tend to buy penny stocks because they are available at very low prices, often below ₹10 or ₹20. They risk losing money when prices correct.

According to an ET report published on November 1, as many as 10 penny stocks saw their prices fall by 35-70% over the past three months. The market regulator is planning to use an AI-based system to monitor companies with minimal economic activity and generate alerts faster, Pandey said. He also said Sebi is likely to issue its proposed consultation paper on compliance requirements for foreign institutional investors (FIIs) within weeks.

The regulator will also take a consultative approach towards capacity building for independent directors. The consultation paper on FIIs will seek views on aligning Indian norms with global standards. This comes amid large foreign capital outflows that have contributed to a persistent decline in stock indices. Foreign portfolio investors withdrew a net $31.4 billion from Indian equities in the first 10 months of the year, seeking higher returns in safe-haven assets amid rising US Treasury yields, the dollar's relative strength against other major currencies & geopolitical uncertainty.

Banks Seek Extension of Credit Guarantee Fund for Micro Loans

Lenders fear higher provisioning and risk costs if govt does not reopen scheme

Atmadip Ray

Kolkata: Banks have approached the government seeking an extension of the Credit Guarantee Fund for Micro Units (CGFMU) programme.

The scheme, designed to support collateral-free loans to micro enterprises, ended on March 31, 2026, creating uncertainty around risk pricing, capital provisioning and the outlook for unsecured lending to bottom-of-the-pyramid borrowers.

IDFC First Bank and small finance banks such as AU, Jana and Suryoday were among the biggest users of the scheme to reduce credit risk. They have set aside the guarantee fee for the current fiscal year, expecting the government to reopen the window soon, people aware of the matter said. Banks have expressed concerns that if fresh loans turn non-performing before the scheme is extended, they will have to make additional provisions to cover credit risks, the people cited above said. Without the guarantee cover, credit costs for unsecured loans remain elevated, analysts said.

IDFC First Bank reported a marginal increase in its microfinance portfolio during the quarter ended September 30 to ₹6,825 crore, with 97% of the book covered under the CGFMU scheme, chief financial officer Sudhanshu Jain said in a post-earnings analyst call.

AU Small Finance Bank said 99% of its microfinance portfolio was covered under the CGFMU guarantee scheme.

"All the new disbursements, we will continue putting under the guarantee programme," Jana Small Finance Bank managing director Ajay Kanwal told analysts. "The CGFMU programme is right now not open for fresh guarantees to be added to it. The scheme is going through an approval process. We expect that to get reopened soon. We have taken the 1% that is required to be put in the programme, and we've already accrued for it," he said. The CGFMU scheme helped lenders improve asset quality, particularly in the unsecured lending segment.

"We have witnessed a further improvement in asset quality during the quarter, with gross non-performing assets declining to 2.9% as of September 2026, compared with 6.5% in June 2026 and 5.9% in September 2025, after giving effect to the claims received from CGFMU," Suryoday Small Finance Bank managing director R Baskar Babu said.

Jana said 36% of its total portfolio was covered under government-backed guarantee schemes for micro units and micro, small and medium enterprises. The coverage could rise to 70-75% once the CGFMU window reopens. About 77% of its unsecured gross loan book was covered under guarantee programmes at the end of March. Ujjivan Small Finance Bank had around 9% of its microfinance portfolio covered under the CGFMU scheme at the end of September.

The government launched the CGFMU scheme in 2016 to encourage lenders to provide collateral-free microloans of up to ₹20 lakh and overdraft facilities of up to ₹10,000 under the Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana. The scheme also covers collateral-free loans of more than ₹10 lakh and up to ₹20 lakh extended to self-help groups.

Sports World Play

VITALS

INDIA IN NEW ZEALAND

My job is to take the right decisions, not the popular decisions. My job is not to make everyone happy. It is very easy to take the popular decision. The important thing is to take the right decision and make sure that there is a lot of security inside the dressing room

*India coach **Gautam Gambhir** before the 5th and final T20I against New Zealand. India lost the last game in Hamilton on Sunday but won the series 3-2, after being triumphant in the first three games*

BRIEF SCORES (5th T20I)
India 191/8 in 20 overs (Ishan Kishan 61, Shreyas Iyer 50; Adam Milne 4 for 19) lost to
New Zealand 192/2 in 17.1 overs (Tim Seifert 93, Glenn Phillips 65 not out) by seven wickets

Double Delight: Sindhu & Sen Win Hylo Open Titles

Saarbrucken (Germany): PV Sindhu and Lakshya Sen made it a double delight for India, claiming the women's and men's singles titles with straight-game victories in the finals of the Hylo Open Super 500 badminton tournament on Sunday. Sindhu displayed excellent control and precision in her strokeplay to register a commanding 21-12, 21-14 win over eighth seed and world No 25 Line Højmark Kjærsfeldt of Denmark in the 39-minute women's singles final. Later in the day, Lakshya outwitted Jonatan Christie 21-17, 21-10 in the men's singles final to complete a memorable double for India. **PTI**

BUNDESLIGA

What's Mr Ballon d'Or Up To?

Harry Kane misses a penalty in his first game after winning the coveted trophy

Ballon d'Or winner Harry Kane ran up to the penalty spot in his golden boots and ... missed.

Kane hit the crossbar instead of scoring as his first game as the holder of football's biggest individual award didn't quite live up to the pre-game hype. Perhaps nothing could.

By the time Bayern kicked off against Dortmund in the Klassiker, Kane had put on his special-edition boots with golden soles, been honoured in a pre-game ceremony on the field, and had a colossal Kane likeness projected onto the side of Munich's TV tower.

One of the quirks at Bayern is that a club sponsor arranges for a cluster of fans to wear white hooded ponchos and sit in the shape of its logo in the stands to create a living advertisement. on Saturday they were shimmering in gold, too.

Kane spoke before the game of being "extremely proud to be a Bayern Munich player" and thanked the fans. But a frustrating evening ensued as a 2-2 draw kept Bayern and Dortmund level on points at the top of the Bundesliga.

He did everything but score.

Kane's sheer number of goals — 73 for club and country last season — was a big factor in Kane becoming the first Bayern player to win the Ballon d'Or in 45 years and the first English winner in 25 years.

Even though he didn't score on Saturday, he offered glimpses of how he's evolved into a more creative, all-round attacking threat for Bayern, too. Kane found space to meet a cross from deep and met it with a cushioned header that gave Dayot Upamecano an easy job of scoring Bayern's second goal. **AP**

IN NUMBERS

73 Goals scored last season for country and club to bag the top award

45 yrs The last time a player from Bayern Munich, and **25 yrs** since one from England won

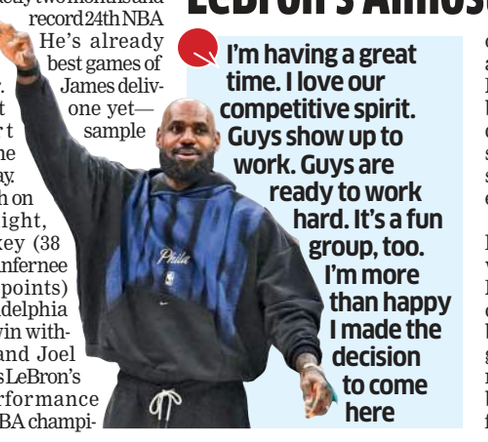
Mbappe Scores in Real Win

Kylian Mbappe moved on from a tumultuous week by scoring a penalty to help Real Madrid win 3-0 at Racing Santander on Sunday. The French forward lost out on the Ballon d'Or on Monday and then had to apologise after a social media storm following a video in which he joked about former Chinese leader Mao Zedong. **AFP**

LeBron's Almost 42, & Feeling Young in Philly

Philadelphia: LeBron James turns 42 in exactly two months and is in his record 24th NBA season. He's already played his best games of his career. James delivered his best one yet—in a short sample size—with the 76ers on Friday.

Even though on Saturday night, Tyrese Maxey (38 points) and Anfernee Simons (19 points) proved Philadelphia 76ers could win without James and Joel Embiid, it was LeBron's vintage performance against the NBA champions Knicks, that is being talked about. He bullied his way past Mikal Bridges in the post for a bucket in the first half and chased down OG Anunoby for a blocked shot in the third quarter, plays that served as early hints he still has elite game when needed most.



I'm having a great time. I love our competitive spirit. Guys show up to work. Guys are ready to work hard. It's a fun group, too. I'm more than happy I made the decision to come here

After the Sixers let a 14-pointt lead slip away in the fourth, it was James—not Embiid or Maxey—who closed out the champs. James then capped his best game of the season with the go-ahead bucket with 1:10 remaining and V.J Edgecombe buried an insurance 3-pointer for the four-pt lead. James sealed the 98-93 win in an NBA Cup group tie with a tip-in and nearly pulled off a triple-double with nine rebounds and eight assists.

There aren't many meaningful personal statistics for James to chase but a fifth NBA championship with his fourth team would be one for the record books.

"I'm having a great time," James said. "I love what we're bringing to the table every night. I love our competitive spirit. Guys show up to work. Guys are ready to work hard. It's a fun group, too. I'm like a big-ass kid, to be completely honest," he said. **AP**